

Principles of Faith - Foundations for Modern Believers

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Use of AI

Portions of this book were developed with the assistance of artificial intelligence tools to aid in drafting, organizing, and editing content. All theological interpretations and doctrinal statements have been carefully reviewed, refined, and approved by the author to ensure alignment with the intended message and purpose of this work. The use of AI in this process reflects a desire to present material clearly and effectively while maintaining the highest standards of biblical integrity.

Dedication

To my beloved wife, Jessica,
whose unwavering love and faith inspire me daily.

To my son, Zachariah,
whose name is a reminder that “The Lord has remembered us,” a living testament to God’s faithfulness and grace.

Acknowledgements

I would like to express my heartfelt gratitude to my wife **Jessica Nieuwsma** for helping me edit this book and to **Rev. Larry Low & Rev. Andy Spurlin** for taking the time to review this book. Your thoughtful insights and careful attention to detail have been an incredible blessing throughout this process.

I am also deeply thankful to the **Kingsway Fellowship Staff-Dr. Ron Breese** and **Rev. Beth Loomis**-for their invaluable feedback and assistance. Your wisdom, encouragement, and support have strengthened this work in ways I could not have achieved alone.

Thank you all for your dedication to excellence and for helping me bring this book to completion. Your contributions have made a lasting impact, and I am truly grateful.

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Foreword

For things to function effectively, a solid system and structure are essential. Without them, dysfunction and chaos can easily arise. This is why establishing a strong foundation in doctrine is crucial for fully living as a healthy Christian.

That’s why “*Principles of Faith*” will serve as a powerful resource for believers. From the very first chapter, which addresses the importance of sound doctrine, to the rest of the over 300 pages filled with teachings and activities about the church and our roles within it, as well as understanding and recognizing God’s voice, this book is invaluable. It will be an exceptional tool in the classroom for teaching and preparing leaders with a solid foundation in doctrine, while also being highly beneficial for individual readers.

Andrew has been an integral part of my inner circle for many years, and I continue to be impressed by his talents and his approach to understanding kingdom matters. He possesses a genuine passion for ensuring that the church operates as a healthy representation of Christ on Earth. I take great pride in the work he has accomplished with this book, and having collaborated with Him for a significant time, I can confidently attest that he has invested considerable time and thought into this process, just as he does with everything in his life.

Evangelist Robert Newton

Founder and President of Powerhouse Ministries

Preface

Building a Foundation that Lasts

I have always had a fascination with questions. Why is *something* true? What made it that way? How do we know? How are we sure? If *something* is true, what else is true? What is false? This fascination goes beyond a desire to be correct on a surface level, but to know deeply and precisely, and to be able to clearly articulate the new gained understanding.

While communication is common, effective and precise communication is challenging. To effectively communicate a message the author and originator must have an idea. However, the idea alone like water on a hard surface-its edges and boundaries are poorly defined, fluid, and easily moved around.

We use words, terms, and phrases to transform the raw idea from vaguely shaped to precisely shaped. Words give our idea a boundary, they help us distinguish and separate between what the idea is, and what it is not. Now our shaped idea must be transmitted and received through some medium. Whether in long form text, like this book, or short form text, like a social media post, or in oral form, like a conversation or a video recording, the medium transmits the now well-formed idea to the recipient.

So far, we've only discussed the originator and author of the idea. For an idea to be useful, the recipient must receive, decode, and understand the message accurately. The transmitted and received messages should align closely.

Every great human work is the by-product of effective communication. One man's labor can only accomplish so much. To really build or perform something great, many men (speaking here generically of mankind) must labor together in a shared purpose, with a shared idea. Barring naturally occurring disasters (like a volcanic eruption) we also know that the greatest calamities to ever occur usually did so in significant part because of missing, broken or distorted communication. Truly life and death are in the power of the tongue (Proverbs 18:21).

What we believe and how we communicate it has the power to build a person, a family, a community, a nation, or has the power to equally destroy them. What we believe is the foundation for our actions and is the blueprint for what we will do, who we will be, how we will exist. Because belief is expressed through action and communication, it defines the role we play in existence. Our beliefs shape not just our lives, but to a degree the lives of everyone around us.

We must establish our beliefs accurately and learn to share them effectively. Jesus said as much when he said to His disciples:

Matthew 28:18-20 (NKJV)

And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, “All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth.

Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,

teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.” Amen.

Many Christians today desire a stronger faith but lack a clear foundation to build upon. Without solid doctrine, we lack the firm foundation we need to stand strong; we risk being swayed by false teaching, discouraged in trials, or unprepared for the work God has called us to do. This book is designed to equip you with the foundational teachings of Scripture-truths that strengthen your faith, deepen your walk with Christ, and empower you to live a Spirit-filled life.

The Apostle Paul urged believers to be “*rooted and built up in Him and established in the faith*” (Colossians 2:7). To grow into mature, Spirit-led believers, we must first have deep roots in God’s truth. This is why doctrine matters. It is more than information; it is the framework that shapes how we live and respond to God.

Why This Book, Who Is it For?

The teachings in this book are meant to educate and encourage you, the reader, in the foundational doctrines of the New Testament church. It is my hope that these beliefs will convince and inspire your walk of faith to plant deep roots in Christ and to come to know Him personally.

These teachings are framed and shaped by my experience in the church, particularly in Charismatic or Pentecostal manifestations. The composition of the teachings in this book builds upon my own personal study of the scripture, formal and informal education, and from my experience in close to twenty years involvement in ministry, much of that time being an ordained minister. My background includes youth and children’s ministry, evangelistic outreach and revival ministry, discipleship, pastoral counseling, and church and ministry administration.

This book serves believers seeking to strengthen their faith or disciple others in their spiritual growth. Specifically:

- **New Believers** - Those who need a clear foundation to start their Christian journey.
- **Growing Christians** - Those seeking to deepen their understanding of God and Scripture while walking in greater obedience and faith.
- **Teachers, Mentors, and Small Group Leaders** - Those preparing to disciple others, whether one-on-one, in small groups, or from the pulpit.

Each chapter is designed to equip believers both **personally** and **practically**, making it ideal for personal growth as well as group teaching. Whether you're using this book to strengthen your own walk with God or to train others, the content is structured for easy application and Spirit-led growth.

How to Use This Book

The chapters follow a logical progression, beginning with foundational truths like **God, sin, repentance, and faith**, and moving into the deeper work of the **Holy Spirit, discipleship, and spiritual authority**. Each topic stands alone but also builds upon the previous chapters, making it easy to work through step-by-step or focus on specific areas as needed.

For **individuals**, this book serves as a guide to understanding and applying Scripture. For **teachers**, it provides material to prepare lessons, lead discussions, and disciple others effectively. Personal reflection questions, group discussion questions for facilitation, group activities, and word studies are included to help deepen understanding and encourage practical steps of obedience.

How will we study?

We have been given a primary source for sound doctrine, the teachings of the Holy Spirit, inspired and recorded in scripture, passed down through the teachings and tradition of the church. This book will take essential teachings, present them in easy-to-understand format and conclude each chapter with a personal reflection, group facilitation questions, and optional group activities.

Let's explore each element in a bit more depth:

The Holy Spirit

John 16:13-14 (NKJV)

However, when He, the Spirit of truth, has come, He will guide you into all truth; for He will not speak on His own authority, but whatever He hears He will speak; and He will tell you things to come.

He will glorify Me, for He will take of what is Mine and declare it to you.

God, through the Holy Spirit, inspired all recorded Scripture, but God's work is not done! When we read and study Scripture the same Holy Spirit that authored it, illuminates our study, and makes our understanding! The Holy Spirit is our comforter and helper, and His role is unchanged today. He helps us understand the scriptures and walk in truth with Him.

The Scriptures

2 Timothy 3:16 (NKJV)

All Scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness,

The collection of scriptures we have today reflects the written words of God. God, by His Spirit, inspired select men and revealed to them His words. In the earliest period, before Moses, not much was formally written down; instead, oral tradition preserved much of God's interactions with humanity over centuries. The scriptures state that God used Moses to write the Torah (the first five books of the Old Testament), marking the beginning of a more formal written record of God's instructions and covenant with His people.

Exodus 24:4 (NKJV)

And Moses wrote all the words of the LORD. And he rose early in the morning, and built an altar at the foot of the mountain, and twelve pillars according to the twelve tribes of Israel.

Numbers 33:2 (NKJV)

Now Moses wrote down the starting points of their journeys at the command of the LORD. And these are their journeys according to their starting points:

Deuteronomy 31:9,11 (NKJV)

So Moses wrote this law and delivered it to the priests, the sons of Levi, who bore the ark of the covenant of the LORD, and to all the elders of Israel.

when all Israel comes to appear before the LORD your God in the place which He chooses, you shall read this law before all Israel in their hearing.

As history continued, God maintained His relationship with His people, and various prophets, leaders, and scribes recorded these interactions and teachings. This process resulted in what we now recognize as the Old Testament.

Isaiah 30:8 (NKJV)

Now go, write it before them on a tablet, And note it on a scroll, That it may be for time to come, Forever and ever:

Jeremiah 36:2 (NKJV)

“Take a scroll of a book and write on it all the words that I have spoken to you against Israel, against Judah, and against all the nations, from the day I spoke to you, from the days of Josiah even to this day.

Habakkuk 2:2 (NKJV)

Then the LORD answered me and said: “Write the vision And make it plain on tablets, That he may run who reads it.

Following the ministry of Jesus, numerous eyewitnesses and apostles documented accounts of His life, ministry, death, and resurrection. They also wrote letters, or epistles, that addressed doctrinal and practical matters within the early Christian communities. These writings, divinely inspired, were carefully recorded, compiled, and preserved through the centuries, forming what is now known as the Bible.

Generally, we will use the NKJV translation but also may use a different translation where it makes the passage clearer. *Scripture references will be italicized to aid in reading.*

I strongly suggest using multiple translations whenever possible, to ensure the concept is clearly understood in your mind. I personally find translations like the Amplified bible to be of benefit, not for its pure textual accuracy, but to help me understand in plain English what the scriptures are communicating.

We’ll take time to explore certain key Bible words (**word studies**) so we can better understand what God is saying and how it applies to our lives. I recommend learning to use electronic bible resources like: E-Sword (<<https://www.e-sword.net>>), or the Blue Letter Bible (<https://www.blueletterbible.org/>). Such resources will also give you access to a Strong’s Concordance.

Strong's Concordance helps us understand what the Bible meant in its original language, so we can hear more clearly what God is saying. The Old Testament (sometimes abbreviated OT in this book) was authored in Hebrew. The New Testament (sometimes abbreviated NT in this book) was authored in Greek. The Strong's number will be indicated: **Hxxx** (Hebrew) or **Gyyy** (Greek).

The Teachings of the Church

Matthew 28:20 (NKJV)

teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age." Amen.

The teachings I present in this book are not new or novel. We should be skeptical of 'new' never-before-seen-or-heard teachings regarding our Christian faith. Rather this book is a compilation and explanation of teachings that have been present since the beginning.

This book is not a study of church history, nor is it a comparison on Christian denominations. Pick up any two books on theology written by different authors with divergent denominational backgrounds and while you will see great harmony in much of their work, you will see notable division. I will not claim inerrancy, but I will claim that this work is well studied, peer reviewed by faithful men and women (see Acknowledgements section), and well supported by the scriptures and by well accepted Pentecostal tradition.

I implore you to read the scriptures for yourself and commit to their mastery. God's Word promises that when we seek Him, we will find Him (Jeremiah 29:13). I invite you to approach this book with faith and expectation. As you walk through these teachings, I pray you'll not only grow in understanding but also experience the power of the Holy Spirit working in and through you. My hope is that you will be restored, strengthened, and empowered to fulfill God's purpose in your life.

Chapter 1 - Sound Doctrine Matters

Doctrine simply means the core truths we believe and teach-truths passed on by faithful people of God, rooted in Scripture, and lived out in our daily walk.

When Jesus instructed His church to 'teach', He was instructing them to share His doctrine.

Matthew 28:18-20 (NKJV)

And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, "All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth.

Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,

teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.” Amen.

In other words, Jesus is instructing all of us to learn His teachings and to replicate them in others.

The New Testament uses several related Greek terms for concepts like doctrine, teaching, disciple, and commandment.

Table 1 - Word Study: Doctrine, Disciple, Commandment

High-Level Meaning	Greek	References
	Didaskalia	
Doctrine, teaching	dee-das-KA-lee-a G1319	1 Timothy 4:13, TIT 2:1, 2 Timothy 4:3
	mathētēs	
Disciple, learner	ma-THAY-ta-ce G3101	Matthew 10:24, John 8:31, Luke 14:26
	Entolē	
Commandment, instruction	en-to-LAY G1785	Matthew 22:36-38, John 13:34, 1 John 5:3
	logos	
Word, message, teaching	LOH-gos G3056	John 1:1, Hebrews 4:12, Matthew 7:24

Jesus is the Way, the Truth, and the Life (John 14:6), fully embodying God's truth, wisdom, and revelation. This embodiment, the Word (logos), existed from the beginning and became flesh to dwell among us (John 1:1, 14). The structured teachings of Jesus is His doctrine (**didaskalia**), in observing (obeying, guarding, protecting) His commands (**entolē**) we become His disciples (**mathētēs**).

Imagine a master architect, the greatest builder in all history, whose vision, knowledge, and wisdom surpass all others. He alone understands the perfect design for an enduring, unshakable structure. His understanding is not derived from others-it is inherent within Him. He is the source of all architectural wisdom, and every sound building finds its origin in His design. This architect represents Jesus, the Logos-the full and complete embodiment of God's truth, wisdom, and revelation (John 1:1, John 14:6).

To bring His design to life, the architect creates a **detailed blueprint**-a structured plan that contains the principles, proportions, and foundational truths necessary for constructing a building that will stand firm. Without this blueprint, no one could build correctly. This blueprint represents Jesus' structured teaching, His doctrine (**didaskalia**) — the framework through which divine truth is understood and applied (Titus 2:1, 1 Timothy 4:13). His doctrine is not merely theoretical knowledge; it is the means by which His wisdom is communicated and preserved so that all who follow Him can build their lives on the right foundation.

However, a blueprint alone is not enough. The architect also provides **precise instructions**, detailing how each part of the structure should be assembled, where each beam must be placed, and how every element should align with His perfect design. These specific instructions represent His commands (**Entolē**)-the actionable directives that govern obedience (John 14:15, Matthew 28:20). His commands are not arbitrary rules; they are the necessary steps to ensure the building stands strong, aligned with the original blueprint. To ignore or alter His commands would be to compromise the integrity of the entire structure.

Now, imagine that the architect gathers a group of **apprentices**-those who desire to learn from Him, build under His guidance, and one day teach others how to construct buildings that endure. These apprentices study His blueprint carefully, listen to His instructions attentively, and apply His commands faithfully in their work. They do not build according to their own ideas but according to the master's design. These apprentices represent the disciples (**Mathētēs**)-those who observe, obey, and internalize Jesus' teachings, aligning their lives with His Word (Matthew 28:19-20, John 8:31). The more they study under the architect, the more skilled they become, eventually teaching and training others in His ways.

Why Should We Study Doctrine?

Jesus' teaching is the bedrock of our faith! He is the master architect who has a perfect design and blueprint. Only by studying the blueprints, obeying the architect's specific instructions, and developing a strong working relationship can we build a life that will stand in the storms of life.

Psalms 127:1 (NKJV)

A Song of Ascents. Of Solomon. Unless the LORD builds the house, They labor in vain who build it; Unless the LORD guards the city, The watchman stays awake in vain.

We cannot expect our lives to stand strong in the face of difficulties, challenges, tribulations, persecutions, or just ordinary life if we have not built our lives on the strong rock of faith.

It takes more than a gym membership to make a person healthy and physically fit. You must continue in the discipline of the gym to get the full benefits of membership. Likewise, we cannot merely attend a church or casually claim to be Christians, we all must become educated, trained, equipped, disciplined in the faith, only then will we realize the full benefits of membership!

Jesus' charge extends beyond us. It's great that we become whole, healthy, disciplined, submitted to God, but we must teach, train, equip, lead, and disciple others into the faith as well!

Why should we study doctrine and become disciplined? To build our lives on the rock!

However, this is more than just a benefit, it also stands as a warning to us. If we do not build our lives on the rock, we build our lives on the sand, and a strong storm will break our house. (Matthew 7:24-27).

Our beliefs dictate our actions and our destiny. Proverbs teaches us that as a man thinks, so is he! (Proverbs 23:7). We don't get to stay neutral-we're all building on something. Jesus calls us to build on the rock so we can stand strong and walk in His salvation. The promise of truth and freedom is for us!

John 8:31-32 (NKJV)

Then Jesus said to those Jews who believed Him, "If you abide in My word, you are My disciples indeed.

And you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free."

Being Jesus' disciple is only possible by continuing in His word (his logos)! The result of continuing in His word is our knowledge of the truth, which makes us free!

Disciples, having been taught discipline, can carry out the master's commandments. Every person in the New Testament church is called to:

1. Be a disciple -> subject ourselves to the discipline of sound doctrine.
1. Make disciples -> teach others to be subject to the discipline of sound doctrine.

How Do We Go About Building Our Lives On the Rock?

Don't worry, we do not have to go this alone.

1. God has given us His Holy Spirit who will lead us and guide us into all truth (John 14).
1. God has given us His recorded words in the scriptures.
1. God has given us spiritually mature gifted leaders to help build us up, make us mature, keep us safe, and organize us into doing good work.

Christianity is a team sport, and we have a perfect coach who knows exactly what we need. He has given us specialists who know through experience how to help us grow and mature, and in time you too can be one of them!

Ephesians 4:11-16 (NKJV)

And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers,

for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ,

till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ;

that we should no longer be children, tossed to and fro and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the trickery of men, in the cunning craftiness of deceitful plotting,

but, speaking the truth in love, may grow up in all things into Him who is the head—Christ—

from whom the whole body, joined and knit together by what every joint supplies, according to the effective working by which every part does its share, causes growth of the body for the edifying of itself in love.

An important note: the word ‘some’ indicates that not all of us are called with a gift of apostle, prophet, evangelist, pastor, or teacher but we are all given ministry gifts, talents, and special roles (discussed later in the chapter on the church).

God has given the church these special gifts to bring us to maturity, so we can and are:

- Able to do work and bear fruit
- Unified in the faith
- Full of the knowledge of God
- Mature
- Not like children

Without sound doctrine we will be children, tossed about and carried off.

Children are an important part of the family of God, but children are inherently:

- Immature - unable to bear fruit or reproduce.
- Naive - unable to discern between good and bad actors.
- Self-centered - concerned with the temporal and the now.
- Defenseless - vulnerable to harm.

Sound doctrine Provides a Defense Against the Wickedness of the World

We do not have the luxury of being spiritually neutral in this life. We are either influenced by the Kingdom of God, or the Kingdom of Darkness.

Paul charged his spiritual son in the Lord Timothy saying:

2 Timothy 4:1-4 (NKJV)

I charge you therefore before God and the Lord Jesus Christ, who will judge the living and the dead at His appearing and His kingdom:

Preach the word! Be ready in season and out of season. Convince, rebuke, exhort, with all longsuffering and teaching.

For the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine, but according to their own desires, because they have itching ears, they will heap up for themselves teachers;

and they will turn their ears away from the truth, and be turned aside to fables.

Timothy, an aspiring leader in the church, was instructed to have a great depth of doctrinal understanding. Paul warns Timothy that there is a time coming when men will not endure sound doctrine and will fall away! Paul in the previous chapter of his letter to Timothy clarifies the nature and character of these men who will not endure sound doctrine:

2 Timothy 3:1-9 (NKJV)

But know this, that in the last days perilous times will come:

For men will be lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boasters, proud, blasphemers, disobedient to parents, unthankful, unholy,

unloving, unforgiving, slanderers, without self-control, brutal, despisers of good,

traitors, headstrong, haughty, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God,

having a form of godliness but denying its power. And from such people turn away!

For of this sort are those who creep into households and make captives of gullible women loaded down with sins, led away by various lusts,

always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth.

Now as Jannes and Jambres resisted Moses, so do these also resist the truth: men of corrupt minds, disapproved concerning the faith;

but they will progress no further, for their folly will be manifest to all, as theirs also was.

The crux of this message is that perilous times will come. Men will be so self-absorbed that despite all their 'teaching' they will not submit to sound doctrine, will deny the power of God, and will walk with a corrupt and reprobate mind. Paul urges Timothy to be well prepared to preach sound doctrine.

As disciples we study and subject ourselves to the discipline of sound doctrine, this provides a defense against the wickedness of the world, we become full grown mature men and women of God, able to defend ourselves against the

snare of the enemy and able to protect those around us that have not yet come to full maturity.

We must be careful and diligent in our study, sound teaching of the scriptures can be led astray by several perverse influences.

Sound doctrine can become twisted by the traditions of men. We see this truth evident from the need of the great reformers of Protestantism and in the history of the Old Testament. God raised men up to restore the fundamental truth that had become perverted by the traditions of men.

The scriptures warn us:

Colossians 2:8 (NKJV)

Beware lest anyone cheat you through philosophy and empty deceit, according to the tradition of men, according to the basic principles of the world, and not according to Christ.

Mark 7:9,13 (NKJV)

He said to them, "All too well you reject the commandment of God, that you may keep your tradition.

making the word of God of no effect through your tradition which you have handed down. And many such things you do."

Men can twist sound doctrine through private interpretation. This is sadly clearly visible in the countless death cults and false messiahs that have come in each generation. These evil and corrupt leaders all claim to be God's special representative with God's special knowledge and refuse to submit themselves to the authority of Jesus and the boundaries set in the scriptures. The Spirit warns us:

2 Peter 1:20-21 (NKJV)

knowing this first, that no prophecy of Scripture is of any private interpretation,

for prophecy never came by the will of man, but holy men of God spoke as they were moved by the Holy Spirit.

All truth and revelation are from the Spirit of Truth. God's Spirit is not the author of confusion, so no teaching or revelation is to violate the scriptures that have been given us, inspired, and authored by the Holy Spirit.

In both cases, whether through group tradition or private interpretation we know that the spirit at work to deceive the church is the devil:

1 Timothy 4:1 (NKJV)

Now the Spirit expressly says that in latter times some will depart from the faith, giving heed to deceiving spirits and doctrines of demons,

Just like a parent must protect their children, mature disciples protect the immature in the faith from the destruction in this world. The end result of this maturity is our ability to bear much fruit!

John 15:8 (NKJV)

By this My Father is glorified, that you bear much fruit; so you will be My disciples.

What are His doctrines, what will we study?

In this work we will primarily study foundational doctrines of the New Testament church. These doctrines are foundational in that scriptures refer to them as such, but more so because they provide a strong foundation for the learner to build their life upon.

Hebrews 6:1-2 (NKJV)

Therefore, leaving the discussion of the elementary principles of Christ, let us go on to perfection, not laying again the foundation of repentance from dead works and of faith toward God,

of the doctrine of baptisms, of laying on of hands, of resurrection of the dead, and of eternal judgment.

The core doctrines we will study are:

1. Principle doctrines of the Christ (the Anointed One)
 1. Repentance from dead works
 1. Faith towards God
 1. Doctrine of baptisms
 1. Laying on of hands
 1. Resurrection of the dead
 1. Eternal judgment

We will also study core elements of our Christian walk:

- Sanctification by the Holy Spirit
- The Church and our role in it
- Making disciples
- Spiritual authority

We will study each of these in the context of the church, and study them so we can ‘go onto perfection (maturity)’. Our study will focus on the various perspectives and aspects of the Godhead as revealed to us: God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Why does sound doctrine matter in your personal walk with God?
1. What does it mean to be “rooted and built up in Him” (Colossians 2:7)? How does doctrine help with this?
1. How do false teachings affect believers, and how can sound doctrine protect against this?
1. How has your understanding of doctrine changed through this study?
1. Who in your life could benefit from learning these foundational teachings, and how can you begin discipling them?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 minutes)

1. **Opening Question (Icebreaker)** - *“What is one teaching or belief that had a major impact on your faith journey?”*
1. **Digging Deeper** - *“How does doctrine shape not only what we believe, but how we live?”*
1. **Practical Application** - *“What steps can we take to ensure we’re growing in sound doctrine while guarding against false teaching?”*

Chapter 2 - God-Eternal Creator and Loving Father

It is crucial that we establish a firm foundation in the knowledge of who God is. We can come to understand by studying:

- His desires, intents, and actions,
- His nature, character, and attributes,
- What is said of Him and what He says of Himself.

Scripture reveals God's characteristics uniquely, with each facet deepening our understanding of the unchanging, eternal God.

Summarizing God in one descriptor is challenging, if not impossible, as He is too vast and multifaceted for simplification. While we can, and will, make great efforts to explain, describe, and depict God, ultimately like art and music, He must be experienced to be understood.

When a person listens to music, they describe it by expressing how it moves them-how it resonates within, beyond just the notes and rhythms. A melody might carry warmth or intensity, with a rhythm that pulses like a heartbeat or crescendos that create a sense of exhilaration or longing. Music can soothe like a gentle wave or electrify like a storm, lifting the listener's spirits, grounding their thoughts, or transporting them to another place entirely. This experience is far more than the sequence of sounds; it is the soul of the music that lingers, captured in how it shapes the listener's emotions and personal journey.

Similarly, a viewer of a painting looks beyond the colors or brushstrokes, exploring what these elements embody. A landscape might evoke a serene escape, while an abstract piece can stir curiosity or introspection. Certain shades can bring warmth, while a composition may create a sense of calm, chaos, or beauty. The painting becomes a living experience, provoking a shift in perspective or a deep emotional reaction that words alone can't capture. Both music and art, then, transform into more than their physical forms-they become encounters that touch something essential, changing the listener or viewer in profound and personal ways.

Exploring God Through the Old Testament

Genesis: The God Who Dwells With His Creation

A central theme in the narrative of God is His **desire to dwell** with His creation. This is clear in the stories throughout Genesis. Across its fifty chapters and genealogies from Adam (the first man) through Joseph (that last major figure in the book of Genesis, the last significant leader of God's people before Moses), there is a period of approximately ~2,400 years. We can see through these stories the consistency of God's goodness despite man's wickedness.

In Genesis, God establishes relationship with select individuals.

1. **Adam and Eve** - The first humans, created by God and placed in the Garden of Eden. God walks and talks with them, giving them instructions and establishing a relationship of mutual love and obedience. However, this relationship is impacted by their disobedience in eating from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil (Genesis 1-3).
1. **Cain** - Although Cain ultimately rebels by murdering his brother Abel, God speaks directly to him, warning him about the danger of sin and offering him guidance before the murder. Even after Cain's punishment, God marks him to protect him from harm (Genesis 4).
1. **Noah** - God establishes a unique relationship with Noah, a righteous man, in a time of widespread corruption. God commands Noah to build an ark to save his family and the animals from the Flood. Afterward, God makes a covenant with Noah, promising never again to destroy the earth with a flood and establishing the rainbow as a sign of this covenant (Genesis 6-9).
1. **Abraham (Abram)** - One of the most significant relationships in Genesis, God calls Abram to leave his homeland and promises to make him the father of a great nation. God establishes a covenant with Abram, promising land, descendants, and blessings for all nations through him. Abram's faith and obedience become central themes, and his name is changed to Abraham as part of the covenant (Genesis 12, 15, 17, 22).
1. **Hagar** - An Egyptian servant of Sarah, Hagar encounters God in the wilderness after being mistreated. God comforts her, promises her a future for her son Ishmael, and instructs her to return to Abraham and Sarah. Hagar refers to God as "El Roi" ("The God Who Sees Me"), recognizing His care for her (Genesis 16).
1. **Isaac** - The son of Abraham and Sarah, Isaac inherits the covenant promises made to his father. God reaffirms these promises directly to Isaac, including the promise of descendants and blessings. God also guides Isaac during a

famine, protecting him and establishing the covenant relationship (Genesis 26).

1. **Rebekah** - Although her relationship with God is indirect, God answers Rebekah's prayer about her difficult pregnancy, revealing that her twins, Jacob and Esau, will become two nations with distinct destinies (Genesis 25).
1. **Jacob** - God establishes a personal relationship with Jacob, appearing to him in a dream and confirming the covenant promises of land, descendants, and blessings. Jacob encounters God several times, including the famous wrestling match where God changes his name to Israel, symbolizing his transformation and the establishment of Israel as a people (Genesis 28, 32, 35).
1. **Joseph** - Although Joseph's relationship with God isn't based on direct appearances or covenants like those of Abraham or Jacob, God is deeply involved in his life. Through dreams, divine favor, and providence, God guides Joseph's journey from being sold into slavery to becoming a powerful leader in Egypt. Joseph's faith in God's sovereignty allows him to forgive his brothers, recognizing that God used his suffering for good (Genesis 37, 39-50).

Throughout this narrative God, who wants to dwell with His creation, has to settle for dwelling with select individuals, and ultimately through covenant with Abraham establishes a people (Genesis 17:7).

Exodus: The God Who Dwells With His People

God's desire to dwell with His people is also clearly seen in the second book of the Bible, Exodus. In the book of the exodus the people of Israel, who had lived for a period of time in relative peace and harmony in Egypt, are now being oppressed by a Pharaoh who did not know of Joseph and feared the Hebrews (Exodus 1:6-8). God's people lived in Egypt for roughly ~400 years (Exodus 12:40-41), of which the later portion of that was spent living as slaves (there is not a universal consensus on precisely how long Israel was in bondage to Egypt).

In the powerful presence of the burning bush that was not consumed, God reveals Himself to a Hebrew-born, Egyptian-raised, murderer in exile, who is tending to his father-in-law's flock in the desert, Moses.

Exodus 3:14 (NKJV)

And God said to Moses, "I AM WHO I AM." And He said, "Thus you shall say to the children of Israel, 'I AM has sent me to you.'"

The phrase “**I AM THAT I AM**” (Ehyeh-Asher-Ehyeh) is one of the most profound self-revelations in Scripture. When Moses asks for God’s name, God responds with this phrase, which can be translated as “I Am Who I Am,” “I Will Be Who I Will Be,” or simply “I Am.” This declaration on the surface is a bit confusing but holds deep meaning. Could you imagine introducing yourself to someone new as ‘I am’? When God reveals Himself as ‘I AM THAT I AM’ He is attesting to His nature, His eternal presence, His sovereignty. ‘I am’ is infinite in meaning and purpose.

God uses Moses to reveal Himself to Pharaoh:

Exodus 7:16 (NKJV)

And you shall say to him, ‘The LORD God of the Hebrews has sent me to you, saying, “Let My people go, that they may serve Me in the wilderness”; but indeed, until now you would not hear!’

Moses tells Pharaoh, God is the ‘I AM’ and that God demands the Israelites be released so that they may worship Him in the wilderness.

Plagues and misery ensue, but ultimately Pharaoh relents and lets the Israelites leave.

Exodus 12:31 (NKJV)

Then he called for Moses and Aaron by night, and said, “Rise, go out from among my people, both you and the children of Israel. And go, serve the LORD as you have said.

In the wilderness God miraculously delivers His people from the vengeful Egyptian army (Exodus 14), provides protection from the sun and a pillar of fire to keep them warm in the cool night of the desert (Exodus 13), food from heaven (Exodus 16), and water to drink (Exodus 17).

God brings His people to Mount Sinai where God commands Moses to consecrate the people and gives them the law (including the 10 commandments) and establishes His covenant with them (the old covenant) (Exodus 19, 20, 24). This covenant (the Mosaic covenant) builds upon the Abrahamic covenant and lasts from Moses to Jesus.

Despite building a covenant with His people, the relationship is one of a loving and jealous God pursuing and abiding with very stubborn and ungrateful people (Exodus 32:9). Ignoring God’s miraculous intervention, they keep a rebellious attitude for large parts of the text. God even brings them to the promised land and tells them they can inherit it (Exodus 33:3), but in fear and disobedience they ignore the supernatural deliverance that God has given them, and instead must wander the desert for 40 years until almost everyone from that generation had died (Numbers 14:33-34).

The Rest of the Old Testament

In the ~1,400 years between the death of Moses and the birth of Christ the Israelites experienced a recurring cycle of devotion which brings God's favor and blessings, followed by rebellion, God's judgment, their subsequent repentance, and ultimately God's deliverance. This pattern is particularly evident in the books of **Judges, Kings, and Chronicles**, which recount cycles where the people turn away from God, often by worshiping other gods, resulting in periods of oppression or exile. In response to their cries, God repeatedly raised up judges, prophets, or leaders to deliver them.

Throughout these years, despite the Israelites' frequent failures to uphold their covenant with Him, God remains faithful, showing both justice and mercy. He continuously rescues and forgives His people, demonstrating His enduring commitment and love.

As we see in Scripture, God reveals Himself through actions, relationships, and even names that speak to His character. Each name represents a specific aspect of His total character. These names were given as part of a narrative of how God revealed Himself to His people. For your personal study a reference table is included in the Appendix: *Table 10 - Old Testament Names of God*. Read through these names and study the scripture references. Each reference is a story that depicts precisely how God saved, delivered, and rescued His people.

Also included in the Appendix is a further derived set of attributes describing His nature, descriptions of His actions and intents: *Table 11 - Attributes of God*. These attributes, while slightly more abstract than the names of God, are no less authentic!

These names help us understand God-Father, Son, and Holy Spirit (the **Trinity**)-working together as one. In our continued study we will examine names and attributes of Jesus and the Holy Spirit in more depth.

God's character and actions are fully expressed in the unity of Father, Son, and Spirit. The scriptures teach that God is one in essence, yet exists as three distinct persons: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Scripture affirms God's oneness, stating, "beside Him there is no God" (Isaiah 45:5). However, the Godhead is understood as a **compound unity**-three distinct persons who cooperate with a singular mind and purpose, united in the truest sense. Each person of the Trinity has a unique role: the **Father creates**, the **Son redeems**, and the **Holy Spirit sanctifies**. The term "Trinity" does not appear in the Bible; it was developed as a theological expression to describe this concept, which is revealed through Scripture.

The Trinity can be illustrated by examples in nature, which help clarify this idea of unity in diversity. Like water, which can be liquid, ice, or vapor but remains

H₂O, each person of the Trinity is fully God yet distinct in personhood. Or consider a triangle, with three sides and three angles, forming one complete shape; if one side is removed, it ceases to be a triangle. Similarly, **God's nature is incomplete without all three persons**, who work together in perfect unity.

- **God the Father:** He is the creator and sustainer of all things, often understood as the initiator in the Godhead. His love for humanity is central to the biblical story, exemplified in John 3:16. In our study we will examine God the father as the loving father and righteous judge, who made a path for our redemption.
- **God the Son:** Co-existent and co-eternal with the Father, Jesus took on human nature, being conceived by the Holy Spirit and born of the virgin Mary. He lived a sinless life, died to redeem humanity, and rose again, defeating sin and death. He now sits at the Father's right hand, interceding for us (John 1:1-3; Matthew 1:23; 1 Timothy 2:5). In our study we will examine Jesus as the perfect atoning sacrifice, the resurrected Lord, and head of the church.
- **God the Holy Spirit:** The Holy Spirit, co-existent and equal with the Father and the Son, is sent by the Father through the Son to convict the world of sin and prepare believers as the Bride of Christ. He empowers, comforts, and sanctifies those who are in Christ (John 14:26; 15:26; 16:8). In our study we will examine the Holy Spirit as the comforter, given to us by God to equip, empower, sanctify, and abide with us.

Through these distinct persons, God's triune nature is revealed as a perfect union in purpose, will, and love, each person playing a vital role in the divine mission of creation, redemption, and sanctification. The Trinity invites believers to experience God fully, both as a loving Father, a redeeming Savior, and a transforming Spirit.

Conclusion

We can be uniquely known by our names: husband, father, son, brother, friend. Each of these a declaration of who we are in relation to someone else. We can also be known by our attributes: faithful, patient, kind, intelligent, funny. Likewise, we can know God by His attributes and names- He is our Healer, Provider, Shepherd, and Redeemer. However, as labels and words are only a small part of us, for ourselves to be truly known by others, we must be experienced. Even more so with God. To truly and fully know Him we must experience Him.

God's names reveal His character, but personal encounters deepen our understanding of what these names signify. For instance, "God my Healer" takes on a richer, more profound meaning when we understand the depths of illness,

desperation, or helplessness from which God rescues. Knowing Him as our Provider is transformed when we have felt true need and found Him faithful.

Scriptures offer a context to these encounters, showing us God's faithfulness to His people across time and circumstance, reinforcing how His names and attributes are not mere titles but realities He brings to life, experienced in the lives of individuals. It is through this interplay of personal experience and the scriptural narrative that we come to know God—not just as a distant description but as a present, active relationship in every season of our lives.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What attribute of God resonates most with you right now? Why?
1. How does knowing God as “I AM” (Exodus 3:14) change the way you approach Him in prayer?
1. Which of God's names speaks most to your current situation (e.g., Yahweh-Jireh, Yahweh-Rapha)? How has He shown Himself in this way to you?
1. How does understanding God's faithfulness in the Old Testament help you trust Him in areas of uncertainty today?
1. What does the Trinity reveal about God's relational nature, and how does it impact your relationship with Him?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 minutes)

1. **Opening Question (Icebreaker):** *Which of God's names or attributes stood out to you the most during this chapter? Why?*
1. **Exploring Scripture:** *Looking at Exodus 3:14 and Genesis 22:14, how do God's names reflect His character and actions in those stories?*
1. **Practical Application:** *How can understanding God's attributes (e.g., faithful, merciful, sovereign) impact the way we respond to challenges in life?*
1. **The Trinity Discussion:** *How does the Trinity demonstrate unity and purpose? How can this model influence relationships in the church?*
1. **Reflection:** *Where in your life do you need to see more of God's provision, healing, or peace? How can the group pray for you in this area?*

Chapter 3 - Sin and Redemption

Scripture tells us many stories about sin-its causes, its consequences, and how God responds to it. To sin is to fall short of God's standard, or 'miss the mark,' a term from archery describing an archer's failure to hit the target.

Both Old and New Testaments use various terms for sin, each highlighting aspects like its type, severity, intent, victim, nature, and required punishment. There are several broad categorizations that the scriptures use to describe sin:

- Sin against God, sin against man, sin against self
- Intentional sin, unintentional sin
- Sin of a single moment, sin habitually committed
- Sin requiring severe punishment like death, sin requiring financial restitution

In our modern criminal justice systems, we have similar distinctions: degrees of crime, premeditated or crimes of passion, crimes requiring financial restitution, or incarceration, or even capital punishment. An act might be both a crime and a sin, but crime is man's categorization, sin is God's.

The various Greek and Hebrew words for sin have a high level of overlap. All sin is broadly described under the umbrella term 'missing the mark', **Hamartia** in Greek, and **Chata'** in Hebrew. This umbrella term is used for the most severe sins, adultery, murder, but also less severe sins, like showing partiality to wealthy people in our church gatherings (James 2:9).

Here are some words the Scriptures use for sin. They help us understand how serious sin is-and how deeply we need God's grace.

Table 2 - Word Study: Sin

Concept Reference	Hebrew	Meaning & Example
	Greek	
Missing the Mark	Chata' khaw-TAH	Falling short of God's standard. E.g., Cain's jealousy and murder of Abel, an action that falls far

	H2398	
Genesis 4:7 (OT), Romans 3:23 (NT)	Hamartia hah-mar-TEE-ah	from God's standard of righteousness.
	G266	
	Avon	
	ah-VONE	
Moral Corruption	H5771	
2SA 11:4 (OT), Romans 1:18 (NT)	Adikia ah-DEE-kee-ah	Iniquity, guilt, or moral perversity. E.g., David's act of adultery with Bathsheba and the ensuing deception, showing deep moral corruption.
	G93	
	Pesha	
	PEH-shah	
Rebellion	H6588	
Exodus 32:1-4 (OT), Galatians 3:19 (NT)	Parabasis pah-RAH-bah-sis	Transgression, active defiance. E.g., Israel's worship of the golden calf, directly rebelling against God's commandment against idolatry.
	G3847	
	Awen	
	AH-wen	
Wicked and Idolatry	H205	
Genesis 19:4-5 (OT), 1 John 3:4 (NT)	Anomia ah-NO-mee-ah	Wickedness, vanity, disregard for God. E.g., Sodom and Gomorrah's indulgence in wickedness and sexual immorality, with no reverence for God's laws.
	G458	
Trespass or Offense	Asham ah-SHAHM	Trespass, offense, violation. E.g., Achan's theft of devoted items at

H817

JOS 7:1 (OT), Ephesians 2:1 (NT)	Paraptoma pah-RAP-toh-mah	Jericho, violating God's command and bringing harm to Israel.
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G3900

Unintended Sin	Shawgaw shaw-GAW	Sin through ignorance or mistake. E.g., Accidentally breaking a commandment due to ignorance, such as eating food considered unclean without realizing it.
LEV 4:2 (OT), Hebrews 9:7 (NT context)	H7683 (No direct Greek equivalent; similar to hamartia in concept)	

Sin has Consequences

Every sin brings consequences-sometimes immediate, sometimes delayed, but always real.

Let's consider Cain's murder of his brother Able in Genesis 4.

Genesis 4:1-16 (NKJV)

Now Adam knew Eve his wife, and she conceived and bore Cain, and said, "I have acquired a man from the LORD."

Then she bore again, this time his brother Abel. Now Abel was a keeper of sheep, but Cain was a tiller of the ground.

And in the process of time it came to pass that Cain brought an offering of the fruit of the ground to the LORD.

Abel also brought of the firstborn of his flock and of their fat. And the LORD respected Abel and his offering,

but He did not respect Cain and his offering. And Cain was very angry, and his countenance fell.

So the LORD said to Cain, "Why are you angry? And why has your countenance fallen?"

If you do well, will you not be accepted? And if you do not do well, sin lies at the door. And its desire is for you, but you should rule over it.”

Now Cain talked with Abel his brother; and it came to pass, when they were in the field, that Cain rose up against Abel his brother and killed him.

Then the LORD said to Cain, “Where is Abel your brother?” He said, “I do not know. Am I my brother’s keeper?”

And He said, “What have you done? The voice of your brother’s blood cries out to Me from the ground.

So now you are cursed from the earth, which has opened its mouth to receive your brother’s blood from your hand.

When you till the ground, it shall no longer yield its strength to you. A fugitive and a vagabond you shall be on the earth.”

And Cain said to the LORD, “My punishment is greater than I can bear!

Surely You have driven me out this day from the face of the ground; I shall be hidden from Your face; I shall be a fugitive and a vagabond on the earth, and it will happen that anyone who finds me will kill me.”

And the LORD said to him, “Therefore, whoever kills Cain, vengeance shall be taken on him sevenfold.” And the LORD set a mark on Cain, lest anyone finding him should kill him.

Then Cain went out from the presence of the LORD and dwelt in the land of Nod on the east of Eden.

Where did Cain miss the mark? (in chronological order)

1. He failed to offer a proper sacrifice.
1. He ignored the warning from Jehovah (God), that sin was waiting to devour him.
1. He murdered his brother.
1. He lied to God about his act of murder.

What were the consequences of Cain's actions?

- His sacrifice was not accepted.
- He felt miserable about the state of his sacrifice.
- He was devoured by sin.
- His brother was dead, his parents lost their child.
- God cursed the ground against Cain, he had to live as a vagabond.
- Cain had to endure his punishment; he would not get relief.
- Cain was marked by God, so that he would not be killed by others, but others knew he was a murderer. He would be socially isolated.
- Cain left the presence of God; the scriptures do not mention Cain ever being with God again.

Pretty severe! Cain's sin carried a hefty price for himself, for Able, for his parents, and for his own future family and lineage.

God is a holy (pure, innocent, blameless) God. When man sins, a person separates himself from God, and the effect of our sin is spiritual death, and quite possibly natural death as well.

Isaiah 59:2 (NKJV)

But your iniquities have separated you from your God; And your sins have hidden His face from you, So that He will not hear.

Romans 6:23 (NKJV)

For the wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord.

Galatians 6:7-8 (NKJV)

Do not be deceived, God is not mocked; for whatever a man sows, that he will also reap.

For he who sows to his flesh will of the flesh reap corruption, but he who sows to the Spirit will of the Spirit reap everlasting life.

God cannot have fellowship with unrighteousness. The pain and effect of sin is that it naturally separates us from our relationship with God.

Judgment - Now and Eternal

The scriptures declare that there will be final judgement for every man according to his deed. This judgement, called the ***Great White Throne Judgement***, happens after the **resurrection of the dead to condemnation** (John 5:28-29), and is for everyone whose name is not in the ***Lamb's Book of Life***. This judgement is not for the believer, but for the unbeliever, believers face the ***Judgement Seat of Christ*** (read the final chapter for more details). The scriptures say God will pour out His wrath upon those who have broken His laws; His judgment will be eternal separation and misery. Jesus says in John 5:26-27 that the Father has given Him authority to carry out this judgement.

Revelation 20:12-13 (NKJV)

And I saw the dead, small and great, standing before God, and books were opened. And another book was opened, which is the Book of Life. And the dead were judged according to their works, by the things which were written in the books.

The sea gave up the dead who were in it, and Death and Hades delivered up the dead who were in them. And they were judged, each one according to his works.

Matthew 12:36-37 (NKJV)

But I say to you that for every idle word men may speak, they will give account of it in the day of judgment.

For by your words you will be justified, and by your words you will be condemned.”

We will likely face the consequence of sin in our natural lives. We may perhaps feel that we've somehow escaped from some portion of the punishment, but there will be no escape man can make on his own accord against God's judgment after our natural death.

Hebrews 9:27 (NKJV)

And as it is appointed for men to die once, but after this the judgment,

Ecclesiastes 12:14 (NKJV)

For God will bring every work into judgment, Including every secret thing, Whether good or evil.

Romans 2:5-6 (NKJV)

But in accordance with your hardness and your impenitent heart you are treasuring up for yourself wrath in the day of wrath and revelation of the righteous judgment of God,

who “WILL RENDER TO EACH ONE ACCORDING TO HIS DEEDS”:

Knowledge of judgment isn’t meant to leave us in fear but to awaken us to the seriousness of sin and the depth of God’s mercy. It is God’s loving call to repentance-a call to turn from sin and receive the forgiveness and restoration He freely offers through Christ.

Even in the midst of judgment, God’s heart for redemption shines through. From the first sacrifice in Genesis, where He covered Adam and Eve’s shame with animal skins, to the intricate sacrificial system He established for Israel, we see a pattern of grace woven into God’s plan. These sacrifices were not the final solution but foreshadowed the ultimate sacrifice to come, Jesus Christ, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world. As we examine these Old Testament sacrifices, we begin to see how God prepared His people to understand the cost of sin and the hope of restoration.

Sin Requires Sacrifice

In the story of Adam and Eve, God kills animals and makes clothes for them from their skins (Genesis 3:20). This was the first shedding of blood to cover the consequence of sin. There are a few other similar accounts in the book of Genesis, but God formally institutes a method of sacrifice for sin in the book of Leviticus.

Table 3 - Old Testament Sacrifices

Sacrifice	Hebrew	Purpose
Reference		
	Olah	
Burnt Offering	oh-LAH	General atonement for sin, devotion to God
Leviticus 1	H5930	
	Minchah	
Grain Offering	min-KHAH	Thanksgiving and dedication
Leviticus 2		

H4503

Peace Offering	Shelamim	
Leviticus 3, 7:11-21	sheh-lah-MEEM	Fellowship, peace with God
	H8002	

Sin Offering	Chatat	
LEV 4:1-5:13	khah-TAHT	Atonement for unintentional sin, purification
	H2403	

Guilt Offering	Asham	
LEV 5:14-6:7	ah-SHAHM	Atonement and restitution for specific sins
	H817	

Burnt Offering (*Olah*)

The burnt offering, or ***Olah***, was a general offering for atonement and devotion to God, often symbolizing complete surrender. This offering addressed sin in a broad sense, covering both known and unknown sins. The ritual involved sacrificing a male animal—typically a bull, sheep, goat, or bird—without any defects. The offeror laid hands on the animal's head, symbolizing identification with the sacrifice, and then the entire animal was burned on the altar. This act of burning the whole offering represented total dedication to removing sin and aligning one's life with God. The burnt offering underscored the seriousness of sin and the need for complete devotion, showing reverence and repentance through the giving of something valuable.

Grain Offering (*Minchah*)

The grain offering, known as ***Minchah***, was a sacrifice of thanksgiving and dedication rather than a direct offering for sin. This offering accompanied other sacrifices, like the burnt and peace offerings, and was meant to express gratitude, worship, and devotion to God. Made from fine flour mixed with oil and frankincense, the grain offering included no blood. A portion of the grain was burned on the altar as a gift to God, while the rest was given to the priests as food. While not specifically for sin, the grain offering was an important part of

communal worship, symbolizing the offeror's dedication and gratitude toward God's provision and grace.

Peace Offering (*Shelamim*)

The peace offering, or ***Shelamim***, focused on fellowship and symbolized peace with God. This offering often followed sacrifices for sin and atonement, celebrating restored relationship with God after sin had been addressed. The offeror could bring a male or female animal without defect, such as a cow, sheep, or goat. In the ritual, the fat portions—the best parts of the animal—were burned on the altar as God's portion, while the remaining meat was shared by the priests and the offeror in a communal meal. The peace offering was unique because it symbolized communion and fellowship, reflecting a sense of wholeness and unity with God. After sin had been atoned for, this offering allowed the community to rejoice in God's acceptance and celebrate restored peace.

Sin Offering (*Chatat*)

The sin offering, or ***Chatat***, was specifically designated for unintentional sins or sins committed in ignorance. When an individual or the community realized they had sinned without intending to, they could offer a sin offering to seek purification and forgiveness. The type of animal offered varied based on the status of the person involved: a priest or congregation offered a bull, a leader offered a male goat, and an individual offered a female goat or lamb. The priest would sprinkle the blood of the sacrifice before the Lord, burn the fat on the altar, and dispose of the rest of the animal outside the camp if it was a communal sin. This offering demonstrated the seriousness of even unintentional sins and provided a means for the people to remain purified and in right relationship with God.

Guilt Offering (*Asham*)

The guilt offering, or ***Asham***, addressed sins that involved a breach of trust, harm to another, or desecration of holy things. Unlike the general burnt offering, the guilt offering required restitution and was often associated with sins where reparations needed to be made, such as property offenses or violations against holy objects. To perform this offering, the sinner would bring a ram without blemish to be sacrificed. If the sin involved harm to another person or property, the offender also had to make restitution by returning the property plus an additional 20% as a penalty. The guilt offering highlighted the importance of acknowledging one's guilt and taking tangible steps to correct the wrong. It underscored the relational and communal nature of sin, emphasizing that true atonement required not only seeking God's forgiveness but also making things right with those who had been affected by the sin.

Collective Sin

In addition to these specific offerings for individual sin, there were also sacrifices and offerings for the collective sin of the nation made daily, weekly, monthly, but the most important of these is the **Day of Atonement**.

The Day of Atonement (Yom Kippur) was an annual ritual described in Leviticus 16, designed to purify the entire Israelite community from their collective sins over the past year. This unique ceremony took place once a year, on the 10th day of the seventh month, and addressed the sins of the nation rather than individual transgressions. It served to cleanse the tabernacle, the priesthood, and the people, symbolizing both atonement and purification for the entire community.

Central to the Day of Atonement were **two goats** used to represent both sacrifice and the removal of sin. The high priest cast lots to determine each goat's role. The first goat designated "for the Lord," was sacrificed as a sin offering, and its blood was carried by the high priest into the Holy of Holies. Here, the blood was sprinkled on the mercy seat-the cover of the Ark of the Covenant-symbolizing atonement for the sins of the people and reconciling them to God. This act of sprinkling was deeply significant, as it represented the purification of the holy space and ensured that God's presence would remain with His people.

The second goat, known as the **scapegoat (Azazel)**, symbolically bore the sins of the community. The high priest would lay his hands on the scapegoat, confessing Israel's collective sins, thereby transferring them onto the animal. The goat was then sent into the wilderness to die alone, symbolizing the complete removal of sin from the camp. This visible act served as a powerful illustration of both atonement and the release from sin, showing that God not only forgave but also removed the sins of His people.

The Day of Atonement was a profound expression of God's forgiveness and purification, allowing the nation to delay the consequence of sin, and postpone judgment each year. This **atonement did not permanently forgive** the sins of the nation, but delayed God's judgment.

Hebrews 10:1-4 (NKJV)

For the law, having a shadow of the good things to come, and not the very image of the things, can never with these same sacrifices, which they offer continually year by year, make those who approach perfect.

For then would they not have ceased to be offered? For the worshipers, once purified, would have had no more consciousness of sins.

But in those sacrifices there is a reminder of sins every year.

For it is not possible that the blood of bulls and goats could take away sins.

We Have All Sinned

The books of the Bible focus on the issue of sin differently. When Moses recorded the law in the Torah (the first five books of the Old Testament) he recorded specific punishments for specific sins/crimes. I use the word crime here interchangeably, because the books of the law were the legal system of the day for the Israelites.

In the prophets and the historical books, sin and its consequences are often described in terms of the destiny of the whole nation. When the king and the people were disobeying God, the Israelites would be oppressed by their neighbors, defeated in battle, and in some cases carried away into exile.

In Proverbs the author writes as a loving father, to his son, warning him of the personal dangers of sin, and a lifestyle against God's commands. In Psalm, many of David's writings deal with the personal and emotional consequences of having committed sin.

In the Gospels, Jesus warns of sin, calls men to personal repentance, and makes the ultimate sacrifice of sin. In Romans, the Apostle Paul, makes a tremendous case for how God has planned to deal with sin, and how we can be free from its grasp.

The reality is we are all guilty of sin, and we must all pay the price for our transgression.

Romans 3:23 (NKJV)

for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,

Every one of us has sinned, separated ourselves from God, and will stand a before final judgment and its consequences. It may be easy for us to attempt to justify our actions and say that we haven't committed seriously grave sins like murder or adultery and that we are mostly moral and good people. This false attempt to justify ourselves ignores the consequences of our actions, the people we have hurt and sinned against, and ignores the reality of a holy and perfect God. The scriptures say if we deny that we sin that we are liars, and the truth is not us!

1 John 1:8-10 (NKJV)

If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us.

If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

If we say that we have not sinned, we make Him a liar, and His word is not in us.

As we have all sinned, we are all in need of redemption, else we will experience judgment, and eternal separation from God. But the story doesn't end there. Thanks be to God-He made a way for us to be saved, healed, and brought back to Him!

John 3:16 (NKJV) For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.*

From the first sacrifice in Genesis to the cross of Christ, God's plan has always been to redeem us and restore our relationship with Him. No sin is too great, and no distance too far for the grace of God to reach us.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. How does the meaning of sin as “missing the mark” challenge your understanding?
1. Reflect on a time when you experienced the consequences of sin. How did God's mercy and grace meet you in that situation?
1. What emotions arise when you consider God's judgment? Does it lead you toward fear, hope, or repentance? Why?
1. How do the Old Testament sacrifices point to Christ's work on the cross? (Hebrews 9:13-10:18)
1. In what specific areas of your life do you need to experience God's mercy and restoration? How can you respond to His call to repentance and renewal?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** *“What is one example of a time you ‘missed the mark’- whether in faith, relationships, or work-and what did you learn from it?”*
1. **Scripture Discussion:** *Read Romans 6:23. Why does sin carry such serious consequences, and how does Christ’s gift of eternal life resolve this tension?*
1. **Digging Deeper:** *Looking at the story of Cain and Abel (Genesis 4), what warning signs did God give Cain, and how do those warnings apply to us today?*
1. **Practical Application:** *Discuss the difference between guilt and repentance. How does God use conviction to bring about restoration rather than condemnation?*
1. **Reflection:** *What does it mean to live considering Christ’s sacrifice? How can we practically walk in freedom from sin while helping others do the same?*

Chapter 4 - Jesus-The Messiah

Building on our study of sin, we concluded that sin exacts a serious price, against those whom sin is committed and must be restored, and for those who commit sin and must make restitution. The price of sin must be paid. In the Old Testament God established a series of sacrifices performed by priests, individuals, and communities to deal with, resolve, and adjudicate sin.

Even with all the sacrifices for sin, they still weren’t enough-not because God failed, but because people continued to choose sin. While animal sacrifice could provide limited atonement, no amount of animal sacrifice was able to change the sinful nature of men.

God had a wonderful plan, the Messiah (in Hebrew ***Mashiach***, pronounced *Mah-shee-ahkh* - **H4899**) also known as the Christ (in Greek ***Christos***, pronounced *Khris-tos* - **G5547**) meaning “Anointed one”; someone consecrated for a special role (e.g., king, priest, or deliverer).

To understand who Jesus is, it helps to look at what people in His time were hoping the Messiah would be. These expectations shaped how they viewed Jesus and, in many cases, why they struggled to recognize Him as the fulfillment of God’s plan.

Historical Context

The Jewish people had long awaited a coming Messiah. Jewish beliefs about the Messiah during the time just before Jesus were shaped by Old Testament prophecies, the interpretations of which were diverse and not universally agreed upon. Most Jews expected the Messiah to be a political and military leader who would deliver Israel from foreign oppression (primarily Roman rule) and restore the Davidic kingdom. Here's an overview of common Messianic expectations and how they aligned (or did not align) with biblical prophecy:

Common Jewish Expectations of the Messiah Before Jesus

1. A Political and Military Deliverer

- **Belief:** The Messiah would be a king like David, leading Israel in a victorious revolt against foreign powers and restoring Israel's independence.
- **Scriptures Referenced:** Isaiah 9:6-7, Jeremiah 23:5-6, Zechariah 9:9-10.
- **Historical Context:** Jews under the Roman's rule were oppressed and heavily taxed, leading to hopes for a Messiah who would overthrow Rome and establish a powerful earthly kingdom.
- **Truth:** Jesus is a King, but His kingdom is not earthly (John 18:36). He established a spiritual kingdom through His first coming, but He will return as a conquering King to judge and rule in righteousness, as described in the book of Revelation (Revelation 19:11-16).

2. A Restorer of the Davidic Kingdom

- **Belief:** The Messiah would rebuild the Davidic dynasty and bring about a golden age of prosperity, justice, and peace.
- **Scriptures Referenced:** 2 Samuel 7:12-16, Amos 9:11.
- **Interpretation:** The focus was often on national restoration rather than spiritual renewal.
- **Truth:** Jesus, as the descendant of David, fulfills this promise by establishing an eternal kingdom. While this kingdom is spiritual in nature now, it will culminate in a physical reign during His second coming (Luke 1:32-33, Revelation 20:4-6).

3. A Prophet Like Moses

- **Belief:** Some Jews believed the Messiah would be a prophet, like Moses, who would speak directly to God and on His behalf.
- **Scriptures Referenced:** Deuteronomy 18:15-19.
- **Expectation:** While many anticipated a prophetic figure, they often did not see this role as central to the Messiah but as an additional aspect.
- **Truth:** Jesus fulfilled this prophecy as the ultimate Prophet, speaking God's Word and revealing the Father directly (John 1:18, John 14:10). His prophetic role goes beyond Moses, as He mediates a new and better covenant (Hebrews 8:6-7).

4. A Leader Who Would Bring Justice

- **Belief:** The Messiah would judge the wicked, uphold the righteous, and bring justice to the oppressed.
- **Scriptures Referenced:** Isaiah 11:3-5, Psalms 72:1-4.
- **Interpretation:** Justice was expected to be primarily political and societal rather than spiritual.
- **Truth:** Jesus brings ultimate justice. In His first coming, He offered spiritual redemption and justice through the cross (Colossians 2:13-15). At His second coming, He will execute judgment on the wicked and establish perfect justice for all eternity (Revelation 20:11-15).

Diverse Messianic Beliefs

As Christendom today is divided into separate sects, denominations, or belief structures, so too, were the Jews of Jesus' age divided. During the time of Jesus, four major Jewish sects shaped the religious and political landscape of Israel, each with distinct beliefs and expectations about the Messiah. Understanding some background on these different groups can help provide meaningful context to a study of the New Testament scriptures.

The **Pharisees** were the most influential among the common people, known for their strict adherence to the Law (Torah) and oral traditions. They believed in the resurrection, the afterlife, and the existence of angels, emphasizing personal piety and obedience to God's commandments. Their messianic expectation was centered on a figure who would uphold the Law, bring justice, and restore Israel both politically and religiously.

The **Sadducees**, in contrast, were a wealthy and politically powerful group that controlled the Temple and priesthood. They rejected oral traditions and accepted only the Torah as authoritative scripture. The Sadducees denied the resurrection, afterlife, and the existence of angels, focusing instead on maintaining their power and collaborating with Rome to ensure political stability. Consequently, they had little emphasis on a Messiah, as their primary concern was preserving the status quo.

The **Essenes** were a separatist group that withdrew from mainstream Jewish society, living in isolated communities such as Qumran. They were deeply focused on ritual purity, apocalyptic expectations, and a disciplined lifestyle. The Essenes believed in two Messianic figures: a priestly Messiah who would restore the Temple's sanctity and a kingly Messiah who would lead Israel in righteousness. This dual-Messiah concept reflected their hope for a spiritual and political renewal. The Essenes are not directly referenced in the scriptures.

Finally, the **Zealots** were militant nationalists who sought to overthrow Roman rule through violent rebellion. They rejected Roman authority and were deeply committed to the restoration of Israel's sovereignty. Their messianic expectation was for a warrior-king Messiah, akin to David, who would lead them in battle against their oppressors and establish a powerful earthly kingdom.

While these groups focused on earthly expectations, Jesus' mission revealed a far greater plan—one that addressed not just political oppression but humanity's spiritual bondage to sin.

The Truth of the Messiah

The Anointing of Jesus

The Pharisees' and Zealots' vision of a Messiah reflects a recurring pattern in human history—seeking salvation through earthly means while rejecting God's greater plan. As we've seen throughout Scripture, people often turn away from God—even though He's always faithful. Even when God is faithful and accepts us, He is often forgotten and rejected, leading to the cycles of disobedience and decay that plagued earthly kingdoms.

While many expected a political Messiah, Jesus revealed a far greater purpose for His anointing—one that fulfilled spiritual and eternal needs. If Jesus had come as a conquering military leader, as the Jews hoped and expected, it would have only been a matter of time before the kingdom fell into disrepair because of human disobedience.

Instead, Jesus established a kingdom that cannot be shaken. His mission was not rooted in military might or political dominance, but in divine purpose. As the

anointed one, Jesus explained what He was anointed to do and how He would accomplish it:

Luke 4:16-21 (NKJV)

So He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. And as His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day, and stood up to read.

And He was handed the book of the prophet Isaiah. And when He had opened the book, He found the place where it was written:

“THE SPIRIT OF THE LORD IS UPON ME, BECAUSE HE HAS ANOINTED ME TO PREACH THE GOSPEL TO THE POOR; HE HAS SENT ME TO HEAL THE BROKENHEARTED, TO PROCLAIM LIBERTY TO THE CAPTIVES AND RECOVERY OF SIGHT TO THE BLIND, TO SET AT LIBERTY THOSE WHO ARE OPPRESSED;

TO PROCLAIM THE ACCEPTABLE YEAR OF THE LORD.”

Then He closed the book, and gave it back to the attendant and sat down. And the eyes of all who were in the synagogue were fixed on Him.

And He began to say to them, “Today this Scripture is fulfilled in your hearing.”

Jesus was anointed-set apart by God-and sent with a divine mission, full of purpose and power.

Jesus proclaimed:

- The good news (gospel) of the Kingdom.
- Deliverance - forgiveness, pardon of sin, freedom.
- The acceptable year (season) of the lord.

The people He came to were:

- Brokenhearted - shattered emotionally and spiritually.
- Blind - spiritually, and sometimes physically.
- Poor - destitute, in poverty (spiritual and or physical).
- Captives - meaning ‘taken with a spear’ representing those held in bondage against their own will.

Jesus transformed these broken people by:

- Recovering sight
- Set in a state of liberty
- Binding up, healing, restoring

The purpose of Jesus ministry and service was both individual and global, immediate, and long lasting. His purpose does not have a singular focus but is part of God's divine plan to reconcile humanity to God. After sin entered the world, it caused a division between God and mankind. God had to banish man from the garden and from His presence. Throughout the Old Testament, man could be with God, but only partially. It was very rare that God's spirit was given to men, and in the large part men lived in isolation from God. He found a people in the Jews, but wanted a permanent, sure, and complete way to restore His relationship with mankind.

God's presence on the earth at the time of Jesus was for the most part restricted to the innermost part of the temple, the Holy of Holies. Here behind the thick veil that separated the innermost part from the Holy Place, God's presence rested with the ark of the covenant. Man was isolated from God, and God was separated from His creation.

God sent Jesus to repair, rebuild, restore, and reconcile mankind to Himself. (2 Cor 5:17-21)

The Necessary Work of Jesus

To fully reconcile humanity to God, the Messiah's mission required not only proclamation and healing but also the ultimate act of atonement. Jesus had to become the perfect and complete sacrifice, through His death on the cross.

The book of Hebrews explains at great length across its 13 chapters how Jesus became the perfect sacrifice, and was both the offering for sin, and the High Priest to offer it (Hebrews 3 & 4). The priesthood of Jesus is not of the Levitical line (after the tribe of Levi), but was in the manner of Melchizedek, who is said to have no beginning or end, meaning it's not constrained to the patterns and habits of men (Hebrews 7:3). The limitation of the Levitical priesthood is that it depends on the blood of bulls and goats (Hebrews 9:12-13) whose sacrifice is insufficient for the permanent and lasting remission of sins. From our study on sin and sacrifice, we know that the consequence for sins of the people could be put off for a year (Hebrews 10:3) during the day of atonement, but that this sacrifice had to be renewed constantly.

Jesus, in dying on the cross (the accounts of which are in Matthew 27, Mark 15, John 19 and Luke 23) shed His blood, and made payment for the sins, past, present, and future, for of all of humanity. Isaiah 53 reveals Jesus as the suffering servant, who took the full weight of punishment and anguish on Himself. His one-time death became the final, ultimate sacrifice. Jesus is the lamb of God (John 1:29), without spot or wrinkle (sin); because He was perfect and complete and holy, the shedding of His innocent blood made atonement possible. **No more sacrifices are needed or acceptable. The old ones were only temporary-but Jesus' was complete and final.**

Through death and resurrection, we have a new and better covenant (Hebrews 8:6), one secured with the blood of God's own son, Jesus is the mediator of the covenant, He is the go-between. Through the sacrifice of Christ, we receive salvation, and He is the author of '*eternal salvation to all those who obey Him*' (Hebrews 5:9).

The word salvation in Greek is **Sōtēria** (*so-tay-REE-ah* - **G4991**). It primarily means **salvation, deliverance, or preservation**. It encompasses the act of being saved, both in a spiritual sense (eternal salvation through Christ) and in physical contexts (rescue from danger or harm). The term conveys the idea of safety, wholeness, and restoration.

Salvation or Deliverance:

- Refers to God's deliverance of humanity from sin and its consequences through Jesus Christ.
- Used in contexts of eternal salvation (justification, sanctification, and glorification).

Preservation:

- Implies being kept safe, protected, or preserved from danger.

Wholeness or Healing:

- Includes the restoration to a state of completeness or soundness.

Jesus's sacrifice paid the price for us to be forgiven and made a way for us to have a relationship with God and set up a path for us to abide with Him that was only dependent on our obedience, not our perfection or ability to abstain from sin.

When we accept Jesus, by faith (discussed later), we receive His salvation. This salvation connects us with God and puts our name in the **Lamb's Book of Life** (Revelation 20:11-15). The Gospel of John says:

John 3:16 (NKJV)

For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.

To perish means to be ruined-like fruit that goes bad before it can be enjoyed. It's a life that misses what it was made for. Jesus came to give us perpetual, or everlasting life, and to keep us from perishing. Everlasting life is not life that begins after we die, it's life that begins the moment we accept Jesus as our salvation, when we become born-again.

Born Again

2 Corinthians 5:17 (NKJV)

Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have passed away; behold, all things have become new.

When we accept Jesus, we become 'born-again'. This phrase is used by Jesus to describe a transition point, where we become born of the spirit (John 3:1-15). It happens through faith-by choosing to trust Him fully, like entering a marriage covenant, with both heart and words.

Romans 10:9-10 (NKJV)

that if you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you will be saved.

For with the heart one believes unto righteousness, and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation.

When we were born on the earth (born of flesh and water) many things occurred: we took our first breaths and were pronounced alive, we were received by our parents, were given a name, became an heir, received nourishment and protection, and continued to grow.

When we put our trust in Jesus and receive him, we become born again, not of flesh, but of the spirit. We become alive spiritually! Just as in physical birth, many things accompany spiritual birth:

1. When we accepted Jesus, God wiped away our sins and declared us forgiven (**justified**). He gave us a fresh start. The dividing wall between us and Him is removed. (Titus 3:5)
1. We became spiritually **regenerated** and received the indwelling of the Holy Spirit. (1 Corinthians 6:19).
1. We became **adopted** into the family of God and became heirs. (Ephesians 1:5)
1. We receive a source of spiritual nourishment, and eternal protection. (1 Peter 2:2)

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does it mean to you that Jesus was anointed as Prophet, Priest, and King? How does this shape your understanding of His role in your life?
1. In what ways has Jesus fulfilled your expectations of a Savior? Are there areas where He has exceeded what you expected?
1. How does understanding Jesus' mission as the Messiah challenge or deepen your faith?
1. Reflect on your own "born-again" experience. How does this new birth in Christ give you purpose and hope?
1. Jesus came to bring freedom and restoration. What areas of your life still need His touch, and how can you surrender them to Him today?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** *“What is one title or role of Jesus that has been most meaningful in your life?”*
1. **Exploring Scripture:** *Read Isaiah 61:1-3 and Luke 4:16-21. How did Jesus fulfill these prophecies, and what does that mean for us today?*
1. **The Role of the Messiah:** *Discuss how Jesus being Prophet, Priest, and King affects His mission. Why is it important that He fulfills all three roles?*
1. **Personal Application:** *What are practical ways we can reflect Christ’s mission of freedom and restoration in our families, churches, and communities?*
1. **Born-Again Reflection:** *How does the idea of being “born again” (John 3:3-7) relate to Jesus’ mission as the Messiah? How does it shape our identity and purpose?*

Chapter 5 - Repentance from Dead Works

Oftentimes in Christianity we think about repentance as fundamental only to the beginning of our faith in Jesus. The heart of repentance goes much deeper than turning away from sin unto salvation. Repentance from dead works means living with our hearts turned away from the things that harm us or stunt our growth- and turned toward the things of God.

The author of Hebrews sets ‘repentance from dead works’ as the first item in the list of the foundational doctrines after the foundational principles of the Messiah (Chapter 4).

Hebrews 6:1 (NKJV)

Therefore, leaving the discussion of the elementary principles of Christ, let us go on to perfection, not laying again the foundation of repentance from dead works and of faith toward God,

Let’s take an in-depth look at the Greek for this phrase:

Table 4 - Word Study: “Repentance from dead works”

Greek

Pronunciation

Definition

Strong’s

metanoia

meh-TAH-noi-ah

Repentance; a change of mind or purpose, turning away from sin and toward God

G3341

Apo

ah-POH

From; a preposition indicating separation, departure, or moving away from something

G575

Erga

ER-gah

Works; actions, deeds, or labor (toil)

G2041

Nekros

NEH-kros

Dead; lifeless, ineffective, without vitality

G3498

Dead Works

Every person who has ever been employed knows what work is. Work is the set of tasks that you undertake to receive a paycheck so you can earn a living (employment). Employment is an agreement to trade your talents and efforts for something of value that will help sustain you. You work because you get something out of it.

Our work is important, it can bring a sense of purpose, often a sense of identity. It's very common to be asked 'What do you do for a living?' and the response begins with a statement of identity 'I am'. While work can be enjoyable and purposeful, it is also very likely to be physically or mentally tough, difficult, challenging, and stressful. If your job is none of these things, you might find it too menial and boring.

If you work a 40-hour a week job, and sleep 8 hours per night, you spend 36% of your waking hours working, and this excludes the time you spend getting ready to work, commuting to work, taking care of a household, and all the other necessary tasks you need to do to keep the your life on track.

Why do we do all this work? It varies, but definitionally because we get something of value from it.

Would you continue to work at a job if they stopped paying you? For most of us the easy and painfully obvious answer is a resounding, NO!

Would you continue to work at a job if it was killing you? I suppose it depends on how quickly.

The context of **nekros** joined with **erga** is labor or work that is dead, has no vitality, cannot reproduce! The author of Hebrews is warning us of labor that is dead.

In the study of biology, there are several criteria that are used to determine if an organism is alive (this is a partial list used for our purpose):

1. **Metabolism:** Living things convert energy through metabolic processes to grow, develop, and sustain themselves.
1. **Growth and Development:** Life involves growth and progression over time, with a specific life cycle and developmental changes.
1. **Reproduction:** Living things have the capacity to reproduce, creating offspring or new entities.
1. **Response to Stimuli:** Life responds to external stimuli (like light, heat, or sound) and can adjust to changes in the environment.
1. **Homeostasis:** Living organisms maintain internal stability, such as temperature regulation or pH balance.
1. **Adaptation:** Over time, living things can adapt to their environments through genetic changes, allowing survival in various conditions.

If we apply this standard of 'life' to our works with a bit of creative license, then dead works are those that:

1. Do not permit personal growth or development.
1. Do not reproduce, cannot produce a positive or desirable result.
1. Do not respond to external stimuli, the light of God's presence or the sound of His voice.
1. Do not maintain internal stability, become dis-regulated, are not self-controlled.
1. Do not adapt (are too rigid) and no longer help us survive.

Dead works are not God's desire for us. God wants to bring us life!

John 10:10 (NKJV)

The thief does not come except to steal, and to kill, and to destroy. I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly.

While dead versus alive is a binary. Dying is a gradient. Our dead works may not be completely dead across every single category, yet, but they will become so! Dead works are like poisons, some have greater effects.

Poison hurts the body by preventing it from functioning normally. Some poisons have small effects, like a headache. Others affect how we think, see, or even if we can bear children (live fruitfully). Dead works are just like that. They may just be a headache, or they may cause death.

Dead works are any works that in review and consideration are not bringing the abundant life that Jesus promised. Having an extra marital affair is very strong poison, it's likely to have a full and negative effect quite soon. Being a needlessly stubborn and resentful person will slowly poison a person until they've driven everyone away from them.

To be delivered from dead works, we must repent!

Repentance

To 'repent from dead works' is to turn to God and leave behind anything that is hurting our walk with Him-starting with a change of heart and mind.

Building on the analogy of poison for dead works, if you found out that your favorite snack was full of toxic heavy metals that would give you a fatal condition if consumed, what would you do? We would without hesitation put it away from

us, and never enjoy it again. Realizing that to consume it means our untimely, and probably painful death.

We must repent! We must turn away from the things of this life that are poisoning us and leading to both our natural and spiritual death.

To understand this fully we need to look a bit deeper into the Greek language.

The term used in Hebrews is *repentance*. This is contrasted with the term *repent*, an example is found in

Matthew 4:17 (NKJV)

From that time Jesus began to preach and to say, “Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.”

Repent (***Metanoēō***, pronounced *meh-tah-NO-eh-oh* - **G3340**) is a verb, it’s an action or occurrence, it means to change one’s mind or purpose; to turn away from sin and toward God.

Repentance (***Metanoia***, pronounced *meh-TAH-noi-ah* - **G3341**) is a noun, it’s a state of having repented, it means to have a change of mind; the state of having turned away from sin and toward God.

When God says in Hebrews ‘*repentance from dead works*’ He is saying to be in the state of having repented! We are to live in a continual state of having ‘turned away’ from dead works.

How many times do we need to repent? Trick question! We need to continually change our minds until we are no longer doing dead works. To repent is **not asking for forgiveness, or apologizing**, although that might be involved. Repent is to turn away from the previous manner of thinking.

Changing Our Minds

How do we change our minds? Intentionally, through an experience with truth.

John 8:31-32 (NKJV)

Then Jesus said to those Jews who believed Him, “If you abide in My word, you are My disciples indeed.

And you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.”

John 16:13 (NKJV)

However, when He, the Spirit of truth, has come, He will guide you into all truth; for He will not speak on His own authority, but whatever He hears He will speak; and He will tell you things to come.

We change our minds by hearing truth that replaces our deadly belief. His truth could be spoken to us by a friend, read in a book, revealed personally by the Holy Spirit, or in any number of ways.

Systems of Change

There is a cognitive trap in changing our minds. If we don't perceive a need to change our minds, then why would we ever open our eyes to look for change? Again, back to the poison analogy, if you cannot perceive that the poison is killing you, why would you stop consuming it?

Some people believe that a person just must hit 'rock-bottom', then they will look at their lives and decide to change. Experience and psychology tell us we humans are more complex. There are many theories related to behavior change in the study of psychology, one highly regarded theory is the **Transtheoretical Model of Change** Developed in the late 1970s by James Prochaska and Carlo DiClemente [1].

People may go through a cycle of six stages for change:

1. Precontemplation: There is no intention to change.
1. Contemplation: There is an intention to change in the near future.
1. Preparation: Some steps have been taken to change.
1. Action: The behavior has been changed for a short time.
1. Maintenance: The behavior has been changed and continues to be maintained.
1. Termination: There is no desire to return to the previous behavior.

There is no set length of time for how long any stage may take. Some people with respect to certain issues in their lives never meaningfully progress through the stages. In other instances, we can progress from stage 1 to 6 very expediently.

Example - Emotional Regulation

Scenario:, a father experiencing a sudden conviction after yelling at his child.

1. **Precontemplation:** He sees himself as a *firm* but *loving* parent. He believes raising his voice is necessary. He's not considering changing. In fact, he might even justify it- "That's how my dad raised me."
1. **Contemplation:** One day, after a long day at work, he snaps and yells at his young daughter harshly, louder and angrier than ever before. She flinches. Her lip trembles. She quietly walks away. In that moment... something **shifts**.
1. **Preparation:** He sits alone in the kitchen, stunned. The image of her hurt face plays over and over in his mind. His stomach turns. He says to himself, "*That's not who I want to be.*" He knows he needs to do something different-*now*.
1. **Action:** He walks into her room, kneels down, apologizes sincerely, and says, "*Daddy was wrong. You didn't deserve that.*" She hugs him. Motivated to cement the change he prays and talks to a friend for support.
1. **Maintenance:** The next day he starts reading parenting books to work on developing positive emotional self-regulation.
1. **Termination:** Months pass. Yelling isn't part of the pattern anymore. He's not perfect, but something has truly changed. He no longer justifies the old behavior-and he has no desire to go back.

Helping Others Change

Much of our discussion has been centered on the act and necessity of repentance from the perspective of the person who needs change. However, we will encounter people who desperately need to change, but are stuck in **precontemplation/contemplation** - blind to their need to change. We will also likely encounter those who are desperate to change, but clueless on what to do (**preparation**).

Jesus, in preaching to the crowds, often encountered people who did not know that they needed to change. We cannot forcibly change someone's mind or repent on their behalf. That is not our place, nor is it the example of Jesus.

Jesus deals with this slow process and sometimes inability to change by speaking in parables. Why did Jesus decide to speak in parables? He reveals why in Matthew:

Matthew 13:10,11,13,15 (NKJV)

And the disciples came and said to Him, “Why do You speak to them in parables?”

He answered and said to them, “Because it has been given to you to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it has not been given.

Therefore I speak to them in parables, because seeing they do not see, and hearing they do not hear, nor do they understand.

FOR THE HEARTS OF THIS PEOPLE HAVE GROWN DULL. THEIR EARS ARE HARD OF HEARING, AND THEIR EYES THEY HAVE CLOSED, LEST THEY SHOULD SEE WITH THEIR EYES AND HEAR WITH THEIR EARS, LEST THEY SHOULD UNDERSTAND WITH THEIR HEARTS AND TURN, SO THAT I SHOULD HEAL THEM.’

Jesus is saying that He is using parables to slowly open the minds and the eyes of people who cannot see or understand the truth. The truth is like a blinding light, too much of it at one time forces us to close our eyes, it's too painful. By exposing ourselves to a portion of the light it brings illumination which causes us to see what darkness we are actually in. As we experience this illumination, we realize that the word of God is like a lamp to our path and a light into our feet (Psalms 119:110) and that we can use the words of truth to bring light to any aspect of our life.

If you find yourself dealing with someone whose mind is closed off, I recommend you pray and seek God's counsel on how to proceed. From experience and from the example of Jesus, a grace-filled experience with truth, sometimes gradual, can start to open the eyes of the blind. Remember it's the work of the Spirit to bring conviction and illumination.

Once they start experiencing the transformative process of repentance, it produces a good harvest in their lives. If they've been sickened by a poison, having their eyes opened, stopping the poison, and taking an antidote will start to make them healthy.

As we really embrace this transformation we can pray as King David:

Psalms 139:23-24 (NKJV)

Search me, O God, and know my heart; Try me, and know my anxieties;

And see if there is any wicked way in me, And lead me in the way everlasting.

David's prayer of repentance is an invitation for the lamp of truth to be shone in our lives and to reveal the darkened places that are making us sick and producing death.

Godly Sorrow and God's Goodness

While hitting rock-bottom is more a myth than a certain precondition to change, God can use sorrow to influence our minds. God will use sorrow to bring us to repentance. He will convict us of our actions and the state of our lives and hearts to open our eyes to see our complete and total need of Him.

2 Corinthians 7:10 (NKJV)

For godly sorrow produces repentance leading to salvation, not to be regretted; but the sorrow of the world produces death.

Godly sorrow, or the experience of sadness or distress that leads to a *metanoia*, is not the same thing worldly sorrow. Worldly sorrow is the same experience of sadness or distress, but the world offers no hope, only the relief and promise of death.

Sorrow is also different from suffering and grief.

Suffering is the endurance of pain-physical, emotional, mental, or spiritual-especially when prolonged or intense.

Grief is a multifaceted emotional response to significant personal loss, especially relational or existential.

Sorrow, suffering, and grief are closely related ideas. In the human condition we will experience all three, we can learn and grow through all three, but God will not bring about death and destruction in our lives to teach us.

The scriptures say every good and perfect gift is from God above (James 1:17). He is a good Father who knows how to give good gifts to His children (Matthew 7:11). Godly sorrow will cause discomfort, but His discipline is just and loving. Just as a good father would not intentionally break his child's arm to 'teach him a lesson', God will not inflict sickness or disease on His children to teach us.

Example of Worldly Sorrow vs Godly Sorrow

A three-year-old boy was playing in the yard with his two-year-old sister. He was playing with a stick, and he intentionally hit her, causing her to cry and leaving a red mark.

Their father hearing the commotion investigated and when he learned what his son did took the stick, broke it in half and tossed it away. He sent his son inside to think about what did and comforted his daughter.

The father coming inside to deal with his son found him crying. Asking him why he was crying his son said, “because you broke my stick”.

The father’s reply was, “I’m sad that you are more concerned about your stick than you are about your sister who you hurt” and sent him back to his room for more reflection.

A few minutes later his son came back out and apologized. He said he was still sad because dad has broken his stick, and because he had hit his sister.

Progress!

In this example the boy experienced both worldly sorrow, for his lost stick, and then eventually godly sorrow, for his hurt sister.

Godly sorrow and God’s goodness are connected. God is a good father that will let us experience the consequences of our actions but will still stand beside us as we walk through those consequences.

God’s unrelenting goodness, to be willing to redeem us and restore us if we come to Him is a positive agent in our path of repentance. His goodness isn’t that we continue in sin, but that despite our sin He makes a way for us to be redeemed and experience His salvation.

Romans 2:4 (NKJV)

Or do you despise the riches of His goodness, forbearance, and longsuffering, not knowing that the goodness of God leads you to repentance?

Despite God’s goodness, mercy, and grace, some people do not repent and do not change, they get stuck in a cycle of frustration and pain. In the extreme opposite, for some people the mere example of sin and consequence in someone else’s life is enough to cause them to change their thinking.

Man has great capacity to change; it’s wired into our very essence. Humans are very adaptable, we can learn and grow, and find better ways to do things. However, a capacity to change is not the same as a willingness or a persuasion to change.

I do not know why some people get stuck and others are so ready to change, but I can say that the entire process of change is really from God’s grace.

Ephesians 2:8-10 (NKJV)

For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God,

not of works, lest anyone should boast.

For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand that we should walk in them.

The process of repentance begins before we accept Jesus as our personal Lord and Savior, but the lifestyle of repentance is to endure for our entire Christian walk. We are to throw off dead works and change our minds away from them to the truth of God.

Repentance can be a purely natural process, but repentance is also the work of the Spirit calling out to us, opening our eyes to the truth, changing our hearts, beckoning us to be transformed. Galatians 6:1 reminds us that some will be ‘stuck’ in a trespass (sin) and need help to get unstuck! That help comes in the form of mature men and women who help restore us in a spirit of gentleness.

The Holy Spirit is the greatest agent for change mankind can engage with, and this is backed up by both the scriptures and by research. Research by “Lyons et al. (2010) found that up to 82% of clients who experienced a spiritual awakening during substance abuse treatment and recovery were completely abstinent at a 1-year follow-up compared with 55% of non-spiritually awakened clients.” [2] While man can initiate and mediate change, we can accomplish so much more when we walk with God’s Spirit.

In our subsequent studies on the Holy Spirit and on sanctification, we will see in greater depth how the Spirit calls and transforms the hearts of men. Let’s look at one such example, the story of King David and his example of repentance.

David’s Example of Repentance

Perhaps no account in the scriptures has a richer example of repentance than the story of King David’s sin found in 2 Samuel 11-12. It begins with King David remaining in Jerusalem instead of going to battle, where he sees Bathsheba bathing. Despite knowing she is the wife of Uriah, one of his loyal soldiers, David sends for her, and they have an affair, resulting in Bathsheba’s pregnancy.

To cover his actions, David recalls Uriah from the battlefield, hoping he will spend time with Bathsheba and appear to be the child’s father. However, Uriah, out of loyalty to his fellow soldiers, refuses to go to his home with Bathsheba. David then arranges for Uriah to be sent to the front lines where he is ultimately killed in battle. After Uriah’s death, David hastily marries Bathsheba to cover up the pregnancy.

The Lord is displeased with David's actions and sends the prophet Nathan to confront him. When confronted by the prophet, David immediately admitted, "*I have sinned against the Lord*" (2 Samuel 12:13). David did not try to justify or excuse his actions. This confession was the first step in his repentance, acknowledging his wrongdoing directly to God.

In Psalm 51, David's words, "*For I know my transgressions, and my sin is always before me,*" show his complete ownership of his actions. He expresses grief not only for the sin itself but also for how it offended God, saying, "*Against you, you only, have I sinned.*" David displayed "*a broken and contrite heart,*" an essential part of true repentance (Psalms 51:17). This sorrow wasn't superficial; he deeply grieved over the sin he committed and the hurt it caused. This depth of remorse was a sign that he wanted not only forgiveness but a changed heart.

David asked God to "*Create in me a pure heart, O God, and renew a steadfast spirit within me*" (Psalms 51:10). He sought an inner transformation that would prevent him from repeating the same mistakes. Rather than just apologizing, David pleaded with God to cleanse him, saying, "*Wash me, and I will be whiter than snow*" (Psalms 51:7). He recognized that only God could purify his heart and restore his joy.

David's desire to be renewed spiritually reflects a genuine commitment to walk in God's ways moving forward. His request for a "*willing spirit*" (Psalms 51:12) demonstrates his hope to be aligned with God in every part of his life.

Although God put away David's sin, the Lord struck the child and he was very sick. David fasted, prayed, and pleaded with God to spare the child, but when the child died, David accepted it (2 Samuel 12:15-23).

In Psalm 51 we find a personal prayer of repentance and a public acknowledgment of his transgressions. David's decision to write down his plea for mercy, creating one of the Bible's most enduring psalms, shows his willingness to be transparent about his sin and God's forgiveness. This psalm became a testimony of repentance and restoration for others to learn from, memorializing his journey from guilt to grace.

David's repentance journey was not simply about feeling sorry; it was a profound change in his heart and life. Through confession, acceptance, and the heart transformation inscribed in Psalm 51, David memorialized his sin as a lesson on God's mercy, repentance, and the possibility of restoration, making his story one of the Bible's most significant examples of genuine repentance.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What are “dead works” in your life? How can you identify areas that are not bringing the abundant life Christ promises?
1. Reflect on the concept of repentance as a lifestyle. What steps can you take to ensure repentance remains a daily practice?
1. In what ways has God used “godly sorrow” to draw you closer to Him? How did it lead to positive change?
1. Think about a time when the Holy Spirit revealed a truth that changed your mindset. How did that experience impact your actions and faith?
1. David’s repentance was marked by confession, acceptance, and transparency. Which of these aspects resonates with you, and how can you apply it to your walk with God? What stages of change did David go through?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** *“When you hear the word ‘repentance,’ what emotions or thoughts come to mind?”*
1. **Exploring Scripture:** *Read 2 Corinthians 7:10. How does “godly sorrow” differ from the sorrow of the world? Why is this distinction important?*
1. **Dead Works:** *Discuss the characteristics of “dead works” (e.g., ineffective, unfruitful, lifeless). How can we avoid or turn away from them in our daily lives?*
1. **The Role of the Holy Spirit:** *Read John 16:13. How does the Holy Spirit guide us in repentance and truth? Share personal experiences where you felt the Spirit leading you to change.*
1. **Practical Repentance:** *What does it mean to “renew a steadfast spirit” as David prayed in Psalms 51:10? How can we cultivate this in our lives?*

References

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[2] - Grim, B. J., & Grim, M. E. (2019). Belief, Behavior, and Belonging: How Faith is Indispensable in Preventing and Recovering from Substance Abuse. *Journal of*

Chapter 6 - Faith Toward God

Faith is a bedrock concept in Christianity. Faith is such a commonly used word in Christianity that sometimes the meaning of the word is supplanted by subtle misconceptions and wrong understanding. But it's not something you can hold in your hands-it's something formed in your heart as you come to trust God. Persuasion is belief.

The writer of Hebrews instructs us that we are to have 'faith towards God'.

Hebrews 6:1-2 (NKJV)

Therefore, leaving the discussion of the elementary principles of Christ, let us go on to perfection, not laying again the foundation of repentance from dead works and of faith toward God, of the doctrine of baptisms, of laying on of hands, of resurrection of the dead, and of eternal judgment.

In this chapter we will discuss what faith is, and is not, how to increase our faith, how we exercise our faith (obedience), the benefits of living a life of obedience, and practical steps to increasing our faith.

As we did in our study on repentance, let's examine the Greek to set the stage for our study. Understanding these terms helps us see how faith is both directional (toward God) and relational (rooted in trust and persuasion).

Table 5 - Word Study: "Faith toward God"

Greek	
Pronunciation	Definition
Strong's	
Pistis	
PEES-tees	Faith; persuasion, trust, belief, assurance, or conviction

Table 5 - Word Study: “Faith toward God”

G4102

Epi

eh-PEE

Toward; a preposition indicating direction, purpose, or aim

G1909

theos

theh-OSS

God; the supreme being, creator, and ruler of all things

G2316

Defining Faith

Faith is a commonly misunderstood and misrepresented aspect of Christianity. As the saying goes, “there is a ditch on both sides of the road”! Because the word faith is so commonly used without proper explanation in our modern Christianity, it can come to pick up erroneous definitions amplified through misunderstanding. Faith is often portrayed either as a blanketed statement of abstracted belief or as an almost mystical power or “magic,” something you possess in a specific measured and limited amount.

What Faith is Not

Faith misrepresented abstractly has no specific conviction or persuasion. This is often evident with a bit of probing as this representation of faith cannot be made specific. If you ask, ‘what do you believe’ or ‘why do you believe’ the person with this understanding of faith often cannot clarify beyond ‘I believe’. 1 Peter 3:15 says we should be ready to give an answer for the hope that is in us.

Sometimes people think of faith like a magical power-but that’s not what Scripture teaches. Faith is about a real relationship built on trust. In Scripture, faith is far more dynamic and relational-it’s rooted in persuasion, trust, and confidence in God’s character and promises. It’s not an impersonal force but an engaged response to God that shapes thoughts, feelings, and actions.

Why is belief relevant to persuasion?

Our beliefs shape the way we see and interact with the world around us. Belief molds perception and precipitates our actions. This is how our minds are wired- we live based on what we believe is possible.

We act on what we perceive, understand, and believe to be possible. When we walk through a hallway our brain detects the boundaries of the floor and the wall and tells our feet automatically where we can step, and what to avoid. This truth extends beyond our physical navigation of the world around us.

Suppose you believe that it is impossible for you to become financially independent or live a healthy and active lifestyle. In that case your actions will follow that belief, and you, true to belief, will not do or likely even attempt what you believe is impossible.

If you believe that God has an unloving and punishing character, that perception of Him will prevent you from walking with Him as His child.

Faith is Persuasion

So, what is faith? Persuasion! The Greek word ***pistis*** means persuasion, or the result of being persuaded. We are to have persuasion towards God. In English we might say faith (persuasion) ‘**in** God’. If you are married, you hopefully have faith ‘**in**’ your spouse. You believe that they will do what they said they would do, and you believe that they are being authentic and genuine. This trust should extend beyond what they’ve said, to extend to them in general.

Developing faith, persuasion, and trust in a relationship takes time and experience. Hopefully in life you have learned how to develop a trusting relationship with another person. The principles you’ve learned that allow you to increase your trust in someone you know will also allow you can increase your faith in God. Faith in a relationship is increased over time, in experience, with consistency, and through small and large actions that build your confidence in the other person’s character and nature.

‘Faith towards God’, is relational. Relationships are built by two parties, not one. The good news about our faith in God is that God is responsible for His side of the relationship (made possible by the atoning death of Jesus, and the infilling of His spirit at rebirth), and He helps us on our side too (through the work of the Comforter - the Holy Spirit). God is doing almost all the work, our part (as we will discuss later in this chapter) is to walk *WITH* Him in obedience.

Jesus Matures Our Faith

Jesus is the author and perfecter of our faith (Hebrews 12:2). Our faith is designed to be continually growing and expanding. We don’t reach a single point where we have enough ‘faith’, but rather our faith increases. Consider a deep and personal

relationship you have in your life today. As in any relationship we don't arrive at a specific milestone where now we 'know' the person. We continue to know them, and increase our knowledge of them, and this refines, shapes, and grows our relationship.

How do we grow our faith in God? By continuing to experience Him across His many revelations, manifestations, and attributes. Again, consider a deep personal relationship in your life. You increase the depth of relationship by engaging them in different ways, in different formats, in different mediums, in different settings. You talk to them, message them, perhaps write to them. You see them individually, and in group settings. You talk about what you value, and perhaps you challenge one another. The numerous ways go on to infinity. Across these many expressions you come to know the person more deeply.

We should all come to know God, through Jesus, as our savior. Think back to the names of God (*see the appendix*), just because we know God as savior doesn't mean we have yet experienced Him as deliverer, healer, counselor, Lord.

If you are in a spot where you have been persuaded (faith) to know God as your savior, building this relationship will give you the confidence in His character to know Him in other ways.

I am blessed to have several very deep relationships in my life. One such relationship is with my wife. In our relationship because of the level of trust (faith) we have in each other, my wife can tell me things that she will do, that I have yet to see made manifest, and I have confidence to believe her because of her proven character.

This example is how our deep relationship with God can be experienced, with trust and confidence! We may not have yet fully experienced Him (indeed we never will fully experience Him in this lifetime), but as we mature in our relationship, we can trust Him beyond the boundary of what I know personally, and what I have seen already happen.

Jesus increases our faith through experience with Him. A significant way we can and should experience Him is through His word.

Faith Increases by the Word of God

Consider this passage from Romans:

Romans 10:16-17 (NKJV)

But they have not all obeyed the gospel. For Isaiah says, "LORD, WHO HAS BELIEVED OUR REPORT?"

So then faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.

When we replace the word *faith* with *persuasion* it reads:

‘Then persuasion comes by hearing and hearing by the Word of God’. This truth is naturally self-evident. A major way someone comes to have persuasion, is to have been persuaded (convinced), and we become convinced when someone makes an ‘argument’-or provides a reasoned and articulated explanation.

There are two Greek words for ‘Word’ in the Bible-**logos** and **rhema**. Understanding the difference helps us see how faith grows.

Logos: generally, refers to the **concept, idea, reason, or broader expression of God’s word**. It encompasses a universal, foundational truth or message and is often used to describe God’s eternal wisdom and Christ Himself as the living Word.

Rhema (G4487): emphasizes a **specific, spoken word or utterance**. It typically refers to a particular word or message given in a specific moment, especially a spoken or revealed word that applies directly to a person’s situation.

Logos is like the entire message of a book, whereas *rhema* is like a particular passage or sentence that speaks directly to someone at a given moment. While *logos* is God’s overarching truth, *rhema* is when part of that truth is spoken to an individual in a personal, applicable way. Together, they illustrate the fullness of God’s communication: *logos* as the broad, foundational truths of God’s character and will, and *rhema* as the specific, applied word that brings that truth alive in a person’s life and situation.

Example of a Rhema Word in Action

God promises revelation and wisdom for all those that ask. When He speaks to us, that utterance is a *rhema* word. Rhema words are from God and serve to confirm, lead, and guide us. They are not a replacement for the *logos* word, nor do they carry authority of scripture. *Rhema* words are to be judged by the same standard as prophecy or interpretation of tongues (see the chapter on the Holy Spirit for an in-depth study on this topic).

At several points in my career, I have prayed for divine guidance. Several years ago, I was contemplating the process of starting to look for a new opportunity and in my prayer time, I heard God say to me *‘Just wait on me, I have an opportunity for you.’* I was starting to look for a new job because I was dissatisfied with my current role and felt frustrated. God’s word of direction *‘wait on me’* helped me have peace and confidence in an otherwise restless season.

Three of four months passed, I kept working hard and faithfully, keeping my attitude positive. God would remind me, *‘wait on me’*, then His promise occurred. I had an opportunity to be promoted and received a generous wage increase.

I could have continued my job search; I could have left. I could have started somewhere new. No doubt someone else would have gotten that promotion! But because I sought the Lord's counsel and was persuaded in His **rhema word**, I obeyed, and received the benefit. God's words are **alive and personal**, and He promises to give us manifold and liberal wisdom (James 1:5).

I have dozens if not hundreds of times where I have prayed and asked God what to do and He has given me a rhema word. Not each had the same spectacular outcome, but they all brought a sense of peace and confidence that I was obeying God and that He would work things out. They were the words I needed for the moment! Many times, when God brings a rhema word, it's from the logos. He will bring to my memory a passage of scripture, "*Fear not for I am with you!*" (Isaiah 41:10), "*By his stripes we are healed*" (Isaiah 53:5), "*Do not grow weary in doing good!*" (Galatians 6:9), manifold examples continue!

Receiving a rhema word not only strengthens our faith but also deepens our relationship with God, as we trust Him more fully in our daily decisions. We will continue our study of learning to hear from God in the chapter on the Holy Spirit.

Our faith is also strengthened by what we see God do, but sometimes what we see in the natural world challenges what we hear from God. Reconciling the inconsistency between what we see and hear is an important ministry of the Holy Spirit, who promises to lead us in to all truth (John 16:13).

Faith Greater Than We Can See

After His resurrection, Jesus appeared multiple times to many of His disciples. Thomas (one of the twelve) had not been with the other disciples, so had missed the appearance of the resurrected savior. Thomas believed in Jesus, and trusted his fellow disciples, but he didn't believe that Jesus had been resurrected in bodily form; he insisted he could not actively believe it until he experienced it personally.

John 20:24-29 (NKJV)

Now Thomas, called the Twin, one of the twelve, was not with them when Jesus came.

The other disciples therefore said to him, "We have seen the Lord." So he said to them, "Unless I see in His hands the print of the nails, and put my finger into the print of the nails, and put my hand into His side, I will not believe."

And after eight days His disciples were again inside, and Thomas with them. Jesus came, the doors being shut, and stood in the midst, and said, "Peace to you!"

Then He said to Thomas, “Reach your finger here, and look at My hands; and reach your hand here, and put it into My side. Do not be unbelieving, but believing.”

And Thomas answered and said to Him, “My Lord and my God!”

Jesus said to him, “Thomas, because you have seen Me, you have believed. Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed.”

When Jesus appeared to His disciples and calmed them down (I imagine it’s quite alarming when someone appears in your midst, having come through locked doors), He spoke to Thomas. He did not criticize or blame Thomas or accuse him as part of the wicked and perverse generation seeking a sign (Matthew 16:4) but revealed Himself to Thomas.

Jesus goes on to say, *‘blessed are they who have not seen and have believed’*. This is not Jesus encouraging ‘blind or ignorant faith’ or rejecting the use of empirical evidence. But He is saying that we are more blessed when we can believe without the need for empirical proof. Why? If our faith, our trust, was limited to purely what we had seen empirically demonstrated, we could never have any confidence in the future work. We would have great confidence in what had been accomplished but would not walk in the peace of God for our tomorrows and for our future.

Using a relational example, how challenging would my relationship with my wife be if my attitude was consistently *‘I’ll believe it when I see it!’*? Instead a trust-based relationship says *‘I know you are a trustworthy person’*.

If we could only have faith in what we have seen demonstrated, then Paul’s encouragement by the Holy Spirit to us would be of no effect:

Philippians 4:6-7 (NKJV)

Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God;

and the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus.

How could God’s peace protect our hearts, if we could not have confidence in Him beyond what we had already seen!?

2 Corinthians 5:7 (NKJV)

For we walk by faith, not by sight.

It is in growing our relationship with God that we can move beyond merely what we can naturally see or comprehend. Like the account of Abraham given in Romans:

Romans 4:19-22 (NKJV)

And not being weak in faith, he did not consider his own body, already dead (since he was about a hundred years old), and the deadness of Sarah's womb.

He did not waver at the promise of God through unbelief, but was strengthened in faith, giving glory to God,

and being fully convinced that what He had promised He was also able to perform.

And therefore "IT WAS ACCOUNTED TO HIM FOR RIGHTEOUSNESS."

My relationship with my wife started as we began dating. As we came to know each other more deeply and built our relationship we progressed from acquaintances, to being friends, to being romantic, to the point where we wanted to be committed to each other in marriage. Upon this rich history and commitment, we are building a family and a life together. In the same manner, our faith towards God should progress. We grow from knowing about God, to knowing God, committing to Him (accepting His salvation), then building our life upon that relationship.

Faith Produces Obedience and Good Works

Our trusting relationship with God is strengthened through obedience, the result bringing good works! These works don't save us or earn God's love-they're the natural result of a life rooted in Him.

Scripture presents a natural progression of faith. As we come to know God and experience His presence, we grow in our belief in Him. This belief compels us to act in ways that align with our faith, leading us to obey His commands. Our obedience produces good works, which bear a harvest of positive and beneficial outcomes.

Consider again this passage from Romans:

Romans 10:16-17 (NKJV)

But they have not all obeyed the gospel. For Isaiah says, "LORD, WHO HAS BELIEVED OUR REPORT?"

So then faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.

Dissecting this in reverse order:

1. Hearing the Word (**rhema**) of God produces faith (**pistis**)

1. Faith, which is a state of belief or persuasion, will produce the action or verb of believing. Again, consider the person who believes they can be debt free acts upon it!

1. Our act of believing is demonstrated in obedience.

The word for 'obeyed' is **hupakouō (hoop-ak-oo'-o- G5219)**: **hupakouō** means to *hear under* (as a *subordinate*), that is, to *listen attentively*; by implication to *heed* or *conform* to a command or authority: - hearken, be obedient to, obey.

In a work setting when the boss or supervisor is giving instructions, they are not "talking to talk", rather they are giving directions that they intend their employees to follow.

When we really listen to God, it should lead us to action-to trust Him and obey. As the scriptures say in:

James 1:22 (NKJV)

But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves.

Consider again the example of financial independence. A person in debt that longs to be free of the burden will seek out financial counseling. The counselor will teach them about the principles of financial freedom and help them build a budget. This counseling will (trust / faith) in what they need to do be debt free. But confidence is just the first step, the person must obey the principles they've learned through disciplined practice to receive the good work and blessing of being debt free.

The book of James says that our belief (faith) must produce works! We already know what works is (e.g., 'dead' works from Hebrews 6:1).

James 2:14-20 (NKJV)

What does it profit, my brethren, if someone says he has faith but does not have works? Can faith save him?

If a brother or sister is naked and destitute of daily food,

and one of you says to them, "Depart in peace, be warmed and filled," but you do not give them the things which are needed for the body, what does it profit?

Thus also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead.

But someone will say, “You have faith, and I have works.” Show me your faith without your works, and I will show you my faith by my works.

You believe that there is one God. You do well. Even the demons believe—and tremble!

But do you want to know, O foolish man, that faith without works is dead?

What stands out to you from that passage in James? To me a significant sentence is that even the demons believe! Belief alone is not enough. Our belief must rise to the level of obedience. We need to and want to obey Jesus our risen savior and Lord.

We do not receive salvation through works! When we receive salvation (through faith) we do works! Let me reiterate that, you cannot work hard enough, or make enough sacrifices to earn your salvation, it is the free gift of God that we receive by faith!

The outcome of these works (obedience) is that they yield a good and beneficial harvest. The length of time it takes to receive the harvest, or the measure of that harvest is varied, but it will produce a good harvest! (Genesis 8:22).

Recalling back to our study on sin and sacrifices, we know that several of the sacrifices instituted in the Old Testament were for sin, so that man could reconcile himself to God or his fellow man. However, there is a more desirable path!

1 Samuel 15:22 (NKJV)

So Samuel said: “Has the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, As in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, And to heed than the fat of rams.

A truth consistent since the Old Testament is that obedience is better than sacrifice. It’s better to correctly follow what we should do, than to need to make a sacrifice to make up for what we did not do correctly. Thankfully there is grace from God when we stray from the path, miss the mark (sin), and need to turn back towards God.

As we build our faith in God, it will naturally produce in us obedience. This obedience is to our benefit and produces a good harvest. Going back to my person example from this chapter, I would not have experienced the peace in the season, or the blessing of a promotion if I had not obeyed God’s word to me to *wait on Him!*

Benefits of Obedience

It's very important in the life of every believer that they strengthen their faith (trust) towards God. God has wonderful promises and blessings for everyone who obeys Him, too numerous to mention here, but these are a few of them:

1. Blessings and Provision

Deuteronomy 28:1-14 (NKJV)

“Now it shall come to pass, if you diligently obey the voice of the LORD your God, to observe carefully all His commandments which I command you today, that the LORD your God will set you high above all nations of the earth.

And all these blessings shall come upon you and overtake you, because you obey the voice of the LORD your God:

“Blessed shall you be in the city, and blessed shall you be in the country.

“Blessed shall be the fruit of your body, the produce of your ground and the increase of your herds, the increase of your cattle and the offspring of your flocks.

“Blessed shall be your basket and your kneading bowl.

“Blessed shall you be when you come in, and blessed shall you be when you go out.

“The LORD will cause your enemies who rise against you to be defeated before your face; they shall come out against you one way and flee before you seven ways.

“The LORD will command the blessing on you in your storehouses and in all to which you set your hand, and He will bless you in the land which the LORD your God is giving you.

“The LORD will establish you as a holy people to Himself, just as He has sworn to you, if you keep the commandments of the LORD your God and walk in His ways.

Then all peoples of the earth shall see that you are called by the name of the LORD, and they shall be afraid of you.

And the LORD will grant you plenty of goods, in the fruit of your body, in the increase of your livestock, and in the produce of your ground, in the land of which the LORD swore to your fathers to give you.

The LORD will open to you His good treasure, the heavens, to give the rain to your land in its season, and to bless all the work of your hand. You shall lend to many nations, but you shall not borrow.

And the LORD will make you the head and not the tail; you shall be above only, and not be beneath, if you heed the commandments of the LORD your God, which I command you today, and are careful to observe them.

So you shall not turn aside from any of the words which I command you this day, to the right or the left, to go after other gods to serve them.

1. Guidance and Wisdom

Psalms 32:8 (NKJV)

I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will guide you with My eye.

1. Answered Prayers

1 John 3:22 (NKJV)

And whatever we ask we receive from Him, because we keep His commandments and do those things that are pleasing in His sight.

1. Protection and Safety

Psalms 34:7 (NKJV)

The angel of the LORD encamps all around those who fear Him, And delivers them.

1. Joy and Peace

Psalms 119:165 (NKJV)

Great peace have those who love Your law, And nothing causes them to stumble.

1. Fruitfulness and Prosperity

Isaiah 1:19 (NKJV)

If you are willing and obedient, You shall eat the good of the land;

1. God's Favor

Psalms 37:23-24 (NKJV)

The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD, And He delights in his way.

Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down; For the LORD upholds him with His hand.

1. **Strength and Endurance**

Isaiah 40:31 (NKJV)

But those who wait on the LORD Shall renew their strength; They shall mount up with wings like eagles, They shall run and not be weary, They shall walk and not faint.

1. **Blessing on Future Generations**

Exodus 20:6 (NKJV)

but showing mercy to thousands, to those who love Me and keep My commandments.

1. **Eternal Life**

Romans 2:7 (NKJV)

eternal life to those who by patient continuance in doing good seek for glory, honor, and immortality;

Every one of those blessings is by the grace of God; we cannot earn them, but we can walk in them through our obedience to Him, which is spurred on and activated by our trusting relationship in Him.

Practical Steps for Growing Your Faith

Walking with God is relational, but there are skills to be learned if you want good relationships. In earthly relationships, the skills that yield the strong and secure relationships are built upon:

- Open and free dialogue and communication
- Healthy conflict resolution
- Commitment
- Consistency

You must show up consistently, reveal (communicate) yourself (our thoughts and emotions), receive the other person (listen), and walk with them, if you want a strong, vibrant relationship! All these skills apply to our relationship with God.

Beyond core relational skills, there are specific practices and disciplines that will strengthen your relationship with God:

- **Build and Maintain a Prayer Life, Listen and Communicate with God.** Regular, heartfelt prayer is essential to a close relationship with God. Through prayer, you can share your worries, joys, and gratitude, seeking His guidance and strength. (*Philippians 4:6-7*) Being sensitive to the Holy Spirit's voice helps you discern God's will, find wisdom in decisions, and grow in spiritual maturity. Take time for quiet reflection to hear His direction. (*Romans 8:14*)
- **Spend Time in Worship.** Worship is a powerful way to draw close to God, expressing love and reverence. Through praise, song, or quiet reflection, worship deepens your awareness of His presence. (*Psalms 100:2-4*)
- **Read, Study, and Meditate on Scripture.** God's Word reveals His character, promises, and instructions for life. Dedicating time to studying Scripture helps you grow in faith, understanding, and spiritual resilience. (*2 Timothy 3:16-17*)
- **Obey His Commandments.** Obedience to God's instructions demonstrates your love, respect, and trust in Him. Walking in obedience aligns your life with His purpose and brings blessings. (*John 14:15*)
- **Actively Attend a Local Church and Serve.** Engaging in a church community offers spiritual support, encouragement, and opportunities to serve others. Being involved helps build a sense of belonging and strengthens your commitment to God's mission. (*Hebrews 10:24-25*)
- **Build Relationships with Other Believers.** Fellowship with other Christians provides accountability, encouragement, and shared wisdom. These relationships enrich your faith journey and help you grow through mutual support. (*Proverbs 27:17*)

Our 'faith towards God' is not a one-time occurrence for salvation but is an ongoing practice and relationship that we are supposed to cultivate our entire lives. The benefits of a trusting and beneficial relationship are incredibly numerous, but we must do the good work of fostering that trust and growth to see it thrive.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does faith mean to you personally? How has your understanding of faith grown through this chapter?
1. Reflect on the concept of logos and rhema. Has there been a time in your life when a specific Scripture came alive for you and became a personal rhema word? How did it impact your faith?
1. How does understanding faith as persuasion rather than a mystical force shape your relationship with God?
1. Obedience is described as the fruit of faith. Can you think of a time when your obedience to God deepened your trust in Him? What was the result?
1. What practical steps can you take this week to cultivate your faith through prayer, Scripture study, and fellowship?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** “When you think of someone with great faith, who comes to mind and why?”
1. **Exploring Scripture:** Read Romans 10:17. What does this verse teach us about how faith grows? How can we apply it in our daily lives?
1. **Faith in Action:** What does it mean for faith to produce obedience? Share examples of how obedience has strengthened your faith or someone else’s faith journey.
1. **Logos and Rhema Discussion:** Discuss the difference between logos (the written word) and rhema (the revealed word). How can we position ourselves to hear and receive rhema words from God?
1. **Cultivating Faith:** Discuss the practical disciplines of prayer, Bible study, and fellowship. Which discipline has been most effective in growing your faith, and why?

Chapter 7 - Jesus-The Foundation of Our Faith

Building on our study of Jesus as the Messiah, in this chapter we continue in looking at the life, person, and work of Jesus. We’ll see that Jesus is the Mediator of a new and better covenant-and that He perfectly fills the roles of Prophet,

Priest, and King. It is in this New Covenant that we as believers have good standing with God and transition from a works-based covenant to a trust-based (faith-based) covenant. Finally, we will read and study the *Apostles Creed* as a way to round-out our study on Jesus.

Mediator of the New Covenant

The concept of a mediator involves a go-between who bridges the gap between two parties, facilitating a relationship or agreement. In the Exodus story, Moses is the initial mediator of the covenant God established with His people. Moses received the law, offered the sacrifice (priest), called God's people to obedience (prophet), and judged them (judge / king). In the remainder of the Old Testament after Moses, the mediating role was fulfilled through the role of the Prophet, the Levitical Priesthood, and the Judges and later Kings of the nation.

Old Testament Roles of Mediators:

1. **Prophet:** Prophets were God's messengers, sent to speak His heart to the people and call them back when they wandered. Moses, for example, served as a prophet who mediated the Old Covenant by receiving the Law from God and teaching it to Israel. Prophets also foretold the coming of the Messiah and the ultimate redemption of humanity. Other prominent examples of prophet include: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Elijah, Elisha, Samuel.
1. **Levitical Priesthood:** Priests acted as mediators by offering sacrifices for the atonement of sins and interceding for the people before God. The High Priest, especially, played a vital role on the Day of Atonement, entering the Holy of Holies to sprinkle blood on the mercy seat, symbolizing reconciliation with God. The priest's ministry is to intercede for the people.
1. **Judge/King:** Judges, and later Kings, were charged with ruling over God's people, enforcing His laws, judging between the people, delivering them from their enemies, and leading them in righteousness. The book of Judges tells the stories of these leaders-people like Deborah, Samson, and Gideon-whom God raised up to rescue and guide Israel. Israel later had a line of kings, many wicked, some good (see 1st and 2nd Kings, 1st and 2nd Samuel, and 1st and 2nd Chronicles). Some prominent examples are Saul, David, and Solomon.

Worth noting is that all the Old Covenant mediators were fully man and not divine. As men they were able to sin, and many times were given to sin. Some of the mediators were sinful and drove people away from God and towards profane worship: false prophets, lying and corrupt priests, and wicked kings.

Christ as the Mediator of the New Covenant

Jesus' death, resurrection and ascension fulfil the Old Covenant, and establish the New Covenant.

The New Covenant is a transformative relationship between God and His people, established through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ. Unlike the Old Covenant, which was focused on external laws, the New Covenant emphasizes internal transformation and grace. It was inaugurated by Jesus at the Last Supper, where He declared that His blood would establish this covenant, replacing the repeated animal sacrifices of the Old Covenant with His once-for-all atonement (Luke 22:20; Hebrews 9:12; Hebrews 10:10). Through this sacrifice, the New Covenant provides complete forgiveness and cleansing from sin, fulfilling the requirement for a perfect and permanent reconciliation with God (Jeremiah 31:34; Hebrews 8:12; Hebrews 10:12-18).

One of the central features of the New Covenant is its internal nature, as God writes His law on the hearts of His people, fostering a heart-level relationship with Him through the Holy Spirit (Jeremiah 31:33; Hebrews 8:10; 2 Corinthians 3:3). This shift enables believers to live out God's will not by mere adherence to external commands but through empowerment by the Spirit (Romans 8:1-4). The New Covenant also grants direct access to God, eliminating the need for an earthly priesthood. Jesus serves as the eternal High Priest, and believers are called a royal priesthood, able to confidently approach God through Christ's sacrifice (Hebrews 7:24-25; Hebrews 10:19-20; 1 Peter 2:9).

Unlike the Old Covenant, which was exclusive to Israel, the New Covenant is universal, extending to all who believe in Christ, regardless of ethnicity or background (John 3:16; Galatians 3:28). This covenant is based entirely on grace, offering salvation and forgiveness freely through faith in Jesus (Ephesians 2:8-9). It is not sustained by human effort but by the enabling power of the Holy Spirit, who transforms and empowers believers to live in obedience and reflect God's character (Ezekiel 36:26-27; Romans 8:9-16; Galatians 5:22-23). Furthermore, the New Covenant is everlasting, surpassing the temporary and conditional nature of the Old Covenant (Jeremiah 32:40; Hebrews 8:13). It represents the ultimate fulfillment of God's redemptive plan, reconciling humanity to Himself and enabling believers to live as His people under His rule for eternity.

Jesus is explicitly identified as the Mediator of the New Covenant in

Hebrews 9:15 (NKJV)

And for this reason He is the Mediator of the new covenant, by means of death, for the redemption of the transgressions under the first covenant, that those who are called may receive the promise of the eternal inheritance.

Through His atoning death and resurrection, Christ inaugurates this new covenant, replacing the old system of sacrifices and external laws with a covenant written on the hearts of believers (Jeremiah 31:31-34). He stands between God and humanity, not only interceding on behalf of His people but also providing the means of reconciliation through His own blood (Hebrews 9:12). Unlike the mediators of the Old Covenant, Jesus is sinless, eternal, and fully capable of fulfilling the divine requirements for justice and mercy, ensuring a lasting relationship between God and believers.

Jesus Fulfills and Perfects These Roles

1. **Prophet:** Jesus is the ultimate Prophet, not merely a messenger of God's word but the Word made flesh (John 1:14). He reveals God's character, will, and plan for salvation fully and perfectly (Hebrews 1:1-2). His teachings, miracles, and prophetic declarations fulfill the Old Testament prophecies and provide the foundation for the New Covenant.
1. **Priest:** Jesus is the perfect High Priest, offering Himself as the once-for-all sacrifice for sin (Hebrews 7:27). Unlike the priests of the Old Covenant who had to repeatedly offer sacrifices for their own sins and those of the people, Jesus, being sinless, offered His own blood to secure eternal redemption (Hebrews 9:14).
1. **King & Judge:** Jesus is the eternal King, reigning in righteousness and justice. As the Son of David, He fulfills the promise of an everlasting kingdom (2 Samuel 7:16). His kingship is not merely earthly but cosmic, ruling over all creation and establishing peace through His victory over sin and death (Philippians 2:9-11). Jesus will return as king and judge, and judge 'both the living and the dead' (Acts 10:42).

In Christ, the roles of Prophet, Priest, and King converge and are fulfilled perfectly. As the Mediator of the New Covenant, He bridges the gap between a holy God and sinful humanity, enabling believers to approach God with confidence (Hebrews 4:16) and ensuring the eternal inheritance promised in Him.

The Apostles Creed

The *Apostles Creed* is not found in scripture, it was created and modified based on the earliest teachings of the church. A creed is a formal confession of beliefs, think of it like a pledge or oath combined with a statement of belief. Creeds are important because they are used to unify and separate those who believe in a particular way from those who do not. In the United States it is common at civil functions like city council meetings or legislative gatherings for the attendees to recite the Pledge of Allegiance. The pledge is used widely in the United States, but isn't used in other countries, because the citizens of those countries do not owe

allegiance to the United States. The pledge is not what makes a person 'American', but it does represent a significant essential belief for those who are citizens.

The first recognizable versions of the creed were written in the fourth century A.D. The creed has changed slightly over the centuries, and has slight variations based on the denomination. Not every Christian denomination uses the creed, but in large part it is widely accepted in some form across the whole of Christianity.

The Apostles Creed has been used as a teaching and catechism tool for centuries and communicates the most fundamental truths of the Christian faith, the base beliefs that must be acknowledged and held to be a Christian. Some denominations have a formal catechism process which is how a new believer joins that specific denomination and becomes indoctrinated into their beliefs.

A person does not need to fully understand these beliefs to come to God and receive salvation, salvation is by faith, not by a doctrinal test! However, in continuing in that faith we all should come to understand these fundamental truths.

*I believe in God, the Father almighty,
creator of heaven and earth.*

*I believe in Jesus Christ, His only Son, our Lord.
He was conceived by the power of the Holy Spirit
and born of the Virgin Mary.
He suffered under Pontius Pilate,
was crucified, died, and was buried.
He descended to the dead.
On the third day He rose again.
He ascended into heaven,
and is seated at the right hand of the Father.
He will come again to judge the living and the dead.*

*I believe in the Holy Spirit,
the holy catholic Church*,
the communion of saints,
the forgiveness of sins,
the resurrection of the body,
and the life everlasting. Amen.*

Contemporary Version of the Apostles Creed, <https://www.rca.org/about/theology/creeds-and-confessions/the-apostles-creed/>

**Meaning the universal Christian church-all believers in Jesus Christ*

Brief Explanation of the Apostles Creed

The fundamental truths in the Apostles Creed are numerous and quite deep, a full explanation would certainly take many whole volumes to explain. While this chapter is about Jesus, many of the topics cross over into the other members of the Godhead. This will be an abbreviated explanation of the creed, focusing only on the most central themes. Several of these topics are studied in greater depth across the chapters of this book.

I believe in God, the Father almighty, creator of heaven and earth.

This affirms belief in God as the all-powerful, sovereign Creator and Father. The title “Father” emphasizes God’s loving relationship with His creation, particularly His children through faith (John 1:12). As the Creator, He spoke the universe into existence, bringing order out of chaos (Genesis 1:1-3). His almighty power is displayed in the vastness of creation, while His fatherly care is seen in His ongoing sustenance and providence. This foundational statement establishes God as the origin and ruler of all life, deserving worship and trust.

I believe in Jesus Christ, His only Son, our Lord.

Jesus Christ is the unique Son of God, eternally begotten, not created, and sharing in the divine nature (John 1:1-2, 14). Jesus is the ‘Word’ since the beginning, and He became flesh and lived with us. As “Christ,” He is the anointed Messiah, fulfilling the Old Testament promises of a Savior. The title “Lord” acknowledges His authority over all creation and His rightful position as ruler and King (Philippians 2:10-11). He is not only Lord, but the Lord who saves (Acts 16:31).

Jesus is not **just** sent from God; He **is** part of God. Jesus abides in the Father and the Father abides in Jesus. The Gospel of John repeatedly establishes that Jesus and the Father are one (John 10:30), that Jesus did not act on His own accord (John 5:19; John 12:49-50), and that everything He did was to glorify His Father (John 17:4; John 14:13), and was done by the authority and power of His Father (John 14:10; John 8:28-29).

He was conceived by the power of the Holy Spirit and born of the Virgin Mary.

This affirms the miraculous conception of Jesus through the Holy Spirit, underscoring His divine origin. Born of the Virgin Mary, Jesus fulfills the prophecy of Isaiah 7:14, which foretold the virgin birth of the Messiah. This event marks the incarnation, where the eternal Word of God took on human flesh (John 1:14). By being both fully God and fully human, Jesus bridges the gap between God and humanity, enabling Him to be the perfect mediator and Savior.

Jesus was conceived by the seed of the Holy Spirit, and did not inherit a sinful nature that we, born of the seed of men, have. Jesus was in every way tempted and tested, but He was perfect and without sin. Hebrews 4:15, 2 Corinthians 5:21, 1 Peter 2:22.

He suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died, and was buried.

Jesus' suffering and death were real, historical events that occurred under the Roman governor Pontius Pilate, grounding the Christian faith in verifiable history. His crucifixion was a fulfillment of Old Testament prophecies, such as Isaiah 53:5, which speaks of the Suffering Servant who would bear the sins of many. Jesus' death was sacrificial, taking the penalty for sin on behalf of humanity (1 Peter 2:24). His burial confirms the reality of His death and prepares for the significance of the resurrection.

He descended to the dead.

After His death, Jesus descended to the realm of the dead, often referred to as *Hades* or *Sheol* in Scripture. This act demonstrates His full identification with humanity, even in death, and signifies His victory over sin, death, and the devil (1 Peter 3:18-20). By descending, He proclaimed His triumph and the completion of His redemptive work.

On the third day He rose again.

The resurrection of Jesus is the cornerstone of our Christian faith, confirming His divinity and the truth of His teachings. By rising from the dead, He defeated sin and death, providing the assurance of eternal life for believers (1 Corinthians 15:17-22). The resurrection also fulfills Scripture, including Jesus' own predictions (Matthew 16:21). This miraculous event transformed the despair of the disciples into bold faith, forming the foundation of the early Church's witness.

He ascended into heaven, and is seated at the right hand of the Father.

Jesus' ascension marks His return to the Father's presence in glory. Seated at the father's right hand (Ephesians 1:20), He assumes the role of our eternal High Priest, interceding for believers (Hebrews 7:25). His position of authority also signifies His exaltation as King, reigning over all creation and directing the Church's mission (Ephesians 1:22) to do greater works (John 14:12) and fulfilling the great commission He gave to us (Matthew 28:18-20, Mark 16:15-18). The ascension assures believers of His ongoing presence and power through the Holy Spirit.

He will come again to judge the living and the dead.

This points to the future return of Christ when He will bring final justice and restoration. Jesus will judge all people, rewarding the faithful and bringing justice to the unrepentant (2 Timothy 4:1). His return will fulfill God's ultimate plan for creation, ushering in His eternal Kingdom of righteousness and peace. This hope encourages believers to live faithfully and expectantly, knowing their labor in the Lord is not in vain (1 Corinthians 15:58).

I believe in the Holy Spirit.

The Holy Spirit, the third person of the Trinity, is God's presence and power active in the world today. He convicts of sin, regenerates hearts, and empowers believers to live holy lives (John 16:8-13). The Spirit unites Christians as one body, the Church, and equips them with spiritual gifts for service (1 Corinthians 12:4-11). He is the Comforter, Advocate, and Guide, dwelling within believers as a seal of their eternal inheritance (Ephesians 1:13-14).

The holy catholic Church, the communion of saints.

The "holy catholic Church" refers to the universal body of Christ, comprising all believers across time and space. The Church is set apart for God's purposes, called to reflect His holiness and share the gospel. The "communion of saints" emphasizes the unity of all Christians, living and dead, as members of Christ's body (Ephesians 4:4-6). This fellowship transcends earthly divisions, demonstrating the shared hope and mission of believers.

Jesus is the head of the church. The church is referred to as both the bride of Christ (Ephesians 5:25-27) and the body of Christ (Colossians 1:18).

The forgiveness of sins.

This highlights the heart of the gospel: through Jesus' sacrificial death, God offers complete forgiveness for sins to all who repent and believe (Ephesians 1:7). This forgiveness restores the broken relationship between humanity and God, removing guilt and shame. It also calls believers to extend forgiveness to others, reflecting the grace they have received (Matthew 6:14-15).

The resurrection of the body.

Like Jesus, we will experience a bodily resurrection at the end of time. This resurrection will transform mortal, perishable bodies into glorified, imperishable ones fit for eternal life (1 Corinthians 15:42-44). It underscores the Christian hope of restoration, not just for individuals, but for all creation, as God makes all things new (Revelation 21:4-5).

And the life everlasting. Amen.

Eternal life with God is the ultimate promise of the Christian faith. This life begins now through a relationship with Christ and will be fully realized in the new heavens and new earth, where believers will dwell with God forever (John 3:16; Revelation 22:1-5). This closing affirmation reflects the joy and confidence of salvation, echoing the trust and hope expressed throughout the Creed.

Conclusion

In the foundational truths expressed in the Apostles Creed, we see Jesus' life and work as central to God's plan for humanity. Each statement in the Creed captures key aspects of our belief in God, and who Jesus is—His divinity, humanity, mission, and ultimate triumph. These truths point to His unique role as the Mediator of the New Covenant. As Mediator He invites us to approach God with confidence, trusting in His perfect sacrifice and ongoing intercession. It calls us to worship Him as the rightful King and to follow His teachings as the ultimate Prophet. Ultimately, the study of Jesus leads to a deeper relationship with Him, transforming us into people who live in the light of His grace and truth.

Understanding who Jesus is and what He has accomplished is the foundation of the Christian faith. The many names, titles, and roles of Jesus illuminate different facets of His character and mission, providing a fuller picture of His love and authority.

Like our study of God, the scriptures are full of various names referring to Jesus. Each name represents a specific aspect of His total character, ministry, and role. These names were given to us to reveal an aspect of Jesus. For your personal study a reference table is included in the Appendix: *Table 12 - Names of Jesus*. Read through these names and study the scripture references.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. Which role of Jesus-Prophet, Priest, or King-resonates most with you at this point in your faith journey? Why?
1. How does the Apostles Creed help you better understand the foundational truths of Jesus' mission and work?
1. Reflect on one of the names of Jesus (e.g., Emmanuel, Lamb of God, Alpha, and Omega). How does this name reveal His character and impact your relationship with Him?
1. Consider Jesus' role as the Mediator of the New Covenant. How does this truth shape your understanding of salvation and your approach to God?
1. In what ways do you see Jesus leading, interceding, or teaching you today? How can you respond to His work in these areas?
1. If someone asked you to explain why Jesus is foundational to your faith, what would you say? How can this understanding strengthen your personal witness?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** What is one name or title of Jesus that has been especially meaningful to you? Why?
1. **Exploring Scripture:** Read Hebrews 1:1-3. How does this passage describe Jesus' role as the ultimate Prophet? How does this apply to us today?
1. **Prophet, Priest, King:** What does it mean for Jesus to fulfill all three roles? How do these roles address humanity's greatest needs?
1. **Our Foundation:** What are practical ways we can build our lives on Jesus as the foundation of our faith? How can this affect our relationships, work, or ministry?
1. **What if:** Why is it important that Jesus fulfills all three roles-Prophet, Priest, and King? What would be incomplete if one of these roles were missing?

Chapter 8 - Holy Spirit-Comforter, Guide, and Power

The Holy Spirit is not a new spirit but is of God and has been with God since the very beginning. In Genesis 1:2 the Spirit of God is hovering on the waters during creation. In Nehemiah 9:20, the scriptures say that it was the Spirit who instructed the people in the wilderness. It was by this same Holy Spirit that God anointed the kings, judges, and prophets in the Old Testament. In Joel 2:28-29 the Spirit is promised to be poured out on all mankind. It was by this same Holy Spirit that God raised Jesus from the dead, and now dwells in us (Romans 8:11). There is only one Holy Spirit, and He has always been the same. How He works with people has looked different at different times, but His heart has never changed.

Jesus gave His disciples, and all of us, the powerful promise of the Holy Spirit.

John 14:16-18 (NKJV)

And I will pray the Father, and He will give you another Helper, that He may abide with you forever—

the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees Him nor knows Him; but you know Him, for He dwells with you and will be in you.

I will not leave you orphans; I will come to you.

While Jesus walked the earth in His physical body, He was limited as we are, His body needed the same things our bodies need: rest, water, food, sleep, etc. This limitation not only impacted Jesus, but impacted His followers, as He could only be in one place at a time. Oftentimes as Jesus traveled, He was pressed about by a huge crowd, they would try to call out to Him and touch Him. Jesus often needed to spend time with His heavenly Father to recharge and pray.

For the work of the Father to be multiplied Jesus needed to raise up disciples, and for them to carry on this work. Jesus knew that a crucial aspect of His ministry on the earth depended upon Him connecting with and abiding with His Father. In fact, Jesus said He could do nothing unless His Father did it through Him and showed Him to do it (John 5:19). God in His wisdom sent His Holy Spirit to dwell within us, to lead us and guide us, empowering us to do the work of the Father.

When was the Holy Spirit Sent to All Believers?

Jesus said:

John 16:7 (NKJV)

Nevertheless I tell you the truth. It is to your advantage that I go away; for if I do not go away, the Helper will not come to you; but if I depart, I will send Him to you.

After Jesus was crucified, His death made it possible for God's Spirit to dwell inside us. Until that point, God's tangible Spirit was mostly contained behind a thick veil in the temple. From time to time, select individuals were chosen by God and anointed (consecrated and set apart for unique service), and received the Holy Spirit upon them. God's anointing and the Spirit upon them, was special, temporary, and conditional. David prayed after his sin with Bathsheba '*Take not your Holy Spirit from me!*' (Psalms 51:11), because David had seen the Spirit lift off King Saul for his acts of disobedience.

We (Mankind) could not receive the Holy Spirit inside us because of our sinful nature, but when Jesus dealt with the sin issue through His sacrifice, it made a way through faith that we might become children and heirs of God (Romans 8:17).

In John 20, after His resurrection, Jesus appears to His disciples in the middle of a locked room and breathes on them saying '*Receive the Holy Spirit*' (John 20:22). The theology is somewhat debated on precisely what occurred at that moment, but most Pentecostal interpretations view this as the disciples receiving the Spirit of God inside them, signifying the new birth, being born-again. This was not, however when they received the Spirit of God upon them, empowering them with boldness for ministry. This was when they received the Holy Spirit within them, allowing them to abide and commune with God. This will be discussed at greater depth later in this chapter as well as the chapters on sanctification and baptism.

Later at the conclusion of the 40-day period between resurrection and ascension (Acts 1:3), Jesus gives the promise of the Holy Spirit:

Acts 1:4-9 (NKJV)

And being assembled together with them, He commanded them not to depart from Jerusalem, but to wait for the Promise of the Father, "which," He said, "you have heard from Me;

for John truly baptized with water, but you shall be baptized with the Holy Spirit not many days from now."

Therefore, when they had come together, they asked Him, saying, "Lord, will You at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?"

And He said to them, "It is not for you to know times or seasons which the Father has put in His own authority.

But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”

Now when He had spoken these things, while they watched, He was taken up, and a cloud received Him out of their sight.

The disciples were to wait for the promise of the Spirit poured out, and that this was to empower them to be witnesses to the ends of the earth. The Holy Spirit is integral to God’s plan for humanity, and is essential to us as believers, for completing our mission, and to the world.

Getting to Know the Holy Spirit

The Holy Spirit is first and foremost, from and of God. The scriptures refer to the Spirit as the Spirit of God, or the Spirit of the Lord, or the Spirit of Christ, while these highlight different aspects, they are all one in the same. The Holy Spirit, being fully God, is also eternal and is holy (blameless, innocent, pure, not profane). Some translations refer to the Holy Spirit as the Holy Ghost.

The word spirit in Greek is **Pneuma** (NYOO-mah - G4151), it means breath, or wind. The Hebrew word for spirit means the same. Breath is significant as we need it in constant supply to live. It was God’s breath that He blew into Adam to bring Him to life, likewise it was Jesus’ breath that He breathed last before He died on the cross. Without breath there is no life. Breath like wind can be felt and experienced but are not as easily observed as other ‘elements’ water, fire, earth.

There are several other core adjectives to describe the Holy Spirit. Each of these adjectives are used in conjunction with ‘the Spirit of’, meaning that these properties are vital to the definition of the Spirit. Example, the *Spirit of Truth* or the *Spirit of Life*.

The Spirit of:

- **Truth** - John 14:17, John 16:13 Refers to the Spirit's role in guiding believers into all truth, revealing God's will and the reality of Christ.
- **Life** - Romans 8:2, Galatians 6:8 Highlights the Spirit's role in imparting spiritual and eternal life to believers, freeing them from the law of sin and death.
- **Grace** - Hebrews 10:29, Zechariah 12:10 Reflects the Spirit's work in dispensing God's favor, forgiveness, and undeserved kindness to humanity.
- **Glory** - 1 Peter 4:14 Indicates the Spirit's role in revealing and manifesting God's glory, particularly in times of suffering and persecution.
- **Adoption** - Romans 8:15, Galatians 4:5 Refers to the Spirit's work in making believers children of God, granting them the status of sons and daughters.
- **Holiness** - Romans 1:4 Points to the Spirit's sanctifying work, setting apart believers for God's purposes.
- **Power** - 2 Timothy 1:7, Acts 1:8 Describes the Spirit's empowerment of believers for boldness, ministry, and the ability to live out their faith effectively.

In all these attributes the Holy Spirit is also properly recognized as the Helper or Comforter. Jesus refers to the Holy Spirit as the coming helper, He uses the Greek word ***Paraklētos*** (pah-RAH-klay-tos - **G3875**), which means advocate, helper, called alongside.

An advocate speaks on another's behalf, like a defense attorney. They intercede and help the person they are charged with.

The helper helps. They help empower the work, but their job is primarily to aid the work. The helper is not solely responsible for performing the work, but they come alongside to help accomplish it.

The Holy Spirit has several distinct purposes and roles in His ministry. His work is inward (in the hearts and lives of believers), upwards (in service and recognition of God), and outwards (to our mission field, the world).

Roles of the Holy Spirit-Inward, Upward, Outward

Inward-The Holy Spirit Unites Us With Jesus

Before Jesus did any miracles or launched His public ministry, He was baptized by John the Baptist and God's Spirit descended upon him, and a voice from heaven proclaimed, 'This is my beloved Son in whom I am well pleased' (Matthew 3:17).

When we accept Jesus by faith, we receive salvation and the seal of the Holy Spirit.

Ephesians 1:13-14 (NKJV)

In Him you also trusted, after you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation; in whom also, having believed, you were sealed with the Holy Spirit of promise,

who is the guarantee of our inheritance until the redemption of the purchased possession, to the praise of His glory.

This seal is not metaphorical but is literal. It serves as a sign of our redemption and is a down payment on the full inheritance we receive as children of God. Romans 8 describes that through the new birth we receive the same exact Spirit of God that raised Christ from the dead in our mortal bodies and we become the literal temple of the Holy Spirit (2 Corinthians 6:16).

This receiving of God's Spirit transforms us, and it causes rivers of living water to flow from us (John 7:38). This renewal is immediate and complete but continues through our entire lives. The river of the Holy Spirit should never stop flowing in our lives!

Through salvation and the indwelling of the Holy Spirit we can abide in Christ and He in us. God's Spirit is no longer stuck on the outside but can dwell deeply with us. We can walk in communion and harmony with God from now through eternal life.

There is much more to say about the inward work of the Holy Spirit and His role on our sanctification, but that will be discussed in the chapter on sanctification.

Upward-The Holy Spirit Testifies of Jesus

The Holy Spirit is from God and is of God. As Jesus said He did nothing except the father show Him (John 5:19), the Holy Spirit too does nothing unless it's directed from the father. Because the Holy Spirit is the helper, He does not work on His own accord, but works in perfect harmony with the father.

The Spirit testifies of Jesus (John 15:26), glorifies Jesus, and announces and declares what Jesus has for us (John 16:14).

The Holy Spirit will testify of Jesus, glorify him, teach, and bring to our remembrance the teaching of Jesus (John 14:26), and guide us into all truth (John 16:13). Jesus told His disciples that He had much more to teach them, but they could not yet bear it, but that the Holy Spirit would guide them into all truth. This is another nuanced point in theology. These teachings that Jesus needed His disciples to know were communicated in several ways. Jesus taught them in person both before his crucifixion, as well as after the resurrection and before His ascension.

Jesus also promised that the Spirit of Truth, that was poured out upon them on the day of Pentecost would lead them into all truth through divine revelation. Is there still divine revelation today? **Certainly yes!** The gifts of the Holy Spirit, including prophecy and words of knowledge and wisdom have not yet ceased! However, no prophecy or word from a spirit is of private interpretation (2 Peter 1:20). This is crucial. Some people will claim in error they are listening to the Holy Spirit, but their actions and words do not testify of Jesus. 1 John 4:3 warns against any Spirit that does not testify of Jesus, saying that spirit is of the antichrist. This bears repeating, if any spirit strays from the teaching of Christ it is not the Holy Spirit, but a profane one!

1 John 4:1 (NKJV)

Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits, whether they are of God; because many false prophets have gone out into the world.

Throughout Scripture, we see examples of claims made in error, often by false prophets or well-meaning individuals who spoke contrary to God's will. For instance, Jeremiah warned against prophets who spoke visions of their own minds, claiming peace while destruction loomed (Jeremiah 23:16-17). Similarly, in Acts 16:16-18, a slave girl's words about Paul and Silas were accurate but inspired by a demonic spirit, not the Holy Spirit. These examples remind us that even words that seem true can originate from ungodly sources.

Every claim of 'God told me!' or a 'new' teaching should be measured against the biblical tests of truth. To discern rightly, we must ask:

- Does this align with Scripture?
- Does this exalt Jesus Christ?
- Does this produce godly fruit?

By applying these tests, we can distinguish the true guidance of the Holy Spirit from errors or deception.

God is in the habit of providing us with ample & abundant wisdom and direction (James 1:5 & Jeremiah 33:3). God's divine wisdom will not violate the scriptures, but they will go beyond the scope of the scriptures. His *entolē* (commandments) are immediate prescriptions to be obeyed, they are *rhema* words (as discussed in the chapter on faith).

This wisdom and understanding and direction are likely not word for word in the scriptures. As an example, the scriptures give great general direction on what to look for in a spouse, but don't give specific prescriptions on the exact person. God does promise to direct our path, lead us into all truth, and we can take comfort knowing that this wisdom and leading from the Holy Spirit will never violate any teaching of scripture.

Outward-The Holy Spirit Empowers the Mission

Jesus gave us His mission, the Great Commission:

Matthew 28:18-20 (NKJV)

And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, "All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth.

Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,

teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age." Amen.

The Holy Spirit has an integral part in the mission, convicting the world of sin, righteousness, and judgement:

John 16:8-11 (NKJV)

And when He has come, He will convict the world of sin, and of righteousness, and of judgment:

of sin, because they do not believe in Me;

of righteousness, because I go to My Father and you see Me no more;

of judgment, because the ruler of this world is judged.

Diving deeper, the Spirit brings conviction of these three truths:

1. **Conviction of sin:** Revealing the reality of human rebellion against God, drawing men's attention to the depravity of their own lives.
1. **Conviction of righteousness:** Demonstrating Jesus' perfect fulfillment of the Father's will, and that Jesus' sacrifice provided the one-time atonement needed for forgiveness of sins.
1. **Conviction of judgment:** Affirming the defeat of Satan, the certainty of God's justice, and that all will stand a judgement for their life's work and deeds.

The Holy Spirit also empowers the mission. The Holy Spirit gives believers the power to be bold witnesses in the face of persecution to share the gospel. Boldness does not mean loudness. It means to have courage despite fear. Power is force, strength, and ability. The Holy Spirit gives the strength and ability to be a witness of the Gospel despite threats and the fear of punishment.

Acts 1:8 (NKJV)

But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

The entire book of Acts is full of stories and accounts that have this general cycle:

1. **Prayer:** Believers ask for boldness and God's intervention.
1. **Empowerment:** The Holy Spirit fills them with courage, power, and guidance.
1. **Proclamation:** They boldly declare the gospel, often with signs and wonders and miracles.
1. **Opposition:** Resistance arises, leading to persecution or challenges. Sometimes believers were martyred, other times imprisoned and or beaten.
1. **Renewal:** The church returns to prayer, seeking fresh empowerment, and the cycle continues.

The New Testament church has largely grown in the face of determined opposition. Around the world the church suffers violence at the hands of oppressors and wicked rules intent to suppress the knowledge of the truth of Jesus.

God knew that this opposition would occur, Jesus prophesied concerning it:

Luke 12:11-12 (NKJV)

“Now when they bring you to the synagogues and magistrates and authorities, do not worry about how or what you should answer, or what you should say.

For the Holy Spirit will teach you in that very hour what you ought to say.”

Do not fear! Jesus promised us that:

Matthew 16:18 (NKJV)

And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it.

This is an amazing and comforting promise. Gates are fixed defensive armaments. When Jesus says that the *gates of hell shall not prevail*, He is painting the picture of a conquering army that knocks down the gates and captures the city!

The Holy Spirit brings supernatural boldness to proclaim the witness of the Gospel in the face of persecution. The outcome of this empowerment can be described, but it's best experienced. It's a supernatural (greater than human) boldness that motivates believers to share. This boldness of preaching is often accompanied by supernatural acts of demonstration of the Spirit and of power (1 Corinthians 2:1-5). People are healed physically and emotionally, the dead raised, those tormented by evil spirits are set free, people with hard hearts turn and repent.

Jesus said these works and greater would we do! (John 14:12). These collective works are supernatural, divine, and desperately needed in a world tearing itself apart, miserable, full of pain, waiting for the mature sons of God to be made clearly manifest! (Romans 8:22-23)

Jesus' chosen instrument for change on the earth is His church, empowered, emboldened, and directed by the Holy Spirit.

Building a Relationship with the Holy Spirit

Every relationship takes time and experience to develop deeply. The Holy Spirit is our advocate, our comforter, our helper, and our guide. He empowers us and sanctifies us.

Start to think of the Holy Spirit as you would a person. In our relationship we can both work to build it or do things that weaken our relationship. He can be

ignored, He can be quenched, He can be blasphemed, or He can be listened to, honored, and obeyed.

Don't ignore the voice of the Holy Spirit. He is always speaking to us and the church. If you don't yet know how to distinguish the voice of the Holy Spirit, it takes time, willingness, and effort (like all healthy and beneficial relationships). But don't worry, you already have built into you all the necessary parts needed to start to develop a personal relationship with the Holy Spirit.

The quickest and most reliable ways to build an effective relationship with the Holy Spirit is to

1. Call out to Him **individually** in prayer, pause and wait for Him to speak.
1. Call out to Him as part of a **group** of people who know Him (the church), pause, and wait for Him to speak.

I use the phrase 'call out' to mean literally, with your mouth, or however you speak (with your hands if you cannot speak aloud with your mouth). Why speak? A few reasons:

1. We are speaking spirits made in God's image. God speaks, and so do we.
1. We use speaking as the primary way to communicate. You can also write down what you want to say (journaling) and speak it aloud.
1. Speaking is an intentional act, and indicates to the party you are talking to, that you'd like to engage them in a conversation.

What should you say?

If you've never talked to God, try introducing yourself. Sure, it will feel a bit weird, but that discomfort is okay and temporary. Along with introducing yourself, tell God that you want to talk to Him and that you want Him to talk back to you.

Consider asking Him a question. It doesn't have to be a deep theological question; it can start simple. Can you show me Your love for me? Why do I have a certain feeling? What would You like to tell me?

Then what?

Well in all effective relationships you speak for a bit, then you pause and listen. God will speak.

God speaks in many ways, but He wants to do it personally, and internally. It will likely not be an audible voice (like if your best friend was to say your name aloud)

but it will be an internal voice that speaks to your heart and mind. Elijah refers to this as the 'still small voice' (1 Kings 19:11-13).

The most common ways that I've personally witnessed God talk to people, and I've been blessed to help dozens of people learn how to talk to God directly, is some combination of the following:

- A knowing - the person talking to God gets an immediate understanding that helps them.
- A picture - also known in the scriptures as a vision or a dream (a vision is when you are awake, a dream is when you are asleep), God will give you a picture in your mind. Perhaps it's a memory, or place you've been or know? Explore the picture, what do you see? What do you feel as a result? What's happening?
- An inner voice - like an audible voice, but one that only you can hear, and spoken into your heart and mind.

What will God say?

Not sure! But that's the fun in it. I can say that He is NOT the spirit of fear, but of perfect love and that it will never violate the teaching of the scriptures. E.g., God will never tell you to commit an extra-marital affair.

Now what?

Keep the dialogue going! It's really that simple.

A few good books I've read and will personally recommend to help you learn to talk to God are:

- *Genuine Christianity* by Larry Low (www.larrylow.com)
- *Good Morning Holy Spirit* by Benny Hinn (www.bennyhinn.org)

Why build a relationship?

The Holy Spirit is the Helper. The Helper helps us! The work goes much more smoothly if we have a shared language, and relationship with Him. Can you imagine trying to work with someone in your job if you had no relationship, did not speak the same language, and couldn't communicate?!

We serve a God who wants to communicate with us. Jesus said that His sheep know His voice (John 10:27), we have built into us all already the natural abilities we need, but we may lack experienced proficiency.

Speaking from personal experience, a personal and active relationship with the Holy Spirit is one of the best things about being a Christian. His presence brings us peace, comfort, and direction, but only if you know how to seek, listen, and obey Him.

Develop a sensitivity with the Holy Spirit. Like many married people over time, you can communicate with your spouse in a unique way and sometimes just through a look. The look alone tells you everything you need to know about what just happened and what's going to happen. Build that type of sensitivity and familiarity with the Holy Spirit. Include Him in your whole life, this is a wonderful part of your relationship with Him that will provide so much depth and richness to your walk of faith.

The Holy Spirit has come to lead us and guide us, to empower us to be God's people, and to see the people of the Earth radically transformed, delivered from the kingdom of darkness into the kingdom of light. Getting to know him, building trust with Him is essential to everyday life and to accomplish the work that Jesus has for us to do.

Our discussion on the work of the Holy Spirit is not finished in this chapter. His work is discussed at length across the remaining chapters of this book, especially the chapters on sanctification and baptism.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. How have you experienced the Holy Spirit as your Comforter, Guide, or source of power? Which role resonates most with your current season of life?
1. Reflect on the difference between the Holy Spirit being “within” (inward work) and “upon” (outward work). How does this distinction impact your understanding of His work in your life?
1. What steps can you take to cultivate a deeper relationship with the Holy Spirit and recognize His voice more clearly?
1. We are to rely on the Holy Spirit's power to step out in boldness and fulfill the mission God has given us. What specific mission and focus has God given you?
1. The Holy Spirit leads us into truth and discernment. Are there areas of your life where you need clarity or wisdom? How can you invite Him to guide you?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** “When you think of the Holy Spirit, what is the first word or image that comes to mind? Why?”
1. **Exploring Scripture:** Read John 14:26. How does the Holy Spirit’s role as Teacher and Helper encourage you in your faith journey?
1. **Holy Spirit Within vs. Upon:** Discuss the difference between the Holy Spirit being “within” for transformation and “upon” for empowerment. Why are both aspects essential for a believer?
1. **Practical Guidance:** What are practical ways we can position ourselves to hear the Holy Spirit’s voice and follow His leading in daily decisions?
1. **Reflection:** Think of a time when you felt empowered by the Holy Spirit to act. How did that experience impact your faith and the people around you?

Chapter 9 - The Church & Our Role in It

The church is how God shows Himself on earth-through His people, doing His work. We are called to be His body, we are His hands and feet to accomplish His work and purpose. Without our efforts the harvest will remain in the field and will go un-reaped.

Who is the Church?

The church, *Ekklesia* (*eh-klee-SEE-ah* - **G1577**), is derived from two Greek words:

- “**Ek**”: “Out of.”
- “**Kaleo**”: “To call.”

Together, **Ekklesia** literally means “called out” or “called out assembly.” In ancient Greek city-states, it referred to a gathering of citizens summoned for a specific purpose, such as legislative or judicial meetings. It was a secular term denoting an assembly of people.

In the New Testament, it is used primarily to refer to the community of believers in Jesus Christ. It can denote:

- **The Local Church:** A specific gathering of believers in a particular location (e.g., the church at Corinth, Philippi, etc.).

1 Corinthians 1:2 (NKJV)

To the church of God which is at Corinth, to those who are sanctified in Christ Jesus, called to be saints, with all who in every place call on the name of Jesus Christ our Lord, both theirs and ours:

- **The Universal Church:** The collective body of all believers across time and space.

Matthew 16:18 (NKJV)

And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it.

The church is the people, not the building or location they meet. **Called-Out Ones:** Reflects the idea that Christians are called out of the world and set apart for God's purposes (e.g., 1 Peter 2:9) for a specific mission and purpose (the great commission). The church is technically any two or more believers meeting together (Matthew 18:20). Typically, the church is organized into regular meetings, with perhaps a set location and time, but wherever two or more people meet in Jesus' name, that's where the church is!

The church was established by Jesus and increased in the 1st century A.D. by the work of the disciples who followed him. The church we have and experience today in all its local bodies across the Earth is a direct result of the original work of Christ and His apostles. As believers we are to be committed to a local church for fellowship, provision, equipping for ministry, and to do good works!

To help us understand what the church is, the Scriptures gives us powerful pictures that show what it's meant to be.

Understanding the Church

There are several core metaphorical images used to depict attributes of the church:

1. The Body
1. The Bride
1. The Temple
1. The Family
1. The Flock
1. The Vine and Branches

Each analogy highlights a unique aspect of the church, yet together, they reveal the church's identity as a unified and diverse community under Christ's leadership.

The Body

The church is often described as **the Body of Christ**, emphasizing both its unity and diversity. With Christ as the head, the church functions as a living organism where every believer plays an essential and potentially diverse role. Each member is uniquely gifted and contributes to the health and mission of the body according to their own function. This image highlights the interdependence of believers, specifically that the body must be connected to function, and that our function is collaborative not competitive. When every part works together, the body grows and thrives in unity and love (1 Corinthians 12:12-27; Ephesians 4:15-16; Colossians 1:18).

The Bride

The church is described as **the Bride of Christ**, this reflects an intimate and loving relationship with Jesus. Just as a bride is cherished and made ready for her husband, the church is sanctified and purified by Christ's sacrificial love. This metaphor captures the devotion and faithfulness expected of the church, as well as the deep affection Christ has for His people. The imagery also points to the ultimate union between Christ and the church, celebrated in the marriage supper of the Lamb, where the church is presented in glory without spot or blemish (Ephesians 5:25-27; Revelation 19:7-9; Revelation 21:2).

The Temple

The church is described as **the Temple of God**, the dwelling place of His Spirit. Believers are described as living stones being built together on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Himself as the cornerstone. This holy structure signifies God's presence among His people and their role as a community of worship and prayer. The temple imagery underscores the importance of holiness and the church's collective purpose in glorifying God (1 Corinthians 3:16-17; Ephesians 2:19-22; 1 Peter 2:4-5).

The Family

The church is described as **the Family of God**, emphasizing relational unity and care among its members. Through the Spirit of adoption, believers are made children of God and members of His household. This familial imagery highlights the love, belonging, and shared inheritance believers have in Christ. It also reflects the call to treat one another with compassion and humility as brothers and sisters in God's family (Galatians 6:10; Ephesians 2:19; Romans 8:15-17).

Furthermore, through the family image it depicts how the members of the church are to become mature, that they would be taught and nourished by spiritual mothers and fathers (1 Timothy 5:1-2), that we could go from infants drinking the pure milk of the Word, to full grown adults able to eat the strong meat of the Word (Hebrews 5).

The Flock

The church is described as **the Flock**, sheep under the care of Jesus, the Good Shepherd. This image conveys the church's dependence on Christ for guidance, sustenance, and protection. It also emphasizes the responsibility of church leaders to faithfully shepherd God's flock as under shepherds, mirroring Christ's example of love and care. The flock imagery speaks to trust, obedience, and the close relationship between the Great Shepherd and His sheep (John 10:14-16; 1 Peter 5:2; Acts 20:28).

The Vine and Branches

The church is described as **the Vine and Branches**, illustrating the essential connection between believers and Christ. Jesus is the true vine, and believers are the branches that must remain in Him to bear fruit. This metaphor highlights dependence on Christ for spiritual vitality, growth, and productivity. Without Him, believers can do nothing, but by abiding in Him, they glorify God and fulfill their purpose. Jesus will prune so that He can bear more fruit in our lives (John 15:1-5).

Roles of the Church

The church's mission, like the Holy Spirit's role, can be understood through three dimensions: upward, inward, and outward, each reflecting a unique aspect of its calling in God's plan. These dimensions guide the church in fulfilling its role as a worshiping, edifying, and missional community.

Upward: Worship and Glorifying God

The church's first purpose is to worship and glorify God. Corporate worship, where believers gather to exalt God together, is a visible reflection of His glory and a response to His greatness. As the psalmist declares, "*Worship the Lord in the splendor of holiness; tremble before him, all the earth*" (Psalms 96:9). Beyond corporate worship, the church is called to live lives of obedience and sacrifice, offering themselves as "living sacrifices" as an act of spiritual worship (Romans 12:1-2). This upward focus keeps the church centered on God's majesty and aligns its priorities with His will.

Inward: Building Up the Body

The Great Commission commands us to *‘teach them to observe’*, this command goes much further than formal teaching methods like this book. Discipleship making (discussed further in the chapter on discipleship) is forming the follower into the likeness of the discipline, like how a parent raises their child. Good parents don’t hand a five-year-old an encyclopedia and challenge them to figure it out! Rather they model, demonstrate, correct, guide, nurture, love, care, and shepherd.

Parents sacrifice for their children because they love them, because they are part of the same body, because they share the same blood. As members of the body and family of Christ, we share the same body, we share the same blood. Communion reminds us through its symbolism that we have been joined to one another through Christ’s sacrifice. The act of communion is to be a point of unity, reminding us that we all have need of redemption, and that salvation is only from God. In this unity we see that no part of the body is greater than another except for our head, Christ.

Outward: Reaching the World

The most well-known part of the church’s mission extends outward to reach the world with the gospel. Jesus’ Great Commission calls His followers to evangelize and make disciples of all nations (Matthew 28:19-20). Empowered by the Holy Spirit, the church is to be His witnesses to the ends of the earth (Acts 1:8).

Jesus is the light of the world (John 8:12). Light shines in all directions outward from the source. His light shines through His manifestations: the Word, His Spirit, and us, His body. We are the light of the world; our lives we are to radiate His light in our darkened worlds and demonstrate good works that glorify God (Matthew 5:14-16). Practically this means the church is called to advocate for justice and mercy, both spiritual and physical. As James says, our pure worship is to care for the vulnerable, the fatherless, the widow (James 1:27).

The Leadership of the Church

Across Christendom there are a wide variety of denominations, meetings, gatherings, and assemblies. There are very few universal rules to the leadership of the church, but the rules we do have are very significant:

1. Jesus is the singular head of the Church. Everyone serves Him (Colossians 1:18).
1. There are high standards for those who lead, they are worthy of double honor, for they will receive double judgement (1 Timothy 5:17).

2.1 They should be mature, not puffed up, responsible (1 Timothy 3:1-13, Titus 1:5-9).

2.2. They must be servants of all (Mark 10:42-45).

2.3. They must commit themselves to the Word and to prayer (Acts 6:4).

2.4. They are responsible for equipping the body for the work of ministry.

1. There are no greater or lesser members of the body. Scriptures supporting this are:

3.1. There should be no partiality between rich and poor (James 2).

3.2. There is no division between Jew and Gentile, slave, or freedman, male or female (Galatians 3:27-28).

The structure of the Church, beyond the leadership rules, is important but much of it is situational and a matter of tradition rather than universally dictated. “That’s the way we’ve always done it!” is a popular statement; if you go back far enough, there was usually a good reason for why they did it that way. This is generally neither good nor bad, but is a matter of taste, needs, and availability.

A useful example of tradition being the foundation for structure is family dinner time. The most important part of family dinner time is that everyone gets fed and that the meal is nourishing. The variations are endless: what they eat, how they eat, how they season their food, etc. The various combinations are generally acceptable and largely a matter of taste and preference.

A church with 10,000 members has different needs and abilities than a church of 50. The pattern setup in the book of Acts and through the New Testament canon was the model of **elders** and **deacons**. While leadership structures can look different between churches and denominations, ultimately this model represents the minimally viable structure of leadership for the church. Let’s take a look at these leadership positions and how they are selected.

Elders (Overseers)

Role and Responsibilities:

- **Spiritual Leadership** - Provide oversight, guidance, and pastoral care for the church (Acts 20:28; 1 Peter 5:2).
- **Teaching and Preaching** - Responsible for teaching sound doctrine and protecting against false teaching (1 Timothy 5:17; Titus 1:9).
- **Shepherding the Flock** - Care for the spiritual needs of the congregation, modeling humility and service (1 Peter 5:2-3).
- **Guarding the Church** - Serve as watchmen, defending the church from false doctrine and division (Acts 20:29-31).
- **Equipping the Saints** - Train and equip believers for works of ministry and discipleship (Ephesians 4:11-12).

Selection Process:

- **Appointed in Every Church** - Elders were appointed by the apostles or their representatives, often through prayer and fasting (Acts 14:23; Titus 1:5).
- **Confirmed by the Holy Spirit** - Their appointment was seen as Spirit-led, recognizing God's calling and gifting (Acts 20:28).
- **Tested and Approved** - Candidates had to demonstrate maturity and faithfulness before being entrusted with leadership (1 Timothy 3:10). They cannot be recent converts! (1 Timothy 3:6)

Deacons (Servants)

Role and Responsibilities:

- **Practical Service** - Focused on meeting physical needs in the church, freeing elders to focus on prayer and teaching (Acts 6:1-4).
- **Support Ministry** - Assist with hospitality, caring for the poor, and administrative tasks (Acts 6:3).
- **Promote Unity** - Address issues of fairness and care to prevent division (Acts 6:1-7).
- **Examples of Faith** - Serve as role models in humility, faith, and service (1 Timothy 3:13).

Selection Process (Acts 6:1-6):

- **Recognized by the Congregation** - Chosen based on their reputation and spiritual character.
- **Approved by Leaders** - Apostles reviewed and commissioned the chosen deacons through prayer and laying on of hands.
- **Confirmed in Service** - Deacons were first tested to prove their faithfulness before being officially appointed (1 Timothy 3:10).

Qualifications for Leadership

Qualifications for Both Elders and Deacons:

- **Moral Character** - Both must be above reproach, dignified, and demonstrate self-control (1 Timothy 3:2, 8).
- **Family Life** - Both must be faithful in marriage (“husband of one wife”) and manage their households well (1 Timothy 3:4-5, 12).
- **Spiritual Maturity** - Both must be tested and proven before appointment (1 Timothy 3:6, 10).
- **Reputation** - Both need a good reputation inside and outside the church (1 Timothy 3:7).
- **Faith and Integrity** - Both must hold to the faith with a clear conscience and live out their beliefs (1 Timothy 3:9).

Example Structures

Using what we’ve learned so far about rules and structures for leadership, let’s look at two examples for church structure found in the New Testament, Jerusalem and Antioch.

Church at Jerusalem

The church at Jerusalem was led primarily by the **apostles**, who focused on teaching, prayer, and spiritual oversight (Acts 2:42, Acts 6:4). As the community grew, the need for administrative structure became apparent, particularly to address practical matters like caring for widows and distributing resources. This led to the appointment of **deacons** (Acts 6:1-7). These individuals, chosen for their spiritual maturity and good reputation, handled practical ministries to allow the apostles to focus on their spiritual responsibilities. Over time, **elders** also emerged as leaders in the Jerusalem church. For instance, during the Jerusalem Council

(Acts 15), both apostles and elders were involved in decision-making, showing a collaborative leadership structure.

Church at Antioch

The church at Antioch had a more decentralized and diverse leadership structure compared to Jerusalem. It was led by a group of **prophets and teachers**, including Barnabas, Saul (Paul), Simeon, Lucius, and Manaen (Acts 13:1). The church at Antioch was also much more oriented towards reaching the gentiles, where the church in Jerusalem reflected more of its Jewish roots. While the New Testament does not explicitly mention deacons in Antioch, it is likely that practical roles existed given the church's growing size and involvement in sending relief to Jerusalem (Acts 11:29-30). The church at Antioch became a model for commissioning missionaries, with leaders praying, fasting, and laying hands on Paul and Barnabas to send them out (Acts 13:2-3). This demonstrates a structure that balanced spiritual oversight (prophets and teachers) with missional outreach and practical support.

Unlike Paul's corrections to the Corinthians and Galatians, the scriptures do not critique the leadership structures of Jerusalem or Antioch. This suggests that these churches, under the guidance of the Holy Spirit, were free to adapt their gatherings to meet their unique needs and circumstances within the framework of sound doctrine and apostolic teaching (Acts 2:42, 2 Timothy 3:16-17).

Throughout these passages certain terms are used that we have not yet defined and studied: *apostle*, *prophet*, *evangelist*. These gifts are part of the fivefold ministry that Jesus gave to the church.

The Fivefold Ministry Gifts

Jesus established five distinct ministry gifts, often referred to as the **fivefold ministry gifts**, to equip believers for service and build up the Body of Christ.

Ephesians 4:11-13 (NKJV)

And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers,

for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ,

till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ;

The five gifts given to equip the saints for the work of the ministry are:

1. **Apostles** - Pioneers and visionaries who establish foundations, plant churches, and advance the Kingdom of God (Ephesians 2:20). Apostles model boldness and faith, demonstrating how to step out into new territories and take spiritual initiative.
1. **Prophets** - Messengers and guides who proclaim God's truth, bringing encouragement, edification, and direction (1 Corinthians 14:3). Prophets inspire faith, call others to align with God's Word, and demonstrate reliance on hearing God's voice.
1. **Evangelists** - Proclaimers of the Gospel who focus on reaching the lost and stirring others to action in sharing Christ (Acts 8:5-8). Evangelists teach disciples how to share their faith effectively, model boldness in witnessing, and inspire compassion for the lost.
1. **Pastors (Shepherds)** - Caretakers and nurturers who protect, guide, and provide spiritual oversight for the church (Acts 20:28). Pastors teach disciples the importance of community, care for others, and accountability within the body of Christ.
1. **Teachers** - Instructors and trainers who clarify doctrine and help believers grow in understanding and application of God's Word (2 Timothy 2:15). Teachers equip disciples to study Scripture deeply, apply it in their daily lives, and effectively teach others.

Leadership Versus Gifting

A commonly misunderstood aspect of leadership in the church is the separation between the authority and responsibility of leadership, and specific giftings.

This confusion is centered on our use of words like teacher, pastor, prophet, apostle, evangelist. These words are gifts. There is not an **office** of 'apostle' in the New Testament church. There are people who do the work of an apostle, who have the gift or calling of apostle. Having the gift of apostle does not give them authority of responsibility.

I am a skilled musician; I have played saxophone for over 20 years. I played through school and college and played semi-professionally for several summers while working with an evangelistic team. Despite me having the skill, gift, and ability to be a saxophonist, I do not have the right to come into your church and stand on the stage with the worship team.

Likewise, there are people gifted in being a pastor/shepherd, but that does not make them 'THE PASTOR' of the local church or make them 'your' pastor. The five-

fold ministry gifts do not lead the church, the leaders (elders and deacons) do. It is very common for leaders to have specific five-fold ministry gifts, but that gift enhances their leadership, it doesn't create it. Likewise, it's common for still-developing people with fivefold giftings to serve and aspire to leadership, but God is first interested in character, then interested in giftings. We are all to become mature, able to discern the word of God, full of the spirit, and doing good works.

Every leader and every gift must first submit to being a disciple, being part of the body.

Jesus gave specific ministry gifts for the equipping of the saints for the work of the ministry. These are different from the motivational gifts (discussed later in this chapter) or manifestation gifts (discussed in the chapter on the baptisms). As disciples grow, the five-fold ministry gifts equip them for ministry, while elders and deacons provide oversight to ensure sound doctrine and practice.

Your Role in the Church

So far in this chapter we've covered the leadership of the church and the core analogies for the church. Let's build upon the specific analogy of *the body* and consider a marathon runner.

You Are a Part of the Whole

The church, as the Body of Christ, depends on every member working together to fulfill its mission. Just as the body cannot function properly if one part is missing, the church needs each believer to actively participate, grow, and serve. Each member of the body has a very important role. To be part of the body means staying connected. A body can survive at diminished capacity without a limb, but the limb itself cannot live when separated from the body. We must be an active part of the church and not become dismembered. Hebrews 10:24 says that we should gather and not forsake the assembly.

To really work and function together you need to fellowship! You need to know others, love others and ideally like others! Build strong relationships and friendships and repair them when they become stressed or injured. When a joint gets injured or inflamed, you need to work to rest and or reset it; so that the joint that's dislodged doesn't become broken! A broken and unhealing limb will eventually be separated, and you cannot be part of the body, alone.

We don't all have the same function. Some of us may share the Gospel from a stage, others around a dinner table. But we are ALL called to be ministers of reconciliation (2 Corinthians 5:18-19). We have all been received into the priesthood of believers (1 Peter 2:9, Revelation 1:6). This means that we're all supposed to be able to do the work of the ministry by the power of the Holy Spirit.

The toes work with the feet, the feet with the ankles, and so on—each part contributing to the overall mission. Marathon runners must train if they want to be able to complete the race. You need to be ready—not just by learning, but by actually practicing what you’ve learned. The church, like a marathon runner, thrives when each member plays their role in unison.

There are a great number of people in your life that only you can possibly reach. The Pastor can’t be the only one trying to shepherd them, and the Evangelist can’t be the only one trying to reach them. God wants to use you to reach unbelievers by the power of His Holy Spirit. We all do the work of the ministry; the Holy Spirit helps us.

You Need Training

Believers must train and equip for their unique roles in the church, just as a runner strengthens specific muscles for the race. You won’t be successful if you jump into a marathon and haven’t trained, and not all training is equal, you need to be adequately prepared for the race. Jesus has given specific ministry gifts to equip believers, not to do all the work themselves, but to empower every member to serve effectively in their unique roles.

Training for a marathon will bring about transformation. You need strength and you need to transform. It’s our responsibility to submit ourselves to God and let him transform us in renewal (Romans 12:1-2). Transformation should lead you to maturity, enabling you to bear your own loads and support others. You should be able to bear MUCH fruit. This will be discussed at length in the chapter on sanctification.

Training is hard, sometimes it’s uncomfortable. Sometimes the transformation you need to go through you’d much rather skip. But if you want to accomplish the goal, you need to stay on the narrow path. At times, you might need warning, comfort, or support—all offered with patience (1 Thessalonians 5:14).

Every great marathon runner has a coach to train them, you will need a trainer to help you. Of course, you have the Holy Spirit, but He often relies on His coaches, the mature men and women of God, in the Body of Christ that you are called to work alongside.

As individuals we need to submit ourselves first and foremost to God and secondly, in this context, to a body of believers. Submission in the church means honoring godly leadership (Hebrews 13:17) and submitting to one another in humility (Ephesians 5:21).

Submission can be difficult, especially when you have experienced broken trust or failed leadership previously. This does not imply blind obedience or control but reflects a spirit of reverence and cooperation. Worldly submission is demanded by

those in authority and can be degrading and lead to resentment. Biblical submission rooted in humility and discernment strengthens the church and fosters accountability. Be willing to listen to guidance and constructive feedback.

Now that we've set a strong foundation - you a meaningful part of the body but need training - let's get down to finding where you fit.

Finding Where You Fit

Finding your role in the church involves seeking God's guidance, understanding your spiritual gifts, and actively engaging with your church community. It is a journey of prayer, exploration, and growth, where you discover how God has uniquely equipped you to contribute to His kingdom. It's very important to note that your role in the church will likely change over time and is not likely to be the same throughout your entire life.

Here's a practical approach to help you find your place, they are presented as a series of steps for clarity, but you will likely repeat the same step multiple times over the course of your walk with God.

Step 1 - Seek God's Guidance Through Prayer and the Word

Start by **seeking God's guidance through prayer**. God is the ultimate source of your purpose and calling (Jeremiah 29:11). Pray regularly for clarity about how you can serve in the church, asking Him to reveal your spiritual gifts and passions. Trust that He will direct your steps as you surrender your plans to His will (Proverbs 3:5-6).

Study the Word of God to deepen your understanding of the church's mission and your role within it. Key passages such as 1 Corinthians 12 and Ephesians 4:11-12 highlight spiritual gifts and the diversity of roles in the Body of Christ. Reflect on examples of individuals in Scripture who discovered and fulfilled their roles, like Paul, Timothy, and Lydia.

Step 2 - Identify Your Gifts, Passions, and Skills

Identifying your **spiritual gifts** is an essential step. You may find taking a spiritual gifts assessment helpful. These gifts are given by God to build up the church. There are several classes of gifts listed in the New Testament:

- **Motivational Gifts** given by God: Romans 12:6-8
 - Discussed after this list.
- **Five-Fold Ministry Gifts** given by Jesus: Ephesians 4:11-13
 - Discussed previously in this chapter.
- **Manifestation Gifts** given by the Holy Spirit: 1 Corinthians 12:8-10
 - Discussed in the chapter on baptism.

The **motivational gifts** reflect how a believer is wired to think, feel, and act. They motivate believers to serve in specific ways that build up the church. Each gift complements the others, ensuring the church operates as a unified body with diverse roles (Romans 12:4-5). They operate as grace-given abilities (Greek: **charis** - *khar'-ece* - **G5463** - *an unearned gift*) meaning that they are given from God, not earned or learned. While the gifts come from God, a person who has a gift can become more proficient in using it.

The motivational gifts are:

1. **Prophecy** - A God-given inclination to boldly declare truth, often with a focus on conviction and righteousness, guiding others to align with God's Word.*
1. **Service (Helps)** - Meets practical needs through acts of service and assistance to support others.
1. **Teaching** - Explains and clarifies truth, helping others understand and apply God's Word.
1. **Exhortation (Encouragement)** - Motivates, encourages, and comforts others to inspire growth and perseverance.
1. **Giving** - Provides resources generously to meet needs and advance God's work without seeking recognition.
1. **Leadership (Administration)** - Organizes and directs others to accomplish goals with vision and efficiency.
1. **Mercy** - Shows compassion and care to comfort and support those who are hurting or in need.

* Prophecy used in the context of Romans is understood to be different than prophecy as a Holy Spirit manifestation gift (1 Corinthians). The Greek word used is the same in both scriptures, but the context is different. For a more in-depth study of the difference, I recommend reading:

- *The Gift of Prophecy* by Kenneth E. Hagin (www.rhema.org)
- *The Gifts and Ministries of the Holy Spirit* by Lester Sumrall

As you identify your gifts, consider your **passions and skills**. God often calls us to serve in areas we're passionate about or skilled in (Exodus 31:2-6). Reflect on what excites you about serving God and others, and think about how your professional skills, hobbies, and life experiences might contribute to ministry.

Seek guidance from **leaders and mentors** who can provide wisdom and insight (Proverbs 15:22). Meet with a pastor or ministry leader to discuss your interests and ask for honest feedback about where you might fit best. Pray about the feedback you receive. Consider joining a discipleship group to receive training and ongoing support.

Step 3 - Be Faithful Now

The parable of the talents (Matthew 25:14-30) reminds us that we need to be faithful in little things to be trusted in great things (Luke 16:10).

Get involved and serve in various ministries to explore where God is calling you. Start small by volunteering in areas of need within your church and in ministries they support. For example:

- Join the hospitality team, children's ministry, or outreach programs. Consider leading a discipleship-oriented group for new believers on this book *Principles of Faith*, using the group discussions questions and end-of-chapter activities to facilitate dialogue.
- Be open to stepping outside your comfort zone to discover new opportunities.
- Observe where God works through you and where you feel most effective.

Practice giving. We can give to the church in many important ways, and we are instructed to do so to accomplish the mission.

- Time - we can give our time and volunteer. When we give our time, we use our efforts and our talents. This can also be a great way to learn new skills and increase existing ones.
- Resources - we can give of our resources. Most commonly today this is probably giving financially to the church and to ministries (not just the "institution", but those in need in the church). Giving money is useful, because the church can buy needed resources with it, but people have given their physical resources beyond money, for example extra homes, clothing, cars, food, building materials, tools, etc. In Acts 4:32-35 we see an example of early believers giving freely, sharing proceeds from sale of extra lands and homes and giving so that 'none had need'.

Working alongside others in ministry can reveal your strengths and deepen your understanding of your role. Engage in small groups or church activities to foster connections. Listen to the burdens and needs of those around you and consider how you can support them. Building relationships within the church helps you connect with others and understand the community's needs.

Step 4 - Get Help!

Jesus said that in life we would experience trouble! (John 16:33) We are encouraged to not carry the weight of our burdens by ourselves but to cast them on God who cares for us! (1 Peter 5:7)

Sometimes in our journey we may become injured. Marathon runners, even when doing “everything right” can stress their bodies to the point of injury, or they can trip and fall.

Not all ‘falling’ is sin related, but some of it is, not all weakness is ‘our fault’, sometimes others will sin against us. Regardless for the cause of our weakness or injury we are to be restored and healed.

There is great freedom in seeking inner healing and restoration. We are called to cover the vulnerable parts of the body (1 Corinthians 12:23) and to restore those caught in trespasses (Galatians 6:1).

There is much to say about this topic, and we explore the themes of healing as an overview in the chapter on sanctification.

Step 5 - Be Patient

Pay attention to confirmation from God and others. Often, God confirms your calling through fruitfulness, joy, and affirmation from those around you. Reflect on where your efforts have borne fruit and listen to feedback about the impact of the ministry. This can help you recognize where you are most effective in serving the Body of Christ.

Be patient and trust God’s timing. Discovering your role may take time and involve trial and error (Philippians 1:6). Trust that God will guide you as you remain faithful and open to His leading. During this time, commit to growth and training by attending workshops, Bible studies, and other resources that equip you for service. Do this with the church, engage with the body of Christ to discover your gifting.

Remember, the church is not a building or an institution; it is a living, breathing body made up of people like you. By stepping into your role, you contribute to its mission and glorify Christ as its head.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does it mean to you personally to be a “called-out one”? How can you live out this identity in your daily life?
1. Which of the biblical images of the church (Body, Bride, Temple, etc.) resonates most with you? Why?
1. Reflect on your role in the Body of Christ. What gifts, talents, or passions has God given you to serve His church?
1. How does being part of a local church strengthen your faith and help you fulfill God’s mission?
1. What steps can you take to foster unity, accountability, and growth in your church community?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** “What is your earliest memory of attending or being part of a church? How has your view of the church changed over time?”
1. **Exploring the Church as the Body of Christ:** Read 1 Corinthians 12:12-27. What does this passage teach us about the church’s unity and diversity? How can we celebrate and honor each other’s differences?
1. **The Church’s Mission:** How does the church fulfill its upward (worship), inward (edification), and outward (evangelism) purposes? Which area do you feel most called to participate in?
1. **Addressing Conflict and Growth:** Hebrews 12:12-17 calls us to strengthen one another and avoid bitterness. How can we handle division or hurt within the church in ways that foster healing and unity?
1. **Finding Your Place:** Think about a time when you felt most connected to your church. What factors contributed to that experience, and how can we create similar experiences for others?

Chapter 10 - Sanctified-Prepared for God’s Purpose

In the previous two chapters we have discussed several important topics. We explored the role and ministry of the Holy Spirit, as well as the role and ministry of the church.

We have a part to play in the church, and while we know that we need training, we also need purification. To really be prepared for God's purposes we must be sanctified.

The definition of **sanctification** is to purify something for a special purpose. This is closely related to the term **consecration** which means to set something aside for a special purpose.

Imagine a master sculptor preparing to work with a large block of marble. The master imagines what this raw and unshaped marble can be transformed into through his careful craftsmanship. He has a very specific design in mind, he orders his assistants to set this block of marble aside for a special design (**consecration**). As he refines and works the marble, adding texture, depth, and shape, he purifies it (**sanctifies**) for that special design. The act of dedicating the marble for his special project was quick, whereas the process of shaping the marble into its final design takes considerable patience.

We were set aside, consecrated to God at salvation. Through the act of purifying our souls by the help of the Spirit we become transformed. This process of purification is what sanctifies us.

When we received Jesus through salvation, we were born-again. We were justified, our sins forgiven. Our spirit was regenerated, we became alive in Christ. We were adopted into the family of God and became the literal temple of the Holy Spirit. Such a marvelous transformation that the scriptures say, *"there is joy before the angels of God over one sinner who repents."* (Luke 15:10).

Receiving Jesus by salvation (**justification**) saves our spirit, cleanses us, and makes us presentable to God, able to receive His Holy Spirit. However, despite such a great salvation **our souls** (our mind, will, and emotions) still **need work!**

Was the work of salvation incomplete? No! The work of salvation is effective but must be continued in the life of the believer by the renewal brought on by the Holy Spirit. This process of renewal and transformation is the work of **sanctification**.

We know there is continued work to be done after conversion because our painful memories didn't resolve, many of our beliefs stayed the same, and many of our habits or rituals didn't vanish. Furthermore, conversion did not separate our minds from their fleshly (carnal) nature.

The word 'carnal' comes from the Latin root meaning 'flesh' or 'meat.' The carnal nature is inside of each of us from birth, like an animal's instincts, it exists to help us survive. The way the carnal nature works is by being self-focused, self-oriented, self-centered. Children are natural examples of a fleshly nature. Despite

their innocence, their nature is focused primarily on their wants, desires, needs; and ‘watch out!’ if you don’t meet its every expectation.

Part of growing up is maturing past our childish ways, but when pressed we very easily resort to a pattern of thinking and living oriented around the self. As James says:

James 4:1 (NKJV)

Where do wars and fights come from among you? Do they not come from your desires for pleasure that war in your members?

Paul explains this carnal nature in more detail in his epistle to the Romans (chapters 6 - 8). He says this carnal nature keeps him doing what he hates and causes him to do evil. He describes this internal conflict as a war between his man-made nature and his God-made spirit.

This conflict between flesh and spirit exists in each of us, and it’s our job to do something about it. If we do not confront our carnal nature, our souls will remain entangled in patterns of spiritual decay, even though our spirits have been redeemed.

Romans 8:6-8 (NKJV)

For to be carnally minded is death, but to be spiritually minded is life and peace.

Because the carnal mind is enmity against God; for it is not subject to the law of God, nor indeed can be.

So then, those who are in the flesh cannot please God.

These words of Paul are both a warning and a promise to us. Even though we’ve been born again, we still have a fleshly mind that needs to be brought into submission to the knowledge of Christ. As we do so, we walk in God’s life and peace.

Take courage, there is hope for us! We must walk after the Spirit and be led by the Spirit of God. In doing so, we will not walk after the flesh.

Romans 8:1,13,14 (NKJV)

There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus, who do not walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit.

For if you live according to the flesh you will die; but if by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body, you will live.

For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, these are sons of God.

How do we learn to walk in the Spirit? Is it *just a conscious choice*? We learn to walk in the Spirit the same way we learn to walk in the natural. We are motivated to move and grow, so we wrestle, struggle, crawl, totter, till we can stand on our own feet. Our natural parents can't walk for us, but they can support, encourage, help, and enable us in our walk.

Likewise, God cannot walk out our faith for us. He will teach us, but we must put in the effort. As Paul said to the Philippians:

Philippians 2:12-13 (NKJV)

Therefore, my beloved, as you have always obeyed, not as in my presence only, but now much more in my absence, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling;

for it is God who works in you both to will and to do for His good pleasure.

We must work out our own salvation. That doesn't mean that we climb atop a wooden cross and are physically crucified, but we do have to crucify our fleshly nature (Galatians 5:24). God promises that He will work in us and help us, but we must make a choice to walk this out, and we must stick to it.

It's true to say that 'we' are dealing with our fleshly nature, but it's also true to say that 'God' is dealing with it. The work of the cross (justification) was difficult for Jesus, He had to sacrifice His life for ours, but easy for us, it's a free gift. The work of the spirit (sanctification) is easy for God, He walks in perfect truth and is willing and desirous to abide with us, but is difficult for us, because we must crucify our old nature, and our nature isn't very interested in being crucified.

This process is collaborative. God helps, aids, guides, directs, and corrects. We listen, obey, follow, and respond. The result is growth and transformation. This is the pruning that Jesus said God would do in us. Jesus is the vine, His father the vinedresser, we are the branches:

John 15:1-4 (NKJV)

"I am the true vine, and My Father is the vinedresser.

Every branch in Me that does not bear fruit He takes away; and every branch that bears fruit He prunes, that it may bear more fruit.

You are already clean because of the word which I have spoken to you.

Abide in Me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, unless it abides in the vine, neither can you, unless you abide in Me.

Pruning is incredibly healthy for a plant. Thinking back to our chapter on repentance, we are called to turn away from dead works (those works that are no longer bearing fruit) and turn toward God. The result of this turning away from the dead places in our life, and towards God, empowers the great gardener of our life to prune branches, improve growth, and produce greater spiritual fruit (John 15:2).

While pruning can feel painful, it reflects God's loving care as He shapes us into vessels for His purpose (Hebrews 12:11). Some may feel a sense of loss, even fear, when undergoing the pruning process. However, God is gentle, and even a bruised reed He will not break (Isaiah 42:3). Grapevines are pruned during their dormant season to minimize stress on the plant. The gardener tending the growth will cut back old and woody growth that no longer produces fruit like it used to, this allows the vine to direct energy into the branches with the most potential for good fruit.

Like a gardener trimming branches to direct growth, God may allow seasons of correction and discipline to refine our faith and character, but His work is patient and kind. God prunes those who abide in him. Our focus is to be more on the abiding in Christ, and less on the work of the pruning.

Hebrews 12:11 reminds us that pruning *"yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness"* to those who are trained by it.

How are we trained by righteousness? By being transformed through the renewal of our minds.

Romans 12:1-2 (NKJV)

I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service.

And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, that you may prove what is that good and acceptable and perfect will of God.

Paul lays out two simple requirements for transformation:

1. Present your bodies to God as a living sacrifice. A **living** sacrifice doesn't physically die during the sacrifice, but since a living sacrifice cannot die, you must continually bring it to the altar!

2. Renew your mind! Renewal, based on the Greek word: **Anakainōsis** (*An-ak-ah'-ee-no-sis* - **G342**) means a renewal or renovation, focusing on a continual process of inner change and growth.

This renewal brings about transformation. Transformation is based on the Greek word: **Metamorphoō** (*met-am-or-fo'-o* - **G3339**) means to change into another form; to transform or transfigure, emphasizing a complete change. Metamorphoō is where we get the English word metamorphosis, which is the process caterpillars undergo to become butterflies.

God wants to fundamentally transform our minds and our pattern of thinking. His desire is for us not to be conformed to the way of the world, but that we will know what is good (beneficial), pleasing (acceptable), and the perfect (complete & lacking nothing) will of God.

The requirements for transformation are really that simple, **though it takes discipline!**

Our fight against the flesh will not be won by our flesh, but rather by God's equipping for the battle of the mind. His words (the sword of truth) are mighty to correct every imagination, haughty thought, and to bring into arrest (captivity) every thought that goes against obeying God.

2 Corinthians 10:3-6 (NKJV)

For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war according to the flesh.

For the weapons of our warfare are not carnal but mighty in God for pulling down strongholds,

casting down arguments and every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, bringing every thought into captivity to the obedience of Christ,

and being ready to punish all disobedience when your obedience is fulfilled.

When the authorities arrest some, they place them in shackles and put them in a jail cell. If that person escapes custody, they don't turn a blind eye, they will use incredible resources and not rest until that person has been brought back under control. We too should act with such zeal in the contest for our minds!

We are renewed by obedience and experience with truth. Jesus said if we continued in His words, we would be His disciples, experience (know) truth, and that would make us free (John 8:31-32)!

The experience of truth is different than the knowledge of truth. Experience is the Greek word **Ginōskō** (*Ghin-ocē'-ko* - **G1097**) it means to know through personal experience or intimate understanding; implies progressive learning.

It is not our academic knowledge of truth that transforms us and renews our minds, it is our personal experience of truth. We are sanctified by His truth! (John 17:17).

How to Renew Your Mind

Renewing our minds is not a one-size-fits-all process-it depends on which part of the mind we're talking about! God designed our minds with incredible complexity, including several different memory systems, each serving a specific purpose. Some operate automatically in the background, while others require focused, intentional thought. These systems are gifts from God to help us survive, grow, and thrive, but they can also lead us astray when misused or left unrenewed. Understanding how these systems work gives us insight into how to cooperate with God's process of transformation.

In the next section I will describe each of the memory systems, their purpose and function, some practical steps to renewing this aspect of your mind, as well as resources for continued practice and study.

Memory Systems and How to Renew Them

1. Explicit Memory (Declarative Memory)

Purpose: Stores facts, events, and experiences that we can consciously recall. It's split into two types-**semantic** and **episodic** memory.

Semantic Memory - Facts and Knowledge. Semantic memory is where we store facts, definitions, and general knowledge-things like historical dates, Bible verses, and practical information. It helps us predict outcomes, make decisions, and avoid danger (e.g., recognizing poisonous plants). While it gives us stability and order, it can also lead to rigidity-an over-reliance on rules rather than adapting to unexpected situations.

How to Renew It:

- **Study Scripture** to shape our worldview (Psalms 119:105).
- **Memorize truths** and doctrines to stand firm in faith (Colossians 3:16).
- **Read Christian books** like *“Renewing the Mind”* by Casey Treat or *“Battlefield of the Mind”* by Joyce Meyer to develop godly thinking patterns.

Episodic Memory - Personal Experiences. Episodic memory stores our personal experiences, tying them to specific times and places-like a wedding day or a traumatic event. These memories provide context, helping us learn from the past and build relationships. However, episodic memory is prone to emotional bias

and distortion. Past trauma can create fearful associations, making it difficult to move forward.

How to Renew It:

- **Reflect and confess** to bring hidden pain into God's light (1 John 1:9).
- **Reframe past experiences** through the lens of God's grace (Romans 8:28).
- **Seek inner healing** through prayer and counseling ("*Your Pain is Showing*" by Larry F. Low, "*The Bondage Breaker*" by Neil T. Anderson, "*Emotionally Healthy Spirituality*" by Peter Scazzero).

2. Implicit Memory (Non-Declarative Memory)

Purpose: Unconscious memory used for habits, skills, and emotional associations. It operates automatically, helping us respond quickly to situations. It's divided into **procedural memory** and **emotional conditioning**.

Procedural Memory - Skills and Habits. Procedural memory allows us to perform tasks without thinking-like driving, typing, or playing an instrument. It's efficient, saving us mental energy and time. However, bad habits and negative patterns can also become deeply ingrained and hard to break.

How to Renew It:

- **Practice spiritual disciplines** like prayer and fasting to build godly habits (Hebrews 5:14).
- **Train in godliness** through repetition and obedience (1 Timothy 4:7).
- **Read books like** "*Atomic Habits*" by James Clear (practical) and "*Spiritual Disciplines for the Christian Life*" by Donald Whitney (biblical) to establish habits that honor God.

Emotional Conditioning - Emotional Associations. Emotional conditioning links sensory cues (like smells or sounds) to feelings, triggering responses before we consciously process them. This system protects us but can also cause irrational fears or emotional reactions when past experiences are negative.

How to Renew It:

- **Pray for healing** from past wounds (Isaiah 41:10).
- **Practice forgiveness** and release bitterness (Ephesians 4:31-32).
- **Replace fear with God's promises** (2 Timothy 1:7).
- **Seek guidance from books like** *"Your Pain is Showing"* by Larry F. Low, *"The Bondage Breaker"* by Neil T. Anderson, *"Soul Care"* by Rob Reimer for overcoming emotional triggers.

3. Working Memory (Short-Term Memory)

Purpose: Provides temporary storage for problem-solving and decision-making. It helps us focus, hold information briefly, and process tasks-like remembering instructions or making quick decisions. While it's powerful, it's also limited, prone to distraction, and easily overloaded, especially under stress.

How to Renew It:

- **Focus and meditate** on God's Word daily (Psalms 1:2).
- **Renew your thoughts** through intentional thinking (Romans 12:2).
- **Practice mindfulness** and simplify mental clutter (*"Habits of Grace"* by David Mathis).
- **Read** *"The Celebration of Discipline"* by Richard Foster to sharpen focus through spiritual disciplines.

Conclusion

Renewing the mind isn't a quick fix-it's a process of gradual transformation that is lifelong. Each memory system plays a role in shaping how we think, feel, and act. By intentionally working with the Holy Spirit, applying Scripture, and developing godly habits, we can train our minds to align with God's truth. Whether addressing past wounds, learning new habits, or staying focused in the moment, God has provided both **spiritual tools** and **practical wisdom** to help us walk in renewal and freedom (2 Corinthians 10:5).

Our world is full of trouble, tribulation, and trial. Through the disciplined renewing of the mind, our souls become transformed, and we can live a life of freedom unto God full of the fruit of His Spirit (Galatians 5:22-25).

Acknowledgements

The description of the memory systems contained in this chapter is borrowed from the study of psychology: <https://www.psypost.org/implicit-vs-explicit-memory-definition-examples-history/>. The how-to-renew section comes from a combination of sources: the books referenced in this section, several of which I've read, and the rest come highly recommended by practitioners in the field, my own life experience of renewing my mind, and several years of experience as a pastor helping people personally grow through painful spots in their lives. Special thanks to Larry Low (www.larrylow.com) for all his help in teaching me to renew my mind and help others how to do so!

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does sanctification mean to you personally? How do you see it playing out in your daily life?
1. Think about a time when God “pruned” an area of your life. What was the result of this process, and how did it draw you closer to Him?
1. Reflect on the idea of “renewing your mind.” What specific thought patterns or habits might God be calling you to surrender or transform?
1. How does seeing sanctification as a partnership with the Holy Spirit encourage you during difficult or slow seasons of growth?
1. How can you intentionally make space for the Holy Spirit to work in your daily life? What might you need to let go of to do this?
1. Where do you need renewal today? Start by identifying the areas where your mind feels stuck and trust that God will finish the good work He began in you (Philippians 1:6).

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** “What’s one area of your life where you’ve experienced noticeable growth since coming to faith in Christ?”
1. **Exploring Scripture:** Read John 15:1-5. How does the image of pruning and bearing fruit help us understand sanctification?
1. **Renewing the Mind:** Discuss Romans 12:2. What does it mean to “renew your mind,” and how does this relate to sanctification?
1. **The Role of the Holy Spirit:** How does the Holy Spirit empower and guide us in the process of sanctification? How can we become more attuned to His leading?
1. **Encouragement in the Journey:** What would you say to someone who feels discouraged by the pace of sanctification? How can we encourage one another in this journey?

Chapter 11 - Baptisms-Water and Spirit

Baptism in our modern age, separated from the Jewish roots, is typically only thought of in terms of water baptism, and the Holy Spirit baptism (Pentecost).

The book of Hebrews was written to a Jewish audience. The overwhelming majority of Christians in our modern age do not have Jewish roots or heritage. Without the Jewish roots and culture many of us do not have the cultural context for things that 1st century messianic Jews (those Jewish believers professing Jesus) would have shared. As we were not raised in the Jewish tradition we don’t typically know much about the feasts, fasts, prayers, washings, rites, and rituals that Jewish believers would know.

The word for baptisms, or washings, in the Greek is: **Baptismos** (bap-tis-mos’ - **G909**) - The act of dipping or washing. Refers to ceremonial washings or ritual cleansing. It can indicate immersion, purification rites, or washings practiced in Jewish and Christian contexts.

Baptisms is one of the foundational doctrines mentioned in Hebrews:

Hebrews 6:1-2 (NKJV)

Therefore, leaving the discussion of the elementary principles of Christ, let us go on to perfection, not laying again the foundation of repentance from dead works and of faith toward God,

of the doctrine of baptisms, of laying on of hands, of resurrection of the dead, and of eternal judgment.

Old Covenant Washings - Historical Context

In the Old Covenant, ceremonial washings played a central role in maintaining ritual purity and symbolizing holiness before God. These washings were prescribed in the Law of Moses and applied both to the priests who served in the Tabernacle and to the people of Israel. For example, priests were required to wash their hands and feet at the bronze basin before entering the Tabernacle or approaching the altar, symbolizing their readiness to serve in the presence of a holy God (Exodus 30:18-21). Similarly, rituals for cleansing individuals from defilement, such as contact with a dead body or skin diseases, involved washing with water as a sign of restoration to purity (Leviticus 14:8; Numbers 19:17-19). These acts served as outward demonstrations of an inward desire for holiness, emphasizing the importance of being set apart for God.

The ceremonial washings in the Old Testament required regular repetition to maintain ritual purity. Unlike permanent solutions, these rituals only provided temporary external cleansing, leaving the deeper issue of sin unresolved. The writer of Hebrews highlights this limitation, explaining that these practices were “symbolic for the present time,” unable to clear the conscience of the worshiper (Hebrews 9:9-10). These washings acted as constant reminders of human imperfection and the need for something greater—an ultimate purification that could cleanse not just the body, but the heart and soul as well.

The ceremonial washings of the Old Covenant find their fulfillment in Christ, who provides complete and eternal cleansing through His sacrifice. Unlike the temporary rituals of the law, Christ’s blood purifies fully, cleansing not just the flesh but also the conscience (Hebrews 9:13-14). Through His death and resurrection, Jesus accomplished what the Old Testament rituals could only foreshadow—true reconciliation with God. Hebrews 10:22 calls believers to “draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith, having our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water.” This language ties Christ’s work to the imagery of Old Testament washings while showing its far superior efficacy. His sacrifice does not merely cover sin but removes it completely (1 John 1:7). In this way, the ceremonial washings served as a shadow, pointing to the deeper cleansing that only Christ could provide, fulfilling humanity’s need for holiness through divine intervention.

To reiterate this point, Christians are under no obligation to perform any ceremonial washing. Washings did not provide salvation under the old covenant and do not provide salvation in the new covenant. Ceremonial washing will not increase our standing with God, nor gain us favor. Paul strongly condemns the Judaizers of Galatia (read Galatians) who tried to mix in requirements of the Jewish context as necessary for salvation (e.g., circumcision). Salvation is by faith in Jesus alone!

John's Baptism

In the New Testament canon there are several baptisms mentioned. We've already discussed the baptisms and washings of the Jewish tradition.

John the Baptist's ministry centered on preparing the way for the coming of Jesus Christ. His baptism, described as a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins (Mark 1:4), called people to confess their sins, turn their hearts back to God, and prepare for the arrival of the Messiah. It served as an outward sign of inward repentance, symbolizing a desire for spiritual cleansing and readiness for the kingdom of God. John's baptism, however, was temporary and preparatory—it pointed forward to the greater work that Christ would accomplish. While John's baptism focused on repentance, it did not provide complete forgiveness or spiritual regeneration, as it lacked the indwelling and empowerment of the Holy Spirit (Matthew 3:11-12). Instead, John openly declared that one greater than He was coming, who would baptize not only with water but with the Holy Spirit and fire (Luke 3:16).

John's baptism was fulfilled and surpassed through the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ. Christian baptism, instituted by Jesus and practiced by the apostles, signifies a deeper reality—union with Christ, death to sin, and resurrection to new life (Romans 6:3-4). Unlike John's baptism, Christian baptism is directly connected to faith in Jesus' atoning sacrifice and the indwelling of the Holy Spirit (Acts 2:38). The arrival of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost marked the new covenant and the beginning of Spirit-empowered living, which John's baptism could not provide. Because of this, John's baptism is no longer practiced, as it has been replaced by the baptism commanded by Christ (Matthew 28:19), which incorporates repentance, faith, and the sealing of believers by the Holy Spirit (Ephesians 1:13-14).

Christ's Baptism

Christ's baptism set a powerful example for His followers and established the foundation for the Christian practice of water baptism. Though Jesus was without sin, He submitted to baptism by John to "fulfill all righteousness" (Matthew 3:15). In doing so, He identified with humanity's need for repentance and pointed

forward to His own death, burial, and resurrection. At His baptism, the Holy Spirit descended like a dove, and the Father declared, “This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased” (Matthew 3:16-17). This moment marked the beginning of Jesus’ public ministry and revealed the unity of the Father, Son, and Spirit, foreshadowing the spiritual transformation believers would experience through faith in Christ.

Jesus later commanded His followers to be baptized, commissioning them to “go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit” (Matthew 28:19). Water baptism, as instituted by Christ, became an **act of obedience** and a **public declaration of faith** for believers. It represents their identification with Jesus’ death, burial, and resurrection (Romans 6:3-4). Going under the water symbolizes dying to sin, and coming up out of the water illustrates rising to new life in Christ (Colossians 2:12). Yet, it is crucial to clarify that this outward act is not the source of salvation but a **visible sign** of the **inner work of grace** already accomplished by the blood of Jesus.

Water baptism is a **symbol** of the cleansing power of Christ’s blood and the renewal of the Holy Spirit (Ephesians 5:26; Titus 3:5). It signifies repentance, faith, and a commitment to follow Jesus. It is an outward testimony of an inward transformation—a way for believers to publicly declare their allegiance to Christ and their participation in the body of Christ, the Church (Acts 2:41). While it is commanded by Jesus and modeled in the early Church, it does not **save** a person. Salvation is by grace through faith alone (Ephesians 2:8-9), and the true cleansing occurs spiritually through the blood of Christ (Revelation 1:5). Water baptism is a response to that salvation, an act of obedience rather than a requirement for it.

In the New Testament, water baptism is consistently tied to **repentance and faith** (Acts 2:38; Mark 16:16), both of which require a personal decision to follow Christ—something infants are not capable of making. Baptism symbolizes a believer’s deliberate identification with Christ’s death, burial, and resurrection (Romans 6:3-4), as well as their commitment to live in obedience to Him. Some denominations (e.g., Catholics, Lutherans) practice infant baptism as a covenantal sign akin to circumcision, however because infants cannot express personal faith or repentance, the practice of **infant baptism** does not align with the biblical model of **believer’s baptism**. Instead, many churches practice **dedication ceremonies** for infants, following the example of Hannah dedicating Samuel to the Lord (1 Samuel 1:27-28) and Mary and Joseph presenting Jesus at the temple (Luke 2:22). Dedication is not a substitute for baptism but rather a commitment by parents to raise their child in the faith, teaching them God’s Word, and modeling a godly life until the child is old enough to make their own decision to follow Christ and be baptized.

Unlike the **ceremonial washings** of the Old Covenant, which required repeated rituals for purification, Christian baptism is a one-time event that reflects a completed work of grace. Old Testament washings symbolized external cleansing and foreshadowed the deeper spiritual cleansing that comes through Christ. In contrast, New Testament baptism symbolizes the inward renewal and rebirth accomplished by the Holy Spirit (Titus 3:5). It points to the believer's participation in the new covenant, where cleansing from sin is permanent and based on Christ's finished work.

Water baptism is closely tied to the **promise of the Holy Spirit**. In Acts 2:38, Peter calls people to repent, be baptized, and receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. While water baptism publicly signifies the believer's repentance and faith, the true baptism occurs inwardly when the Holy Spirit washes, regenerates, and seals the believer (1 Corinthians 12:13). This spiritual washing makes us members of Christ's body and empowers us to live holy lives. The **Holy Spirit's role** in baptism reminds us that salvation is not accomplished through rituals but through God's transforming power.

It is important to distinguish between the **symbolic act of water baptism** and the spiritual reality of salvation through Christ's blood. The Bible clearly teaches that salvation is based on faith in Jesus (Romans 10:9-10) and not on works, including baptism (Ephesians 2:8-9). However, water baptism is an **act of obedience** that publicly identifies the believer with Christ and the Church. It demonstrates an outward commitment to live as a disciple of Jesus, but it does not add to or complete the work of salvation.

Christ's water baptism set an example for believers to follow, demonstrating humility, obedience, and preparation for ministry. For Christians today, water baptism serves as a public declaration of faith, symbolizing death to sin and resurrection to new life. While it is a command of Jesus and an important step of obedience, it is not required for salvation. True cleansing occurs through faith in the blood of Jesus, and the empowerment of Christian living comes through the Holy Spirit's work in the believer. Baptism unites us with Christ and His Church, reminding us of the inward transformation and renewal that God has already accomplished.

Having established water baptism as an outward sign of faith, we now turn to the baptism of the Holy Spirit, which empowers believers for ministry and service.

Holy Spirit Baptism

The baptism in the Holy Spirit is a profound and transformative experience promised by God to empower believers for ministry, service, and holy living. Every believer receives the Holy Spirit when they're born again-this is how we're

made spiritually alive. But later, we should also receive the baptism in the Holy Spirit, which empowers us for boldness, spiritual gifts, and effective ministry.

Water baptism is a public declaration of faith and symbolizes the cleansing of sin through Christ's blood, Spirit baptism represents the empowering presence of God in the believer's life. Together, these two modes of baptism form complementary aspects of the Christian walk—one as an outward sign of obedience and the other as an inward source of power and renewal. The baptism of the Holy Spirit is the Spirit upon us rather than within. At salvation all believers receive the Spirit within them, but when the Spirit of God comes upon them, they receive power and boldness for ministry.

The baptism in the Holy Spirit was foretold by John the Baptist, who declared,

Matthew 3:11 (NKJV)

I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance, but He who is coming after me is mightier than I, whose sandals I am not worthy to carry. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire.

This promise pointed to a greater work that Jesus would accomplish after His resurrection—sending the Holy Spirit to dwell within and empower His followers. Jesus confirmed this when He instructed His disciples to wait for the gift of the Spirit, explaining that they would receive power to be His witnesses (Acts 1:8). The fulfillment of this promise occurred on the day of Pentecost, when the disciples were filled with the Holy Spirit, evidenced by speaking in tongues, prophecy, and boldness to proclaim the gospel (Acts 2:1-4).

This outpouring marked the beginning of the **Church Age** and demonstrated that the Spirit's power was now available to all believers. This promise wasn't limited to the apostles but extends to all who believe, as Peter declared, *"The promise is for you and your children and for all who are far off—for all whom the Lord our God will call"* (Acts 2:39).

Spirit Within vs Spirit Upon

When someone puts their faith in Jesus, the Holy Spirit gives them new life on the inside. That's what it means to be born again (**regenerated**). At that moment of faith, the Holy Spirit indwells **WITHIN** the believer, making them spiritually alive and adopting them into the family of God (John 3:5-6; Titus 3:5). This is the new birth or being born again, as Jesus described in John 3.

Scriptural Basis:

- *Titus 3:5* - “He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit.”
- *Ephesians 1:13-14* - The Holy Spirit seals believers as a **guarantee** of their inheritance.
- *Romans 8:9* - “Anyone who does not have the Spirit of Christ does not belong to him.”

This work of regeneration is universal for all believers at salvation and establishes a permanent indwelling of the Spirit. It is not dependent on any outward action, such as water baptism, and guarantees salvation by grace through faith.

In contrast, the baptism in the Holy Spirit is a separate and subsequent experience that equips believers with power for service and witness (Acts 1:8). While regeneration deals with new life and identity, Spirit baptism focuses on empowerment **UPON** and the release of spiritual gifts. This baptism is often accompanied by signs and manifestations of Holy Spirit gifts.

Scriptural Basis:

Acts 1:8 (NKJV)

But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”

- *Acts 8:15-17* - The Samaritans had believed and were baptized, but they later received the Holy Spirit through prayer and the laying on of hands.
- *Acts 19:6* - Disciples in Ephesus, already believers, received the Holy Spirit when Paul laid hands on them.

The baptism of the Holy Spirit does not replace regeneration but builds upon it, equipping the believer for spiritual service and boldness in ministry. Being baptized in the Holy Spirit is a free gift to those who are saved, not a requirement to be saved. It is not a requirement that someone manifest a specific gift of the Holy Spirit to prove their ‘baptism’ in the Holy Spirit, but we should expect that the Holy Spirit baptism shows up the same way today as it did in the book of Acts, with signs and boldness accompanying! Some people err in thinking if a person doesn’t speak in tongues that they are not saved, or that they do not have the Holy Spirit baptism. Not everyone will receive every gift or manifestation of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 12:29-31).

How to Receive the Baptism of the Holy Spirit

The baptism of the Holy Spirit is described in Scripture as a gift that is promised to believers and is received by faith. It is separate from salvation and is primarily for empowerment and witness (Acts 1:8). The baptism of the Holy Spirit is a gift of empowerment for believers, promised by Jesus and fulfilled at Pentecost. It is received through repentance, faith, and asking God. While laying on of hands is often used as a method, it is ultimately God who baptizes with the Spirit.

Scripture presents speaking in tongues and prophecy as a common sign, but the purpose of this baptism is far greater-providing boldness, power, and spiritual gifts for ministry. Every believer is encouraged to seek this experience as part of their spiritual journey, trusting that God will equip them for His work.

The Bible outlines several core principles regarding how this baptism is received:

1. The Baptism of the Holy Spirit is a free Gift from God

The baptism of the Holy Spirit is not something believers can earn-it is a free gift given by God. God wants to give good gifts to His children and is eager to give the Holy Spirit to those who ask with faith and a desire for empowerment.

Luke 11:13 (NKJV)

If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask Him!"

Acts 2:38-39 (NKJV)

Then Peter said to them, "Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.

For the promise is to you and to your children, and to all who are afar off, as many as the Lord our God will call."

2. Ask, Seek, and Receive by Faith

Scripture emphasizes that the baptism in the Holy Spirit is received through asking in prayer and faith-filled expectation. Faith, combined with a willingness to ask and receive, is the key to experiencing Spirit baptism. If you are not sure if God wants to give you the baptism of the Holy Spirit, ask Him about it, He is a good father! As He prompts you, you may feel a tangible presence of God in your body that you've never experienced before. It's okay if you don't! God is a big God,

and He doesn't need to be boxed into one perfect formula. If you feel God tugging at your heart, yield to him!

- **Acts 8:15-17** - Peter and John prayed and **laid hands** on believers, and they **received the Holy Spirit**.
- **Acts 10:44-46** - Cornelius and his household **received the Holy Spirit** while Peter was preaching-without hands being laid on them-showing that it is ultimately **God who baptizes**.

Galatians 3:2 (NKJV)

This only I want to learn from you: Did you receive the Spirit by the works of the law, or by the hearing of faith?—

3. Laying on of Hands (Optional)

While some received the Holy Spirit spontaneously (Acts 10:44), others received through the **laying on of hands** by other believers. Laying on of hands is a biblical pattern, but not a requirement. The Holy Spirit ultimately responds to faith, not rituals.

Acts 8:17 (NKJV)

Then they laid hands on them, and they received the Holy Spirit.

Acts 19:6 (NKJV)

And when Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon them, and they spoke with tongues and prophesied.

The Gifts of the Holy Spirit

When the Holy Spirit was poured out, and people baptized in the Holy Spirit, oftentimes manifestations of the Holy Spirit accompanied it.

There are several lists of gifts in the New Testament:

- Motivational Gifts given by God: Romans 12:6-8
 - Discussed in the chapter on the Church.
- Five-Fold Ministry Gifts given by Jesus: Ephesians 4:11-13
 - Discussed in the chapter on the church.
- Manifestation Gifts given by the Holy Spirit: 1 Corinthians 12:8-10
 - Discussed here.

Each set of these gifts are given for different purposes, and operate differently, but they collectively point to the **diversity** and **unity** of gifts within the **Body of Christ**. Each gift has a unique role in fulfilling God's purposes.

Purpose & Operations of the Gifts

The primary purpose of the gifts of the Holy Spirit is to build up the Body of Christ and bring glory to God:

- **Edification** - Strengthening and encouraging believers (1 Corinthians 14:3).
- **Unity** - Promoting harmony and cooperation within the church (Ephesians 4:12-13).
- **Evangelism** - Demonstrating God's power as a witness to unbelievers (Acts 2:43; Acts 8:6-7).
- **Service** - Meeting the needs of others through acts of mercy and generosity (Romans 12:6-8).

These gifts are not for personal glory but for the common good (1 Corinthians 12:7). They function best when exercised in love and humility, reflecting the character of Christ (1 Corinthians 13).

Paul emphasized that spiritual gifts must be exercised decently and in order (1 Corinthians 14:40). This ensures that the use of gifts promotes unity, peace, and understanding, rather than confusion or division.

- Prophecies should be evaluated (1 Corinthians 14:29).
- When giving a message in tongues to the body, pray that it be interpreted (1 Corinthians 14:27-28).
- Gifts must always bring **edification** to the church (1 Corinthians 14:12).

This order does not quench the Spirit but ensures that the gifts operate in ways that **honor God** and **benefit others**.

The operation of spiritual gifts must always be grounded in love. Paul dedicates an entire chapter (1 Corinthians 13) to explaining that without love, even the greatest spiritual gifts are meaningless. Love provides the motivation and framework for using gifts in ways that build up others rather than tearing them down.

Additionally, the gifts operate **as the Spirit wills** (1 Corinthians 12:11). They cannot be manufactured or controlled by human effort-they are sovereignly given and empowered by the Holy Spirit, often in moments of need or ministry. 1 Corinthians 13:8 says that eventually prophecy and tongues will cease. Theologically people who believe that the gifts of the Holy Spirit have ceased are known as ‘Cessationists’. 1 Corinthians 13:10 says “when the prefect [Jesus] comes, that which is in part will be cause to cease”. As Jesus has not yet returned for His church, the gifts are still in operation on the earth.

It is crucial to recognize that the **gifts of the Spirit** should not be separated from the **fruit of the Spirit** (Galatians 5:22-23). While gifts demonstrate power, the fruit reveals character-love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control.

- **Gifts without Fruit:** A believer can operate in gifts yet lack maturity or character, leading to pride, misuse, or harm.
- **Fruit without Gifts:** A believer may have godly character but lack the empowerment to minister effectively.

Both are necessary. Gifts equip believers for service. The fruit is a sign of their spiritual health (Matthew 7:16) and provide a ‘pleasant taste’ to those who consume it.

Explaining the 9 Holy Spirit Manifestation Gifts

1 Corinthians 12:8-10 lists the 9 Holy Spirit manifestation gifts:

1. **Word of Wisdom** - Supernatural insight into God's purposes or direction for a situation. It applies divine wisdom to complex problems or decisions (Acts 6:10).
1. **Word of Knowledge** - A supernatural revelation of information about a person, event, or circumstance that could not have been known naturally (John 4:17-18).
1. **Faith** - A supernatural ability to trust God for the miraculous, even in impossible situations. This gift inspires boldness and confidence (Acts 3:6-7).
1. **Gifts of Healing** - The supernatural power to heal physical, emotional, or spiritual illnesses and restore wholeness (Acts 3:6-8, Acts 9:17-18).
1. **Working of Miracles** - The ability to perform supernatural acts that defy natural laws, such as multiplying food or raising the dead (Acts 9:40-41, John 2:9-11).
1. **Prophecy** - Declaring God's truth or will under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit. It is to be encouraging, edifying, and comforting (1 Corinthians 14:3).
1. **Distinguishing (Discernment) Between Spirits** - The ability to discern whether a spiritual influence is from God, the enemy, or human origin (Acts 16:16-18).
1. **Various Kinds of Tongues** - Speaking in languages unknown to the speaker, often as an act of worship, prayer, or a sign to unbelievers (Acts 2:4, 1 Corinthians 14:22).
1. **Interpretation of Tongues** - The supernatural ability to interpret the message spoken in tongues so that the church may be edified (1 Corinthians 14:27).

Paul makes it clear that all gifts are valuable and should work together for the common good of the church (1 Corinthians 12:7). However, He also encourages believers to desire the greater gifts (1 Corinthians 12:31). The greater gifts are

often interpreted as those that most directly edify the church, such as prophecy (1 Corinthians 14:1-5).

- Prophecy is especially emphasized because it strengthens, encourages, and comforts others (1 Corinthians 14:3). Paul instructs believers to earnestly desire this gift as it promotes clarity and understanding in the church.
- Gifts like tongues are highly valued for personal edification and prayer (1 Corinthians 14:4), but Paul teaches that when giving a message in tongues to the Church to pray for interpretation to ensure they build up the church (1 Corinthians 14:27-28).

While the Holy Spirit gives the gifts, we must yield and to submit to the Holy Spirit to use them. Like muscles and talents, when we practice yielding to the Holy Spirit to use His gifts we become more confident and reliable in the use of them.

Personal Reflection Questions

1. How has your understanding of baptism changed after reading this chapter? What significance does it hold in your spiritual journey?
1. The Old Covenant washings pointed to the need for ultimate cleansing. How does understanding this deepen your appreciation of Christ's work?
1. Reflect on your own experience of water baptism or your anticipation of it. How does this act symbolize your identification with Christ's death, burial, and resurrection?
1. What does the baptism in the Holy Spirit mean to you personally? How have you experienced or sought His empowerment in your life?
1. How can the empowerment of the Holy Spirit help you live out your calling and serve others more effectively?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** “What’s the most memorable baptism service you’ve ever witnessed or experienced? Why was it meaningful?”
1. **Exploring Old and New Testament Washings:** What do the ceremonial washings of the Old Covenant teach us about holiness and our need for cleansing? How does Jesus fulfill these practices?
1. **Water Baptism:** Read Romans 6:3-4. How does water baptism symbolize the believer’s union with Christ in His death and resurrection?
1. **Holy Spirit Baptism:** Read Acts 1:8 and 2:4. What is the purpose of the baptism in the Holy Spirit, and how does it empower believers for ministry?
1. **Practical Application:** How can we, as a group or individuals, encourage and support others in taking steps of faith like baptism or seeking the Spirit’s empowerment?

Chapter 12 - Discipleship

Discipleship means following Jesus, learning from Him, and becoming more like Him in how we live and love. It involves a lifelong journey of obedience, transformation, and service, guided by the Holy Spirit, and rooted in God’s Word.

Discipleship is the primary command in the Great Commission. Jesus defined this mission in:

Matthew 28:18-20 (NKJV)

And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, “All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth.

Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,

teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.” Amen.

We, His followers, are to “*go and make disciples of all nations.*” Discipleship is about personal growth and about multiplying that growth by teaching others to follow Christ. Discipleship is the vehicle through which we build the Kingdom of God; the teachings of Jesus are the message.

The call to be a disciple is more than attending church or learning Bible verses-it is an invitation to live like Jesus and to partner with Him in advancing God’s

Kingdom. Genuine discipleship helps believers become spiritually mature and effective for ministry (Ephesians 4:13). It shapes both the heart and skills needed to serve others and share the Gospel. As Paul instructed Timothy in 2 Timothy 2:2, discipleship follows a pattern of spiritual multiplication, where trained disciples continue raising up new followers to lead others to Christ.

Discipleship is both an individual calling and a global mission. On a personal level, it involves growing in faith, developing an active spiritual life, being in relationship with others & God. At the same time, it fuels the mission of the Church to reach every nation with the Gospel, ensuring that the message of Christ continues to expand and transform lives across generations.

Why Discipleship Matters

The impact of discipleship goes beyond personal transformation-it has a Kingdom impact. Paul reminded Timothy in 2 Timothy 2:2 to entrust what He had learned to faithful men who would then teach others also. This generational pattern highlights how discipleship is the engine that drives the growth and sustainability of the Church. Discipleship matters because it was Jesus' chosen method for spreading the Gospel and building His Church.

Rather than focusing on large crowds, Jesus intentionally invested in a small group of followers, teaching them, modeling faithfulness, and preparing them to carry forward His mission. This personal, relational approach ensured that His message would multiply, as each disciple was equipped to make more disciples.

At its core, discipleship is central to fulfilling the Great Commission (Matthew 28:19-20). Jesus did not just call us to make converts but to make disciples-followers who are grounded in God's Word, empowered by the Holy Spirit, and equipped for ministry. Through discipleship, believers grow in their knowledge of Scripture, develop spiritual disciplines, and learn to walk in obedience to Christ. It prepares the Church to impact the world, advance the Gospel, and reflect the glory of God to all nations.

Nature vs Nurture

In the study of biology, psychology, and anthropology we often consider the impact of nature versus nurture. The question often posed, is a person more the result of their innate, in-built genetic heritage? Or are they more the result of their environment and upbringing? The truth is that every person is a blend of nature and nurture. Both elements in strong interplay choreograph the development of a human soul.

When you accepted Jesus, the miracle of salvation made you born-again of incorruptible seed. You received a godly nature! Your spiritual DNA was re-

written! This godly nature causes a stirring in our hearts to be close to our heavenly Father, to know Him, to experience Him.

Just as a new-born, whose wonderful, beautiful, innocent nature must be shaped by loving parents to develop into a healthy and mature individual, we too must be shaped and nurtured to be developed.

Discipleship is the process of spiritual development that builds upon our godly nature and makes us spiritually mature. Through investing in discipleship, we ensure that faith is passed down, leaders are raised up, and the Church remains healthy and vibrant-both locally and globally.

Didactic Model vs Apprentice Model

In modern day western education, the primary relationship the student has is with the material. The student's learning is focused on content, material, books, videos, assignments, etc. The transformation of education happens via the curriculum. This method of teaching is known as the *didactic model*.

The paradigm of the didactic model has not always been the norm. The model and method used in Jesus' age was the *apprentice model*. This model of learning emphasizes knowledge being more 'caught than taught' and focuses more on the relationship between student and teacher, than student and curriculum.

The didactic model gradually became the default method over about a millennium, from the first medieval universities of Europe in the 11th - 13th centuries, the invention of the printing press in the 15th century, the enlightenment of the 17th & 18th century, and the impact of industrial revolution on information and education in the 19th & 20th centuries.

The advantage of the didactic model is that it can scale more efficiently than the apprentice model. Massively open online courses (MOOCs) can have thousands of students at the same time, whereas even a very skilled master can only have perhaps a few dozen apprentices concurrently.

The result of the didactic model is that the student has mastery of content, however the student does not become like the teacher. The teacher is a facilitator for the curriculum. The teacher imparts knowledge.

In the apprentice model the master shares more than knowledge, he imparts wisdom. The result of the apprentice model is that the student has become like the master so completely that the student can reproduce the work of the master and take on apprentices of his own.

The didactic model has its use and place in the Kingdom of God, a good example is this book or any other Christian educational material. Jesus as a rabbi, skilled and trained in the rabbinical method, practiced the apprentice model as the primary model for His disciples.

Jesus describes the apprentice model in:

Luke 6:40 (NKJV)

A disciple is not above his teacher, but everyone who is perfectly trained will be like his teacher.

In the didactic model the student becomes a carrier of the knowledge, in the apprentice model, the student becomes like the teacher. Let's study the key words from that passage of Luke.

Table 6 - Word Study: Disciple, Teacher, Perfectly Trained

English

Greek

Pronunciation

Strong's

Definition

Disciple

Mathētēs

math-ay-tes'

A learner, student, or follower who adheres to and imitates the teacher.

G3101

Teacher

Didaskalos

did-as'-kal-os

A master, instructor, or one who imparts knowledge and teaches others.

G1320

Table 6 - Word Study: Disciple, Teacher, Perfectly Trained

Perfectly Trained

Katartizō

Kat-ar-tid'-zo

To equip, prepare, or restore completely; to make mature and fit for purpose.

G2675

To summarize, the purpose and goal of the apprentice model used in discipleship is twofold:

First, the disciple becomes fully trained, as the teacher. This does not mean that the disciple imitates everything their teacher does. We aren't being commanded to create clones, but rather to build into maturity men and women who can carry the message of Jesus to the ends of the earth.

Second, the disciple now becomes a teacher for others. The disciple must pass along what they've learned to someone else, otherwise the message of the kingdom stops with them. This doesn't mean that they will necessarily have the exact same giftings as their teacher, or that they will enter full time ministry, but it does mean that they must reproduce for their own training to have been complete.

Any organism that does not reproduce is barren, and its line is cut off. An animal that cannot reproduce is not healthy, a church that cannot reproduce is likewise unhealthy.

Jesus' Model and Process of Discipleship

Jesus demonstrated the mature and complete example of discipleship in the Gospels with His chosen disciples. We should use these steps broadly as the foundation for our own walk in becoming and making disciples.

The apprentice model has two roles: master and student. Every master has been a student, and hopefully every student will become a master. I will use the terms *disciple* to refer to the student and *disciple-maker* to refer to the master/teacher.

Every discipleship relationship goes through a progression of eight phases. The phases, or steps, are not purely isolated from each other, many times the relationship will flow between the phases. In each phase there is an emphasis for

the disciple, and for the disciple-maker. We will study attributes of disciple-makers in depth later in this chapter.

The eight phases of discipleship are:

1. Invitation/Calling
1. Teaching
1. Demonstrating
1. Participation/Trying
1. Correction
1. Empowerment/Authorization
1. Multiplication
1. Remain Connected

Invitation/Calling

Discipleship begins with a personal invitation from Jesus to follow Him. In Matthew 4:19, Jesus called His first disciples, saying, “*Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men.*” This invitation was both relational and transformational—it required leaving behind old ways of life and stepping into a new purpose centered on God’s mission. Jesus’ call wasn’t to spectatorship but to participation in His ministry and Kingdom work.

Modern disciple-makers must invite others into authentic relationships that inspire spiritual growth and obedience. The invitation to discipleship is deeply personal. Jesus meets individuals where they are, addressing their unique needs and circumstances, but He also calls them to go deeper—to grow, serve, and become more like Him. This pattern reflects the relational nature of discipleship, where the focus is not merely on knowledge but on a life-changing relationship with Christ.

Teaching

Teaching is at the heart of discipleship. Jesus spent much of His ministry teaching the principles of the Kingdom of God, most notably in the Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5-7). His teachings provided a foundation for living righteously, loving others, and walking in obedience to God. Instruction in the Word of God remains central to discipleship today, as Scripture is the primary tool for spiritual growth, correction, and training in righteousness (2 Timothy 3:16-17).

Disciple-makers must commit to teaching the Bible faithfully, helping others understand and apply it to their lives. Teaching involves more than imparting knowledge-it requires modeling Christ-like living so disciples can see faith in action. Jesus embodied the truths He taught, showing that effective teaching is both verbal and visible. In the same way, disciple-makers should strive to live out what they teach, providing practical examples of obedience and faithfulness.

Demonstrating

Jesus didn't just teach His disciples- He demonstrated how to live out the truths He proclaimed. Jesus showed what it means to love, serve, and minister in practical ways. Some examples from the gospels are Jesus washing the disciples' feet as an act of humility and service (John 13:12-15), healing the sick, and feeding the hungry. Through His actions, He modeled compassion, faith, and boldness, leaving a clear example for His followers to imitate.

Discipleship requires showing, not just telling. Modern disciple-makers must be transparent about their faith journey, including struggles and victories, so others can see how faith works in real life. Whether it's praying with someone in need, sharing testimonies, or serving the community, discipleship thrives when it's rooted in practical demonstration. Actions often speak louder than words, making demonstration a powerful tool for training others in the faith.

Participation/Trying

Jesus didn't keep His disciples on the sidelines- He actively involved them in ministry experiences. In Luke 9:1-6 and Matthew 10:5-15, Jesus sent the disciples out to preach the Gospel, heal the sick, and cast out demons. These hands-on opportunities allowed the disciples to learn by doing, gaining confidence and skills under His guidance.

Modern discipleship should also include practical involvement. Disciple-makers must invite disciples to participate in ministry, whether through leading prayer groups, sharing testimonies, or serving in outreach events. Providing safe spaces for practice allows disciples to grow in boldness while being supported and encouraged. Learning happens best when it is applied, and participation is the key to turning theory into action.

Correction

Growth often requires correction, and Jesus lovingly corrected His disciples when they misunderstood His teachings or failed in their tasks. In Mark 9:33-37, He addressed their pride by teaching them about servant leadership. In Luke 22:31-32, He prayed for Peter, preparing Him to recover from failure and strengthen others.

Correction in discipleship should be grace-filled and constructive-rooted in Scripture and aimed at restoration (2 Timothy 4:2). It is not about condemnation but about helping disciples grow and avoid pitfalls. Disciple-makers should provide accountability, using God's Word to guide and encourage growth while modeling humility in receiving correction themselves.

Empowerment/Authorization

Jesus didn't just teach and correct- He empowered His disciples to carry out His mission. He gave them authority to preach the Gospel, heal the sick, and cast out demons (Matthew 28:18-20). After His resurrection, He promised the Holy Spirit as the source of power for their ministry (Acts 1:8).

Modern discipleship should include empowering others to operate in their spiritual gifts and minister effectively. This involves identifying gifts (Ephesians 4:11-13), encouraging their use, and releasing disciples to serve. Empowerment also emphasizes reliance on the Holy Spirit for strength, boldness, and wisdom, ensuring disciples are spiritually equipped for the work God has called them to do.

Multiplication

The goal of discipleship isn't just personal growth-it's multiplication. Jesus modeled this by training the disciples to make more disciples (Matthew 28:19-20). After His resurrection, the apostles continued this multiplying mission, spreading the Gospel and planting churches across the known world. Paul's instructions in 2 Timothy 2:2 reinforce this principle, urging Timothy to teach others who will teach others.

Discipleship involves equipping disciples to disciple others, creating a chain reaction of faith that expands the Kingdom of God. This process requires intentionality-teaching disciples how to mentor, teach, and train others, while sending them out with confidence and purpose (Romans 10:15).

Remain Connected

Discipleship doesn't end when someone is sent out. Jesus modeled ongoing connection with His disciples, continuing to encourage and instruct them even after His resurrection (John 21:15-19). The early church maintained this pattern, gathering regularly for teaching, fellowship, and prayer (Acts 2:42-47).

Modern discipleship should also foster ongoing relationships, providing accountability, encouragement, and support as disciples continue to grow and lead. Maintaining unity in the Body of Christ ensures that disciples are never isolated but remain strengthened and encouraged in their faith journey.

Who does Discipleship?

Everyone in the body of Christ is responsible first to become a disciple, then to contribute to the process of discipleship making. There are diversities of gifts and functions, so our contributions may look different, but we are all responsible. The people ultimately most responsible for the state and health of discipleship in the local church are the leaders (**elders and deacons - Acts 14:23**), but everyone plays a part.

Discipleship is a living, growing process-like nurturing a child to maturity. Healthy discipleship brings strength and life to people. Like a parent who strengthens and nourishes a child, and in doing so causes them to be healthy and mature, disciple-makers to help nourish, strengthen, and mature disciples. The end goal of discipleship is not 'knowledge transfer', but transformation.

All of us must become perfect (mature) and make disciples. While we will have diverse gifts there are common characteristics for all disciple-makers.

Characteristics of a Disciple-Maker

A disciple-maker is someone who not only follows Christ but is also committed to helping others grow in their faith. This role requires specific characteristics that reflect both spiritual maturity and practical dedication. Disciple-makers must continually rely on God's strength, wisdom, and grace to overcome the challenges that come with leading others in their spiritual journeys.

Rooted in Christ

The foundation of a disciple-maker's life must be deeply rooted in Christ. Jesus said, *"I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing"* (John 15:5). Effective disciple-makers know that the ability to grow and help others comes from staying close to Jesus every day. However, resistance to personal growth and spiritual change can hinder this dependence. Disciple-makers must continually cultivate their personal relationship with Jesus through prayer, study of Scripture, and obedience, modeling what it means to abide in Christ for those they are discipling.

Committed to the Mission

A disciple-maker must remain committed to the mission of making disciples as commanded by Jesus in the Great Commission (Matthew 28:19-20). This mission requires intentional focus and prioritization, recognizing that disciple-making is not an optional task but the core purpose of the church. Yet, challenges such as time constraints, busyness, and personal distractions can make it difficult to stay

focused. Disciple-makers must intentionally schedule time for mentoring, teaching, and relationship-building, viewing disciple-making as a lifestyle rather than an occasional activity (Luke 19:10).

Spirit-Led

Disciple-making cannot be accomplished in human strength alone; it requires the guidance and empowerment of the Holy Spirit. Jesus promised His disciples that they would receive power when the Holy Spirit came upon them (Acts 1:8), equipping them to be witnesses and ministers of the Gospel. Disciple-makers must be sensitive to the Spirit's leading, relying on His wisdom to navigate complex situations, cultural barriers, and difficult conversations. This reliance on the Holy Spirit enables disciple-makers to operate in love, boldness, and spiritual discernment, ensuring their efforts are Spirit-directed rather than self-directed.

Humble and Teachable

Humility is a hallmark of an effective disciple-maker. As Paul instructed, *“Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit. Rather, in humility value others above yourselves”* (Philippians 2:3). Disciple-makers recognize that they, too, are lifelong learners who must remain teachable and accountable. They invite correction and feedback, modeling humility for those they mentor. Pride can be a significant barrier to growth, both for disciple-makers and their disciples. Embracing accountability and maintaining a servant's heart fosters trust and creates an environment for growth and transparency.

Patient and Persistent

Discipleship is rarely instantaneous—it is a long-term process that requires patience and persistence. Paul reminds believers to *“not grow weary in doing good, for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up”* (Galatians 6:9). Growth in faith often involves setbacks, questions, and failures, but disciple-makers are called to walk alongside others, offering encouragement and support through every step. It is easy to become discouraged when progress seems slow, but disciple-makers trust that God is at work, even when results are not immediately visible.

Being a disciple-maker requires a blend of spiritual dependence, commitment, and humility. It is a calling that demands patience and persistence while remaining Spirit-led and teachable. Disciple-makers are not expected to be perfect, but they must be faithful—abiding in Christ, investing in others, and trusting God to bring the growth and transformation in His timing. These qualities reflect Christ's love and help others become mature disciples who, in turn, can disciple others.

Practical Tools for Discipleship

Effective discipleship requires intentional tools and practices that foster spiritual growth, accountability, and community. These tools help disciples develop a strong foundation in faith, grow in intimacy with God, and become equipped to disciple others. Practical methods such as Bible study, prayer, small groups, and mentorship provide both the structure and support needed for ongoing growth.

Biblical Study

Engaging deeply with Scripture is the foundation of discipleship. Jesus emphasized the importance of God's Word in spiritual growth, declaring that *"man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceeds out of the mouth of God"* (Matthew 4:4). Regular Bible study and memorization enable disciples to internalize truth, combat falsehoods, and apply God's wisdom to daily life.

Disciples must be encouraged to immerse themselves in Scripture, not merely as an academic exercise but to know God and transform their hearts (Psalms 119:105). Practical approaches, such as reading plans, study guides, and group discussions, provide opportunities to explore doctrine and discuss application in community. By building habits of regular study, disciples lay a solid foundation for spiritual maturity and fruitful ministry (2 Timothy 3:16-17).

Prayer

Prayer is the lifeline of discipleship, connecting believers to God's presence, power, and guidance. Jesus taught His disciples how to pray in Luke 11:1-4, emphasizing both dependence on God and spiritual alignment with His will. Through prayer, disciples learn to seek God's wisdom, intercede for others, and receive strength for ministry.

Teaching disciples how to pray-both individually and corporately-equips them to cultivate intimacy with God and discern His leading (Philippians 4:6-7). Incorporating prayer journals, prayer groups, and fasting practices fosters spiritual discipline and empowerment, ensuring disciples remain Spirit-led and mission-focused.

Small Groups and Community

Discipleship thrives in community. The early church modeled relational discipleship through fellowship, prayer, and breaking bread together (Acts 2:42-47). Small groups and accountability partnerships provide a safe space for disciples to grow together, share struggles, and celebrate victories.

The local church serves as the central hub for discipleship relationships, offering opportunities for group Bible studies, prayer meetings, and fellowship events. These gatherings allow disciples to practice love, bear one another's burdens (Galatians 6:2), and encourage one another toward spiritual maturity (Hebrews 10:24-25). Small groups also provide a framework for multiplying leaders, as mature disciples train and send others to lead groups and mentor new believers.

Mentorship

Mentorship provides a personal and intentional approach to discipleship. Jesus modeled this by investing deeply in the twelve disciples, walking with them through teaching, correction, and encouragement. Similarly, one-on-one relationships allow disciple-makers to tailor guidance to individual needs, helping disciples develop in faith, character, and leadership.

Mentors serve as accountability partners, offering support, prayer, and wisdom during times of growth and struggle. Practical tools like spiritual assessments, goal-setting, and regular check-ins ensure that disciples stay focused and motivated. Peer relationships within mentorship structures also foster mutual growth, as both mentor and disciple learn from shared experiences (Proverbs 27:17).

Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does it mean to you personally to be a disciple of Jesus? How are you actively following Him in your daily life?
1. Reflect on Jesus' model of discipleship. Which aspect of His approach—inviting, teaching, demonstrating, or empowering—stands out most to you, and why?
1. How can you multiply your faith by discipling others? What challenges or fears might hold you back, and how can you overcome them? (Notice I said multiply your faith, not multiply your disciples!)
1. What characteristics of a disciple-maker (e.g., patience, humility, relational focus) do you see in yourself? Which traits do you feel led to develop further?
1. Think about the people in your life. Who might God be calling you to disciple? How can you take the first step in building that relationship?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** Who has had the greatest influence on your spiritual growth, and what did they do that impacted you?
1. **Exploring Jesus' Model:** Read Matthew 4:19. How does Jesus' invitation to 'follow Me' encapsulate the heart of discipleship? What does this look like today?
1. **The Call to Make Disciples:** Discuss Matthew 28:19-20. Why is making disciples central to the mission of the church? How can we, as individuals, participate in this mission?
1. **Overcoming Challenges:** What are some common barriers to disciple-making (e.g., time, fear, lack of confidence)? How can we support one another in overcoming these barriers?
1. **Practical Application:** What is one specific step you can take this week to invest in someone's spiritual growth? How can we, as a group, encourage each other in this process?

Chapter 13 - Spiritual Authority

Jesus is the ultimate and complete source of spiritual authority. As the triumphant Christ He has final authority over all things in heaven and the earth.

Matthew 28:18-20 (NKJV)

And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, "All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth.

Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,

teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age." Amen.

In this chapter we will study the authority and power of Christ, which authorities and powers He has delegated to us (His church), and how to operate in the authority of the name of Jesus. We will also study angelic and demonic beings and examine their authority, power, and natures.

Authority means having the right to act. Power is the ability to carry it out. Both are essential in the spiritual life. Authority is different from power. Let's look at

the following table which compares authority & power and consider a few examples.

Table 7 - Word Study: Authority vs Power

English	Authority	Power
Greek	Exousia	Dunamis
Pronunciation	ex-oo-SEE-ah	DOO-nah-mis
Strong's	G1849	G1411
Definition	Legal right to act or enforce commands.	Ability to act or perform supernatural works.
Source	Delegated by God or Christ.	Empowered by the Holy Spirit.
Examples in Scripture	Jesus' authority to forgive sins (<i>Mark 2:10</i>).	Jesus' miraculous works through the Holy Spirit (<i>Luke 6:19</i>).
Application	Commanding authority over sickness, demons, or nature.	Performing miracles, healings, and supernatural acts.
Believers' Use	Authority to bind, loose, and command in Jesus' name.	Power to carry out miracles and preach with boldness.

Here are a few examples to help understand the difference between power and authority.

Example 1: At work, an employee may have the talents and skills to conduct a sale of the company's assets (power). This power is lawful if they also have the associated permission (authority) from the company's owners. Without this authority, selling the company's assets is theft.

Example 2: A police officer is given special training in weapons and hand-to-hand combat to learn how to apprehend and physically compel a criminal (power). Police officers have been given the job responsibility backed up by laws (authority) to enforce criminal statutes.

What is Jesus' Authority?

As Jesus said in Matthew, 'All authority' has been given. Let's look at precisely what that authority entails:

- Over Heaven and Earth
- Over life and death
- Over sin and forgiveness
- Over demons and spiritual forces
- Over sickness and disease
- To judge humanity
- Over the Church
- Over creation and nature
- Over death, Hell, and the grave
- To empower believers

Authority Over Heaven and Earth

Matthew 28:18 (NKJV)

And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, "All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth.

Christ's authority extends to everything in creation, including the physical and spiritual realms. This authority establishes His sovereign rule as King of kings and

Lord of lords (Revelation 19:16). It forms the foundation for the Great Commission, empowering believers to spread the Gospel.

Authority Over Life and Death

John 10:17-18 (NKJV)

“Therefore My Father loves Me, because I lay down My life that I may take it again.

No one takes it from Me, but I lay it down of Myself. I have power to lay it down, and I have power to take it again. This command I have received from My Father.”

Jesus has complete control over life and death, demonstrated in His death and resurrection. He holds the key to eternal life, offering victory over death and fear for those who believe (2 Timothy 1:10).

Authority Over Sin and Forgiveness

Mark 2:10 (NKJV)

But that you may know that the Son of Man has power on earth to forgive sins”—He said to the paralytic,

Christ has the authority to forgive sins, reconciling humanity to God through His atoning sacrifice. This authority demonstrates His divine nature and role as the Savior (1 John 2:2).

Authority Over Demons and Spiritual Forces

Luke 10:19 (NKJV)

Behold, I give you the authority to trample on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing shall by any means hurt you.

Jesus commands demons and spiritual powers, enforcing His victory over Satan (1 John 3:8). He delegates this authority to believers, enabling them to cast out demons and minister deliverance (Mark 16:17).

Authority Over Sickness and Disease

Matthew 8:16-17 (NKJV)

When evening had come, they brought to Him many who were demon-possessed. And He cast out the spirits with a word, and healed all who were sick,

that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by Isaiah the prophet, saying: "HE HIMSELF TOOK OUR INFIRMITIES AND BORE OUR SICKNESSES."

Jesus healed all types of diseases, fulfilling prophecy and demonstrating His authority over both sickness and spiritual affliction. Jesus used healing as a sign of His authority to forgive sin, showing that physical and spiritual restoration are both within His command.

Authority to Judge All Humanity

John 5:22-23 (NKJV)

For the Father judges no one, but has committed all judgment to the Son,

that all should honor the Son just as they honor the Father. He who does not honor the Son does not honor the Father who sent Him.

Christ is the appointed judge over all people, both the living and the dead (Acts 10:42). His judgments are righteous, ensuring that evil is punished, and faithfulness is rewarded. Believers face the Judgment Seat of Christ for rewards (2 Corinthians 5:10), while unbelievers face the Great White Throne Judgment for eternal separation (Revelation 20:11-15).

Authority Over the Church

Ephesians 1:22-23 (NKJV)

And He put all things under His feet, and gave Him to be head over all things to the church,

which is His body, the fullness of Him who fills all in all.

Christ is the head of the Church, guiding and equipping believers through His Word and Spirit. He delegates spiritual gifts and appoints leaders to nurture, protect, and equip the Church (Ephesians 4:11-13).

Authority Over Creation and Nature

Colossians 1:16-17 (NKJV)

For by Him all things were created that are in heaven and that are on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or principalities or powers. All things were created through Him and for Him.

And He is before all things, and in Him all things consist.

Jesus is the Creator and Sustainer of the universe, demonstrating sovereignty over all natural forces. He commands storms to be still (Mark 4:39) and multiplies food, showing His power over nature.

Authority Over Death, Hell, and the Grave

Revelation 1:18 (NKJV)

I am He who lives, and was dead, and behold, I am alive forevermore. Amen. And I have the keys of Hades and of Death.

Christ has victory over death, hell, and the grave, symbolized by His possession of the keys. This guarantees eternal life for believers and establishes His sovereignty over the afterlife (1 Corinthians 15:54-57).

Authority to Empower Believers

Acts 1:8 (NKJV)

But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”

Christ empowers believers through the Holy Spirit to proclaim the Gospel, perform miracles, and minister effectively. Believers act under His authority while relying on the Holy Spirit’s power to fulfill their mission (Matthew 28:18-20).

The Source of Jesus’ Authority

Now that we have looked at precisely what authority is we need to know who the source of that authority is. Jesus’ authority is both divine and delegated. It originates from God the Father, is affirmed through His death and resurrection, and operates in perfect harmony with the Father’s will. Though absolute, His authority respects human free will, demonstrating God’s love rather than forceful control.

Jesus’ authority is rooted in His divine identity as the Son of God and is granted by the Father. The Father entrusted all authority to Christ, including judgment and rule over heaven and earth (Matthew 11:27). Jesus’ authority reflects the unity

and love within the Trinity, where the Son carries out the Father's plan perfectly (John 3:35).

While Jesus had inherent authority as God's Son, His victory over sin, death, and hell was fully established through His death and resurrection. Christ's obedience in His sacrifice led to His exaltation (seated at the right hand of the Father), securing His authority over all creation. By conquering death, Christ gained absolute dominion over life and eternity.

Revelation 1:18 (NKJV)

I am He who lives, and was dead, and behold, I am alive forevermore. Amen. And I have the keys of Hades and of Death.

Even though Jesus has all authority, He uses it in full agreement with the Father's heart and purpose:

John 5:19 (NKJV)

Then Jesus answered and said to them, "Most assuredly, I say to you, the Son can do nothing of Himself, but what He sees the Father do; for whatever He does, the Son also does in like manner.

Jesus does not act independently; instead, He mirrors the Father's actions, ensuring His authority is always just and righteous. Even His words and teachings reflect the father's intent, emphasizing their unity in purpose (John 12:49).

Jesus never forces anyone to obey. He respects our freedom and gently invites us to follow Him.

Revelation 3:20 (NKJV)

Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and dine with him, and he with Me.

Christ's authority works through love and grace to restore broken lives and empower believers. Christ calls, but does not force obedience, demonstrating love instead of domination. While Jesus does not override free will, He allows people to experience the consequences of their choices:

Galatians 6:7-8 (NKJV)

Do not be deceived, God is not mocked; for whatever a man sows, that he will also reap.

For he who sows to his flesh will of the flesh reap corruption, but he who sows to the Spirit will of the Spirit reap everlasting life.

Jesus Delegated Certain Authority to His Followers

Jesus delegated specific areas of authority to believers. This authority is relational. We only have this authority in relationship to Jesus. We have no authority apart from our relationship with Jesus. Likewise, the power we have been given by the Holy Spirit is only through our relationship with Him. Apart from Him, we can do nothing.

John 14:12-14 (NKJV)

“Most assuredly, I say to you, he who believes in Me, the works that I do he will do also; and greater works than these he will do, because I go to My Father.

And whatever you ask in My name, that I will do, that the Father may be glorified in the Son.

If you ask anything in My name, I will do it.

Jesus said these greater works were tied to His name (His rightful authority), not ours! These works are to be done to glorify God in the Son. The scriptures say we must ask, and what we ask for must be in line with God’s will; our asks of God are not for personal enrichment, misuse, or abuse, but for the purpose of kingdom of God:

James 4:2-3 (NKJV)

You lust and do not have. You murder and covet and cannot obtain. You fight and war. Yet you do not have because you do not ask.

You ask and do not receive, because you ask amiss, that you may spend it on your pleasures.

To know the will of God, renew your mind! Paul says renewing the mind and being transformed is key to knowing the good, acceptable, and perfect will of God (Romans 12:1-2).

When we ask, we are to ask in faith (Mark 11:24, Matthew 21:22). Reminding ourselves that **faith is not magic but is persuasion and trust**. Jesus as the source of complete and perfect truth is able to persuade us of His will and His ability to deliver on His promises (Hebrews 11).

Mark 16:15-20 (NKJV)

And He said to them, “Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature.

He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.

And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new tongues;

they will take up serpents; and if they drink anything deadly, it will by no means hurt them; they will lay hands on the sick, and they will recover.”

So then, after the Lord had spoken to them, He was received up into heaven, and sat down at the right hand of God.

And they went out and preached everywhere, the Lord working with them and confirming the word through the accompanying signs. Amen.

Jesus gave us His authority to:

- **Preach the Gospel & Baptize Believers** - This is Christ's authority to build His church and make disciples (Matthew 28:19-20). Boldly proclaiming the message of reconciliation and forgiveness of sins. This is the authority to lead in the Body of Christ as faithful under shepherds and servants and to practice discipline (train, correct, rebuke) in our gatherings (1 Peter 5).
- **Cast Out Devils** - This is Christ's authority over the works of the devil and evil spirits. We have the authority to resist the devil individually and to bring deliverance to those impacted and oppressed by him (Luke 10:19).
- **Speak with New Tongues** - This is Christ's promise of supernatural empowerment by the manifestation of the Holy Spirit.
- **Protection from Serpents and from Poison** - This is Christ's authority and provision to keep us safe from harms and injury in our work. We are not to put God to a foolish test (Matthew 4:7).
- **Heal the Sick** - This is Christ's authority to heal the sick, physically, emotionally, and spiritually (James 5:14-15). To bind up the broken hearted, open the (spiritual and physical) eyes of the blind, to set at liberty those who are held in captivity (Isaiah 61 / Luke 4).

This authority is not given for personal gain but as a tool to advance God's Kingdom, bring healing, and set people free. It requires humility, dependence on the Holy Spirit, and alignment with God's will. As we step into this authority, we do so in faith, knowing that all power ultimately belongs to Christ (Matthew 28:18).

The authority we've received from Christ is put into operation through our expression. Many times, this expression is verbalized in prayer, or in speaking, but in many cases is also expressed through the laying on of hands.

Laying on of Hands

The laying on of hands is a significant biblical practice used throughout both the Old Testament and New Testament to symbolize blessing, commissioning, healing, and the impartation of spiritual authority or gifts. It is more than just a physical act—it represents a spiritual connection and transfer under the direction of God's authority.

In the Old Testament, the laying on of hands was often associated with blessing and dedication. For example, Jacob blessed his grandchildren, Ephraim, and Manasseh, by laying his hands on them (Genesis 48:14). Similarly, Moses laid hands on Joshua to commission him as his successor, imparting leadership authority and wisdom (Numbers 27:18-23, Deuteronomy 34:9). This act publicly signified God's selection and empowerment for the task ahead.

In the New Testament, the laying on of hands is closely tied to the ministry of Jesus and the early church. Jesus regularly laid hands on the sick to heal them (Mark 6:5, Luke 4:40), demonstrating both compassion and authority over sickness and disease. The apostles continued this practice, using it to impart the Holy Spirit (Acts 8:17), spiritual gifts (1 Timothy 4:14, 2 Timothy 1:6), and blessings to believers. It also played a role in commissioning leaders and missionaries for ministry (Acts 13:3).

The laying on of hands symbolizes an act of faith and obedience to God's Word. It is not a mechanical ritual, but a spiritual practice rooted in dependence on the Holy Spirit. For example, in Acts 6:6, the apostles laid hands on those selected to serve as deacons, committing them to God's service and publicly acknowledging their calling. In Acts 19:6, Paul laid hands on believers, and they received the Holy Spirit, demonstrating its role in spiritual empowerment.

However, the Bible also gives warnings about the practice:

1 Timothy 5:22 (NKJV)

Do not lay hands on anyone hastily, nor share in other people's sins;
keep yourself pure.

This highlights the importance of discernment and spiritual maturity when appointing individuals to leadership roles. As we studied in the chapter on the church, leaders must be tested and proven to avoid promoting unqualified or immature believers who could bring harm to the Body of Christ.

A few more guidelines for laying on of hands:

1. Contextually appropriate - the person who is having hands laid on them should be a willing participant.
1. Physically appropriate - laying on of hands does not involve sexual or sensual touch. In practice laying a hand on a shoulder, hand, or forehead are generally accepted places to touch (with permission) in the western world.
1. Culturally appropriate - in some cultures it is not appropriate for men and women to have touch unless they are related by blood or marriage.

The laying on of hands continues to be a powerful expression of faith and obedience in the Church today. It serves as a means of blessing, healing, commissioning, and empowerment, always pointing to the authority of Christ and the work of the Holy Spirit. Whether praying for the sick, sending out missionaries, or commissioning leaders, it is a reminder that believers operate not in their own power but under the authority of Jesus Christ and in alignment with His purposes.

Now that we have studied the authority of Jesus and the authority of the believer, we will discuss the other beings of the spiritual realm, angels and demons.

Angels and Demons

Angels

Angels are a significant part of God's creation, serving as His messengers and agents to carry out His divine purposes. The Bible reveals a spiritual realm inhabited by these beings, who are powerful, intelligent, and obedient to God's commands. While angels are often unseen, their presence and actions impact human history and spiritual warfare. Understanding their roles, classifications, and activities provides us with deeper insight into God's plan and the unseen realities that surround us.

The term "angel" itself means "messenger," highlighting their primary function. Angels operate in obedience to God's will, whether delivering messages, providing protection, executing judgment, or engaging in spiritual battles. They are not objects of worship but serve as examples of obedience and reverence, always pointing back to the glory of God. This chapter explores the nature, classifications, and roles of angels, shedding light on their significance in Scripture and in our lives today.

In the scriptures angels are seen as **messengers**, **servants**, and **warriors**. Angels frequently act as messengers, delivering important announcements, warnings, and encouragements. They reveal God's plans and provide guidance in times of

need (Luke 1:26-38; Matthew 2:13; Revelation 1:1). Angels are actively involved in protecting, strengthening, and delivering believers. They minister to God's people in times of distress and provide supernatural aid (Psalms 91:11; Acts 12:7-11; Matthew 4:11). Angels engage in spiritual warfare, battling demonic forces to advance God's kingdom and defend believers (Daniel 10:13; Revelation 12:7-9).

The Nature of Angels

Angels are created beings, brought into existence by God before the foundation of the world. They are distinct from humans, possessing unique characteristics that equip them for their heavenly roles. The Bible teaches that angels are spiritual beings, not bound by physical limitations, yet they can take on visible forms when interacting with humans.

Angels are described as immortal, meaning they do not die or age. They are innumerable, with vast hosts filling the heavenly realms. While they are often referred to with masculine pronouns, Scripture makes it clear that angels are sexless and do not marry or reproduce. These qualities emphasize their purpose as servants of God, entirely devoted to His will and commands. Angels possess remarkable traits that reflect their divine purpose. They are obedient, reverent, wise, and powerful. These qualities equip them to carry out God's will effectively and faithfully.

Table 8 - Characteristics of Angels

	Description	References
Created Beings	Angels were created by God and existed before humanity.	JOB 38:4-7; Revelation 19:10; Colossians 2:18
Spiritual Beings	They are spirits but can assume human form when necessary.	Genesis 19:1-3; Hebrews 1:14
Immortal	They do not die or age.	Luke 20:36
Innumerable	Their numbers are vast and beyond human counting.	Hebrews 12:22; DAN 7:10; Matthew 26:53
Sexless	They do not marry or reproduce.	Matthew 22:30; Luke 20:34-36
Obedient	Carry out God's commands without question.	Psalms 103:20
Reverent	Engage in constant worship of God.	Revelation 5:11-12; Hebrews 1:6
Wise	Possess wisdom beyond humans but are not omniscient.	2SA 14:17; 1KI 8:39

Table 8 - Characteristics of Angels

Mighty	Exhibit great strength and power to carry out God's will.	Psalms 103:20; 2 Peter 2:11
Holy	Set apart for God's purposes, reflecting His holiness.	Revelation 14:10

Though the Bible highlights several roles and titles for angels, it does not give an exhaustive classification system. However, some angels are identified by specific roles or functions:

- **The Angel of the Lord** - Often considered a pre-incarnate appearance of Christ, appearing with divine authority. (*Exodus 23:20-23; Judges 6:11-24*)
- **Archangels** - High-ranking angels like Michael, who leads armies, and Gabriel, who delivers divine messages. (*Jude 9; Revelation 12:7; Luke 1:19-26*)
- **Cherubim** - Guardians of God's glory and presence, such as at Eden and the Ark of the Covenant. (*Genesis 3:24; Exodus 25:22*)
- **Seraphim** - Worshipers of God, continually declaring His holiness. (*Isaiah 6:1-6*)
- **Elect Angels** - Faithful angels who resisted Satan's rebellion and remain loyal to God. (*1 Timothy 5:21; Matthew 25:41*)

These classifications emphasize the diversity and organization within the angelic realm, yet their primary focus is always fulfilling God's purposes.

Human Interaction with Angels

Humans often encounter angels in Scripture, but we are never instructed to command or pray to them. Instead, angels act according to God's direction. They minister to believers as **servants of God** (Hebrews 1:14). Their interactions include protection, guidance, and deliverance, always pointing us back to God's power and sovereignty.

- **Warnings Against Angel Worship:** Scripture forbids worshiping angels or seeking encounters with them (Colossians 2:18; Revelation 22:8-9).
- **Prayer to God, Not Angels:** Believers should pray to God, who dispatches angels as He wills (Psalms 91:11).
- **Encouragement and Trust:** Angels remind us of God's care, but our faith should rest fully in God, not in angels.

Angels are awe-inspiring beings created to serve God and minister to His people. While their work is often unseen, Scripture provides glimpses into their activity, revealing their faithfulness, strength, and reverence. Angels remind us of God’s provision and protection, but they always point back to His glory. As believers, we are called to trust in God’s care, knowing that angels operate as His servants to fulfill His divine purposes.

Demons

Just as the study of angels is necessary to understand the spiritual world, so too is the study of demons. Scripture clearly describes their activity, influence, and defeat through Jesus Christ. Recognizing their role in spiritual warfare helps believers stand firm in faith without fear.

Origin and Nature of Demons

Demons are fallen angels who followed Satan’s rebellion against God. (*Revelation 12:7-9; Matthew 25:41*). Satan, formerly known as Lucifer (“light bearer”), an exalted angel, sought to exalt himself above God and was cast out of heaven along with other rebellious angels. (*Isaiah 14:12-15; Ezekiel 28:12-17*).

Demons are spirits without physical bodies but can oppress and torment humans and animals. (*Mark 5:11-13*). They seek to deceive, tempt, oppress, and destroy. (*John 10:10; 2 Corinthians 11:14*). Unlike God, they have limits, and are not omnipresent (everywhere), omniscient (all knowing), omnipotent (all powerful). Their ultimate defeat is certain, and they will face eternal punishment. (*Revelation 20:10*)

The scriptures describe the work and activity of the devil as:

- Opposes God’s Work (*1 Thessalonians 2:18*)
- Deceives the World (*Revelation 12:9; 2 Corinthians 4:4*)
- Tempts and Accuses Believers (*Luke 22:31; Revelation 12:10*)
- Afflicts and Harms (*Job 1:12; Luke 13:16*)

There are many names and descriptions for the devil, each describing a different aspect of his work.

Table 9 - Names of the Devil

Title	Meaning	References
Satan		JOB 1:6; 1PE 5:8

Table 9 - Names of the Devil

	“Adversary,” opposing God and His people.	
Devil	“Accuser” or “Slanderer.”	Revelation 12:10
Serpent	Deceiver and tempter.	Genesis 3:1; Revelation 12:9
Prince of this World	Rules over worldly systems opposed to God.	John 12:31; 2 Corinthians 4:4
Tempter	Seeks to lead people into sin.	Matthew 4:3; 1 Thessalonians 3:5
Father of Lies	Misleads through deception.	John 8:44

The gospels and epistles further clarify the work of the enemy. Evil spirits, as disembodied, largely must do their work through willing and open vessels. God works through people, so does the devil. This oppression is often marked by torment, self-harm, and destructive behaviors (*Luke 8:27-29*). Their attacks cause fear, temptation, and discouragement (*2 Corinthians 12:7*). The most common source of their power (not authority) in someone’s life is through the influence of lies and emotional strongholds (*2 Corinthians 10:3-5*).

It’s important to note that not every lie a person believes, infirmity in their body, or stronghold in their life is the direct result of demonic influence, but these places of woundedness are places where the enemy can exploit us and keep us in a place of frustration and oppression.

Jesus’ Authority Over the Works of the Enemy

Do not fear, Jesus has complete and total authority over the works of the enemy. Jesus Demonstrated power over demons during His ministry (*Mark 1:34; Mark 5:1-20*). The works of the enemy and Satan himself are defeated through Jesus’ death and resurrection (*Colossians 2:15*).

As believers we have been given authority delegated by Jesus to cast out demons in His name:

Mark 16:17 (NKJV)

And these signs will follow those who believe: In My name they will cast out demons; they will speak with new tongues;

Furthermore, as heirs of salvation we have the authority to submit ourselves to God, resist the devil and He will flee from us! (*James 4:7*).

To deal with an evil or unclean spirit the pattern expressed in the scriptures is to take authority over it in the name of Jesus and command it to leave. The Holy Spirit promises to give us wisdom and discernment if we ask! (James 1:5). We don't need to make it a production, or a drama like in the movies, or to even talk with them, that is a trick of the devil to distract us. Satan's power is established and maintained only by the lies He can get us to believe.

Matthew 18:18 (NKJV)

“Assuredly, I say to you, whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven.

We speak to them in the name of Jesus and command them to leave.

There are two major cautions in the scriptures when dealing with the demonic:

1. **Only those with a relationship with Jesus have the authority over the demonic.** Acts 19:11-20 talks about sons of a Jewish Chief Priest named Sceva. They tried to intervene in the life of someone who was oppressed and tormented by the devil and the evil spirit refused to leave because they didn't have a relationship with Jesus. The man who was oppressed leapt on them, stripped them naked and beat them. Just as you should not impersonate a police officer, **don't impersonate someone with a relationship with Jesus, instead have a relationship with Jesus!**
1. **When an evil spirit leaves, it goes away for a time and will try to come back.** If it finds the place it had dwelled empty, it will come back worse. Matthew 12:43-45. When we minister to a person oppressed of the devil, that person needs to fill the void that evil spirit occupied in their lives. That means at a minimum establishing a personal relationship with Jesus and strengthening it by obedience to the Holy Spirit. Often an evil or unclean spirit has power to operate in someone's life through the choices they made, based on their beliefs. Anyone delivered from the devil needs to replace that old belief system and be transformed by the renewal of their minds (Romans 12:1-2).

We serve an awesome and mighty God, and we are 'more than conquerors' (Romans 8:37) over the defeated enemy. We have no need to fear our defeated enemy, for Jesus has given us His authority to crush his head! The devil's time is short, and He will ultimately be judged along with every principality and power on the earth that rejects the dominion of Christ.

Acknowledgements

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Personal Reflection Questions

1. What does it mean to you that Jesus has all authority in heaven and on earth? How does this truth shape your faith?
1. Reflect on the concept of delegated authority. How does understanding that your authority comes from Christ influence how you exercise it?
1. Have you experienced spiritual authority in your life-either by exercising it or witnessing it? How did it impact your faith?
1. What areas of your life have you struggled to surrender to Christ's authority? How can submitting these areas lead to freedom and peace?
1. What specific area of your life or ministry do you sense God calling you to exercise His authority? How can you take a step of faith in this area?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** What's an example of someone you've seen walking confidently in spiritual authority? What stood out to you about their life or actions?
1. **Exploring Scripture:** Read Matthew 28:18-20. How does Jesus' authority form the foundation of the Great Commission? What does this mean for us as disciples?
1. **The Nature of Authority:** What is the difference between power and authority? Why is it important to understand this distinction as believers?
1. **Angels, Demons, and Spiritual Warfare:** How does understanding the role of angels and demons influence the way we approach spiritual warfare?
1. **Practical Application:** How can we use spiritual authority to pray for others, resist the enemy, or bring healing and restoration? Share examples or ideas.

Chapter 14 - Keep Watch

Having been given the spiritual authority of Christ on the Earth to establish His kingdom we should work with diligence and haste, for Jesus will return!

The return of Christ is an important part of our faith. The study of the return of Christ and the end times is known as **eschatology**. Many books on eschatology have been written, and *most of them disagree with each other!* Specifically, they

disagree on interpretations (figurative, literal, symbolic), the order and timings of the events in the scriptures. I'm reminded of the saying by the great Pentecostal evangelist Reinhard Bonke - "I will split hairs in heaven when I am done breaking chains on Earth!"

As the author, I'm hesitant to dive very deep into this hotly debated topic given that this book is focused primarily on fundamentals of the faith. I will stick largely to the highest-level view of the events depicted in scripture and focus on what matters most - **the mission of the Gospel!**

Universally Agreed Upon Points:

- 1. Jesus Is Returning
- 1. Resurrection of the Dead
- 1. Judgment for All People
- 1. Eternal Destiny
- 1. A Defeated Enemy
- 1. New Heaven and New Earth

For each point we will review what the concept is, look at reference scriptures, consider why it matters, and what we should do in light of it.

1. Jesus Is Returning

What It Is: The **Second Coming of Christ** is the literal return of Jesus to the earth as King and Judge.

Acts 1:11 (NKJV)

who also said, "Men of Galilee, why do you stand gazing up into heaven? This same Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will so come in like manner as you saw Him go into heaven."

Revelation 22:12 (NKJV)

"And behold, I am coming quickly, and My reward is with Me, to give to every one according to his work.

Why It Matters: Christ's return fulfills God's promise to complete redemption and establish His kingdom. It reminds us to live with urgency, knowing we will one day see Him face-to-face.

What Should We Do?

- **Be Watchful:** Live in expectation of His return.
- **Stay Faithful:** Carry out the Great Commission (Matthew 28:19-20) with purpose and diligence.

2. Resurrection of the Dead

What It Is: The **resurrection** is the raising of all people-both righteous and unrighteous-from the dead to face **judgment**.

John 5:28-29 (NKJV)

Do not marvel at this; for the hour is coming in which all who are in the graves will hear His voice

and come forth—those who have done good, to the resurrection of life, and those who have done evil, to the resurrection of condemnation.

1 Thessalonians 4:16 (NKJV)

For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first.

Why It Matters: The resurrection guarantees justice and eternal life for believers while warning unbelievers of judgment. It points to God's sovereignty over life and death.

What Should We Do?

- **Be Prepared:** Live a life of repentance and faithfulness to God.
- **Share the Gospel:** Help others prepare for the resurrection of life by leading them to Christ.

3. Judgment for All People

What It Is: All people-believers and unbelievers-will face judgment before God. Believers appear at the **Judgment Seat of Christ** for rewards, while unbelievers face the **Great White Throne Judgment**.

Great White Throne Judgement

Revelation 20:11-12 (NKJV)

Then I saw a great white throne and Him who sat on it, from whose face the earth and the heaven fled away. And there was found no place for them.

And I saw the dead, small and great, standing before God, and books were opened. And another book was opened, which is the Book of Life. And the dead were judged according to their works, by the things which were written in the books.

As described in the chapter on sin, there will be a great and dreadful final judgement for all non-believers. The punishment will be eternal separation from God! **This judgement is not for the believer.**

Judgement Seat of Christ

As believers our names have been put in the **Lamb's Book of Life** (See the book of *Revelation*). *As such we will stand the Judgement Seat of Christ.* This judgement is not for condemnation, but rather for reward! Again, it is not a moment of **shame or fear** for believers, but a **celebration** of what God has accomplished through us. It reminds us that our lives matter-not just for today but for **eternity**.

2 Corinthians 5:10 (NKJV)

For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, that each one may receive the things done in the body, according to what he has done, whether good or bad.

1 Corinthians 3:12-15 (NKJV)

Now if anyone builds on this foundation with gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, straw,

each one's work will become clear; for the Day will declare it, because it will be revealed by fire; and the fire will test each one's work, of what sort it is.

If anyone's work which he has built on it endures, he will receive a reward.

If anyone's work is burned, he will suffer loss; but he himself will be saved, yet so as through fire.

At this judgement we will receive rewards for the good works we have done! Everyone at this judgement lived and died as a believer, so their eternal salvation is guaranteed. However not everyone will have further reward. The New Testament mentions crowns as rewards that represent victory, honor, and

faithfulness. These laurel crowns highlight God's recognition of believers' faithfulness and service in His Kingdom.

The rewards:

1. **The Crown of Righteousness** (*2 Timothy 4:8*) - For those who long for Christ's appearing and live godly lives.
1. **The Incorruptible Crown** (*1 Corinthians 9:24-25*) - For believers who practice self-discipline and faithfulness.
1. **The Crown of Life** (*James 1:12; Revelation 2:10*) - For those who endure trials, persecution, and testing.
1. **The Crown of Glory** (*1 Peter 5:2-4*) - For leaders and shepherds who faithfully guide God's people.
1. **The Crown of Rejoicing** (*1 Thessalonians 2:19-20*) - For those who lead others to Christ and make disciples.

What Should We Do?

- **Live with Purpose:** Work diligently, knowing our efforts for the Kingdom matter eternally.
- **Examine Ourselves:** Ensure we live lives of faith and obedience.

4. Eternal Destiny

What It Is: All people will spend eternity in one of two places-eternal life with God or eternal separation from Him.

Matthew 25:46 (NKJV)

And these will go away into everlasting punishment, but the righteous into eternal life."

Why It Matters: Our eternal destiny is determined by whether we have accepted or rejected Christ. It emphasizes the urgency of the Gospel message and discipleship.

What Should We Do?

- **Proclaim Salvation:** Share the Gospel boldly to lead others to eternal life.
- **Live with Eternity in Mind:** Focus on what matters eternally-faith, obedience, and love.

5. A Defeated Enemy

What It Is: Satan, the deceiver, will be cast into **the lake of fire**-defeated forever by Christ.

Revelation 20:10 (NKJV)

The devil, who deceived them, was cast into the lake of fire and brimstone where the beast and the false prophet are. And they will be tormented day and night forever and ever.

Why It Matters: This final act demonstrates God's sovereignty over evil and assures believers that Satan's reign of deception and destruction is over. It gives us confidence in God's ultimate victory.

What Should We Do?

- **Stand Firm:** Resist the enemy's lies, knowing He is already defeated.
- **Walk in Authority:** Live with boldness and faith, knowing God has already won the victory.

6. New Heaven and New Earth

What It Is: After the final judgment and defeat of the enemy, God will create a **new heaven and new earth**-a perfect eternal dwelling place for His people.

Revelation 21:1,3 (NKJV)

Now I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away. Also there was no more sea.

And I heard a loud voice from heaven saying, "Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and He will dwell with them, and they shall be His people. God Himself will be with them and be their God.

Why It Matters: It gives us hope for restoration, where God will wipe away every tear and make all things new-free from pain, sin, and death.

What Should We Do?

- **Fix Our Eyes on Eternity:** Keep our focus on the eternal hope rather than temporary struggles.
- **Persevere in Faith:** Endure trials, knowing that eternal joy awaits.

Points of Common Disagreement

For the sake of completeness, should you be curious about the common division points are in eschatology, here is a **very** brief overview of the most frequently debated points.

- **Rapture Timing:** Pre-, Mid-, or Post-Tribulation? Views differ on **when** the rapture occurs relative to the **tribulation**. Some denominations don't believe in the rapture.
- **Tribulation Purpose:** Is it literal judgment for Israel or a symbolic period of struggle?
- **Millennial Reign:** Is it literal (**Premillennial**), symbolic (**Amillennial**), or spiritual (**Postmillennial**)?
- **Satan's Final Rebellion:** Happens after the millennium (literal event or figurative?).

It is great to study eschatology, but let's remember as D.L. Browning said, "Always keep the main thing, the main thing!"

Final Thoughts

The return of Christ is the culmination of God's plan and the reason we live and labor with urgency and purpose. The parables of the ten virgins (Matthew 25:1-13) and the two men in the field (Matthew 24:40-42) remind us to be watchful and faithful, always prepared for His return. Whether through the rewards of crowns or the hope of resurrection, our motivation is clear-Christ is coming back!

May we be found ready, faithful, and expectant on that glorious day!

Personal Reflection Questions

1. How does the promise of Christ's return influence the way you live your daily life? Are there areas where you need to shift your focus or priorities?
1. Reflect on the parable of the ten virgins (Matthew 25:1-13). How can you ensure your "lamp" is prepared and full? What does that look like practically?
1. What does it mean to you to live as a faithful servant, ready for Christ's return? How can you grow in faithfulness?
1. In what specific ways can you live today with an eternal perspective, focusing on what truly matters considering Christ's return?

Group Discussion Questions (20-30 Minutes)

1. **Icebreaker Question:** "If you knew Jesus was returning tomorrow, what's the first thing you'd do today?"
1. **Exploring Scripture:** Read Matthew 24:42-44. What does it mean to 'keep watch'? How can we balance readiness with the demands of everyday life?
1. **Faithful Living:** Discuss the parable of the two men in the field (Matthew 24:40-41). How does this illustrate the suddenness of Christ's return? How can we live prepared for that moment?
1. **Crowns and Rewards:** What do the crowns mentioned in Scripture (e.g., Crown of Righteousness, Crown of Life) teach us about God's recognition of our faithfulness? How should this shape our lives?
1. **Encouraging One Another:** How can we, as a group or community, encourage one another to stay focused on Christ and live in anticipation of His return?

Postscript

As I bring this book to a close, my hope and prayer for you, dear reader, is that these foundational truths have strengthened your faith, deepened your understanding, and drawn you closer to God. Doctrine is not merely an intellectual pursuit-it is the framework upon which we build our lives, shaping how we live, love, and serve in the Kingdom of God.

If there is one thing I would leave you with, it is this: Keep growing. Keep seeking. Keep walking in faith. The truths outlined in this book are not meant to be read

once and set aside; they are meant to be lived out daily. The journey of following Christ is one of continual learning, refining, and transformation. We move from faith to faith, from glory to glory, ever pressing on to know Him more.

You may have questions that remain unanswered. You may feel like you’ve only scratched the surface of these deep and eternal truths. That is a good place to be. Let those questions drive you deeper into the Word of God, into prayer, and into fellowship with other believers. The Holy Spirit is your guide, your teacher, and your comforter-He will lead you into all truth as you seek Him.

Paul wrote

Philippians 3:12-14 (NKJV)

Not that I have already attained, or am already perfected; but I press on, that I may lay hold of that for which Christ Jesus has also laid hold of me.

Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead,

I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.

Let us press on together. Stand firm in sound doctrine, walk boldly in faith, and proclaim the Gospel with confidence. The world desperately needs the light of Christ, and you, equipped with the truth, are called to shine.

Thank you for allowing me to be a part of your journey. My prayer is that you will continue to grow in grace, stand in truth, and be a faithful disciple of Jesus Christ.

With faith and expectation,

Andrew D. Nieuwsma

Extended Reference Tables

Table 10 - Old Testament Names of God

Name Pronunciation	Meaning	Significance
	References	

Table 10 - Old Testament Names of God

I AM THAT I AM	Self-Existent, Eternal	God's foundational name revealed to Moses, affirming His eternal, unchanging, and self-sustaining nature. This name emphasizes that God exists by His own power and will always be.
Eh-YEH a-sheh Eh-YEH	Exodus 3:14	
Elohim	God, Creator	Emphasizes God's power and majesty as Creator; a plural form denoting greatness or the Trinity.
Eh-loh-HEEM	Genesis 1:1, Psalms 19:1	
Yahweh (Jehovah)	LORD, "I AM"	The covenant name of God, indicating His eternal, self-existent nature, and faithfulness to Israel.
YAH-weh (jeh-HO-vah)	Exodus 3:14, Isaiah 42:8	
Adonai	Lord, Master	Reflects God's authority and lordship, acknowledging Him as the rightful ruler and owner of creation.
Ah-doh-NIGH	Genesis 15:2, Psalms 16:2	
El Shaddai	God Almighty, All-Sufficient One	Signifies God's power to nourish, bless, and provide abundantly; shows His sufficiency.
El shad-DYE	Genesis 17:1, Psalms 91:1	
Yahweh-Jireh	The LORD Will Provide	Symbolizes God's provision; first used when God provided a ram as a substitute for Isaac.
YAH-weh YI-rah	Genesis 22:14	
Yahweh-Rapha	The LORD Who Heals	Shows God's healing nature; He restores physical, emotional, and spiritual health.
YAH-weh RAH-fah	Exodus 15:26	
Yahweh-Nissi		

Table 10 - Old Testament Names of God

YAH-weh NEE-see	The LORD is My Banner Exodus 17:15	Represents God's protection and victory; used by Moses after a victory over the Amalekites.
Yahweh-M'kaddesh YAH-weh Meh-KAH-desh	The LORD Who Sanctifies LEV 20:8, Exodus 31:13	Points to God as the One who sets His people apart as holy, through His commandments and grace.
Yahweh-Shalom YAH-weh shah-LOME	The LORD is Peace JDG 6:24	Gideon used this name after God's reassurance; highlights God as the source of peace and wholeness.
Yahweh-Sabaoth YAH-weh Sa-ba-OTE	The LORD of Hosts (Armies) 1 Samuel 1:3, Psalms 46:7	Refers to God's supreme power over all heavenly and earthly forces; emphasizes His sovereignty.
Yahweh-Raah YAH-weh RAH-ah	The LORD is My Shepherd Psalms 23:1	David's use of this name to show God's guidance, care, and provision, like a shepherd with His flock.
Yahweh-Tsidkenu YAH-weh Tsid-KAY-noo	The LORD Our Righteousness Jeremiah 23:6	Indicates God as the source of righteousness and justice, fulfilled in the Messiah.
Yahweh-Shammah YAH-weh SHAH-mah	The LORD is There EZK 48:35	Used to describe God's abiding presence; symbolizes God's presence with His people, even in exile.
El Elyon	God Most High	Signifies God's supreme authority and exalted position above all other gods and powers.

Table 10 - Old Testament Names of God

El EL-yawn	Genesis 14:18-20, Psalms 57:2	
El Olam	Everlasting God	Emphasizes God's eternal nature; He exists beyond time and is unchanging.
El OH-lahm	Genesis 21:33, Isaiah 40:28	
Yahweh-Makkeh	The LORD Who Strikes	Highlights God's justice in discipline and correction; a reminder of His holy standards.
YAH-weh MAH-keh	EZK 7:9, 22:31	
Yahweh-Gmolah	The God of Recompense	God's justice in repaying and rewarding according to one's deeds; emphasizes divine justice.
YAH-weh GIM-oh-lah	Jeremiah 51:56	
Qanna	Jealous	Reflects God's zealous love for His people; shows His intolerance for idolatry and unfaithfulness.
KAH-nah	Exodus 34:14, Deuteronomy 4:24	
El Roi	The God Who Sees Me	Used by Hagar; emphasizes God's attentiveness and awareness of personal struggles.
El ROY-ee	Genesis 16:13	
Yahweh-Channun	The LORD Who is Gracious	Highlights God's mercy and His readiness to forgive and show compassion.
YAH-weh khan-NOON	Psalms 86:15, Exodus 34:6	
Yahweh-Elyon	The LORD Most High	Affirms God's ultimate authority and position above all else.

Table 10 - Old Testament Names of God

YAH-weh EL-yawn Psalms 7:17, 47:2

The attributes are grouped into relational, moral, foundational, ability categories. Relational attributes describe how we personally experience God. Moral attributes describe His character. Foundational attributes describe His essential nature of being.

Table 12 - Names of Jesus

Name	Meaning	Significance & Reference
Jesus (Yeshua) Matthew 1:21	The LORD is Salvation	Jesus as God in the flesh, fulfilling God's promise of salvation to His people.
Emmanuel Matthew 1:23	God with Us	Represents God's presence among humanity through Jesus; a symbol of closeness and incarnate love.
Messiah (Christ) John 1:41, Matthew 16:16	Anointed One	The promised deliverer and anointed King from the Old Testament, fulfilled in Jesus.
Logos John 1:1-14	The Word	Jesus as the divine Word of God, through whom all things were created, embodying wisdom and truth.
Lamb of God John 1:29, Revelation 5:6	The Sacrifice for Sin	Jesus as the sacrificial Lamb, taking away the sins of the world, fulfilling the sacrificial system.
Alpha and Omega Revelation 1:8, 22:13	The Beginning and the End	Emphasizes God's eternal existence and sovereignty over history and all creation.
Son of God Matthew 3:17, John 3:16	Divine Sonship	Affirms Jesus's divine nature and relationship within the Trinity as the Son.

Table 12 - Names of Jesus

Son of Man Matthew 8:20, DAN 7:13-14	Represent-ative of Humanity	Jesus's favorite self-designation, emphasizing His humanity and messianic role as foretold in Daniel.
King of Kings Revelation 17:14, 19:16	Supreme Ruler	Declares Jesus's supreme authority over all earthly rulers and kingdoms.
Lord of Lords Revelation 17:14, 19:16	Supreme Authority	Jesus as the ultimate authority over all, affirming His divine sovereignty.
The Good Shepherd John 10:11, Psalm 23	Caring Protector	Jesus as the caring shepherd who lays down His life for His sheep, guiding and protecting them.
Prince of Peace Isaiah 9:6, Ephesians 2:14	Bringer of Peace	Jesus as the source of peace, reconciling humanity to God and offering inner peace.
Redeemer Galatians 3:13, TIT 2:14	One Who Buys Back	Jesus as the one who paid the price to free humanity from sin and its penalties.
High Priest Hebrews 4:14-15, Hebrews 7:26	Mediator between God and Man	Jesus as the ultimate mediator who intercedes for humanity before God.
The Way, Truth, Life John 14:6	Source of Spiritual Life	Jesus as the only path to God, embodying truth and granting eternal life.

Table 12 - Names of Jesus

Bread of Life John 6:35	Spiritual Sustenance	Jesus as the source of spiritual nourishment and eternal life.
Light of the World John 8:12	Spiritual Enlightenment	Jesus as the source of truth, dispelling spiritual darkness and guiding believers.
Son of David 2SA 7:16, Isaiah 11:1, Matt 1 and Luke 3	Descendant of King David	Jesus is in the lineage of King David, fulfilling several Old Testament prophecies about him.

End of Chapter Activities

These end-of-chapter activities are designed to reinforce the core learning objectives of each chapter. Each activity is intended to take approximately 15-20 minutes to complete and may require additional resources not included in this book. Alongside personal reflection and group discussion questions, these activities are best utilized in a group study format to deepen understanding and engagement with the book's key lessons. Use these activities as a guideline. Be creative, encourage participation, and modify the activities as you see fit.

Chapter 1 - Sound Doctrine Matters

Activity 1: Scripture Match-Up

Purpose:

Reinforce key biblical concepts about doctrine by exploring Scriptures that emphasize its importance.

Instructions:

1. **Divide participants into pairs or small groups** of 3-4 people.
1. **Assign Scriptures** - Give each group one of the following passages:
 - **Colossians 2:7** - *Rooted and built up in Christ.*
 - **2 Timothy 4:1-4** - *Preaching the Word and guarding against false doctrine.*
 - **Ephesians 4:11-16** - *Spiritual maturity and unity through sound teaching.*
1. **Group Discussion** - Have each group:
 - **Read their assigned Scripture** aloud.
 - **Summarize the main teaching** about doctrine in 1-2 sentences.
 - **Discuss a real-life example** of how this teaching applies to guarding against falsehood or helping others grow in faith.
1. **Share Insights** - Groups take **2 minutes** each to present their Scripture, summary, and application to the whole group.

Activity 2: Doctrine in Action

Purpose:

Apply the importance of sound doctrine to **real-life scenarios** and reinforce practical responses.

Instructions:

1. **Divide into Groups** - Form groups of **4-5 participants**.

1. **Assign Scenarios** - Give each group one of the following:

- **Scenario 1:** *A friend tells you, “It doesn’t really matter what we believe, as long as we’re sincere.” How do you respond?*
- **Scenario 2:** *You’re mentoring a new believer who hears conflicting teachings about salvation by faith versus salvation by works. What Scriptures can you share to help clarify?*
- **Scenario 3:** *A Christian friend stops attending church because they feel it’s unnecessary as long as they believe in God. How do you encourage them with Scripture?*

1. **Discussion Tasks** - Groups should:

- **Identify the doctrinal issue** at the heart of the scenario.
- **List 1-2 Scriptures** that address the issue.
- Prepare a **1-minute summary** of how they’d counsel the person in the scenario.

1. **Share Responses** - Groups take turns presenting their scenarios and answers to the group, followed by **brief feedback or additions** from others.

Activity 3: Statement or Scripture?

Purpose:

Train participants to **discern truth from error** using Scripture as their foundation.

Instructions:

1. **Set Up the Activity** - Read the following **statements** aloud, one at a time. Some statements are **biblical truths**, while others are **errors** or **misinterpretations**.
1. **Group Responses** - Ask participants to:
 - Decide whether the statement is **true** or **false**.
 - Provide a **Bible verse** to support their answer.
1. **Facilitate Discussion** - Allow time for groups to discuss disagreements or look up verses before confirming the correct answers.

Statements:

1. *Faith alone saves us. (True - Ephesians 2:8-9)*
1. *All roads lead to God if we're sincere. (False - John 14:6)*
1. *Sound doctrine isn't as important as loving others. (False - 1 Timothy 4:16)*
1. *We need the Bible, but we also need modern revelations to guide us. (False - 2 Timothy 3:16-17)*
1. *Good works are the result of salvation, not the cause of it. (True - Ephesians 2:10)*

Chapter 2 - God - Eternal Creator and Loving Father

Activity 1: Name That Attribute (Interactive Group Activity)

Purpose:

Help participants connect God's names and attributes to **practical life applications**.

Instructions:

1. **Prepare Index Cards** - Write **one name or attribute of God** (e.g., Yahweh-Jireh, Faithful, Omnipresent) on each card.
1. **Distribute Cards** - Hand out one card per participant or group.
1. **Group Task:**
 - Read the **name or attribute** and the accompanying **scripture reference** from the chapter.
 - Discuss: *How does this name or attribute apply to a personal or biblical situation?*
 - Prepare a **1-minute summary** to share with the group.
1. **Wrap-Up** - Have each participant or group **present their reflections**, emphasizing the practical ways God's character applies to real-life struggles or victories.

Activity 2: God's Names in Prayer (Reflection and Application)

Purpose:

Teach participants how to incorporate God's names and attributes into **personal prayer**.

Instructions:

1. **Set Up Reflection Time** - Provide a **quiet space** for participants to meditate on one of God's names from the chapter.
1. **Guided Prayer Exercise:**
 - Step 1: Choose a **name or attribute** that speaks to a current need (e.g., **Jehovah-Rapha** for healing).
 - Step 2: Write a short **prayer** using that name, praising God, and asking for Him to act in alignment with His character.
 - Step 3: Share prayers (optional) in small groups or pairs to **encourage and build faith**.
1. **Close with Group Prayer** - Thank God for revealing Himself through His names and attributes.

Activity 3: Encountering God's Attributes (15-20 Minutes)

Purpose:

Help participants **reflect on and apply** God's attributes to their lives through **personal stories** and **group prayer**.

Instructions:

1. Divide into Groups of 3-4 People.

1. Attribute Focus:

- Provide each group with a **list of 3-4 attributes** of God (e.g., **Faithful, Merciful, Sovereign, Provider**) drawn from the chapter.
- Ask each group to **choose one attribute** they feel resonates most with their current season of life.

1. Story Sharing (10 Minutes):

- Each participant briefly **shares a story** (personal experience or observation) that connects to the chosen attribute.
- Example Prompts:
 - *"When did you experience God as your Provider?"*
 - *"How has God's mercy shaped your life?"*

1. Group Application (5-10 Minutes):

- Ask the group: *"How can we encourage each other to rely on this aspect of God in daily life?"*
- Have the group **write a short prayer** reflecting the attribute and pray together, focusing on applying God's character in their situations.

Chapter 3 - Sin and Redemption

Activity 1: The Ripple Effect of Sin (Discussion and Application)

Purpose:

Illustrate how sin's **effects ripple outward**, impacting **relationships, communities, and spiritual lives**, while emphasizing God's **redemptive plan**.

Instructions:

1. Opening Illustration (5 Minutes):

- Drop a **stone into a bowl of water** (or describe the image if materials aren't available).
- Ask participants to **observe the ripples** spreading outward and discuss:
"How does this visual illustrate the impact of sin in our lives and relationships?"

1. Small Group Discussion (10 Minutes):

- Divide into groups and assign each one a **biblical example of sin**:
- **Adam and Eve** - Genesis 3:6-13 (Shame and separation).
- **Cain and Abel** - Genesis 4:3-12 (Jealousy, murder, and exile).
- **David and Bathsheba** - 2SA 11:2-27 (Adultery and consequences).
- Discuss:
- *What were the immediate and long-term effects of this sin?*
- *How do we see God's grace and opportunity for restoration in each story?*

1. Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Bring the groups back together and ask:
- *What are some "ripples" of sin you've experienced personally?*
- *How has God's grace been at work to stop those ripples and bring healing?*

Activity 2: Sin and Restoration Timeline (Scripture Walkthrough)

Purpose:

Trace God's **redemptive plan** from **Genesis to Christ**, focusing on His **grace** amid **judgment**.

Instructions:

1. **Divide into Small Groups** - Assign each group a **passage of Scripture** highlighting sin and restoration:

- **Genesis 3:21** - God provides coverings for Adam and Eve.
- **Genesis 4:6-7** - God warns Cain before his sin.
- **Exodus 12:13** - The Passover lamb protects Israel.
- **LEV 16:21-22** - The scapegoat bears sin away.
- **John 1:29** - Jesus, the Lamb of God, takes away sin.

1. **Group Task:**

- Discuss the **sin or judgment** in the passage.
- Highlight the **grace or redemption** offered.
- Summarize the **lesson learned** about God's character.

1. **Presentation:**

- Have each group share their insights, tying the passages together into a **timeline of God's plan** for redemption.

Activity 3: Walking in Forgiveness (Prayerful Application)

Purpose:

Lead participants to **personally process forgiveness**-both **receiving it** and **extending it** to others.

Instructions:

1. Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Ask participants to **quietly reflect** on areas where they may:
- Need to **confess sin** and seek God's forgiveness.
- Need to **forgive someone else** who has wronged them.

1. Guided Prayer Time (10 Minutes):

- Read **1 John 1:9**
- Lead participants in private prayer. The facilitator need not hear the conversation between the person and God.
- Confess sins to God.
- Pray for strength to forgive others.
- Encourage writing down any **commitments** (e.g., forgiving someone, seeking reconciliation).

1. Closing Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Read **Psalms 103:12**
- Invite participants to share (optional) **how forgiveness brings freedom and restoration**.

Chapter 4 - Jesus-The Messiah

Activity 1: Names and Titles of Jesus (Reflection and Scripture Study)

Purpose:

Explore the **names and titles of Jesus** and how they reveal His mission as the Messiah.

Instructions:

1. **Divide into Small Groups.** Assign each group one of the following titles for Jesus:

- **Emmanuel** (Matthew 1:23) - *God with us.*
- **Lamb of God** (John 1:29) - *Sacrifice for sin.*
- **King of Kings** (Revelation 19:16) - *Supreme authority.*
- **High Priest** (Hebrews 4:14-16) - *Mediator between God and man.*
- **The Word** (John 1:1) - *The revelation of God.*

1. **Group Task:**

- Look up the Scripture associated with the title.
- Discuss what the title reveals about Jesus' mission.
- Share **one takeaway** about how this title applies to their personal faith.

1. **Wrap-Up:**

- Each group shares their reflections, emphasizing how Jesus' identity fulfills His mission as Messiah.

Activity 2: Jesus' Mission Fulfilled (Timeline and Discussion)

Purpose:

Trace key moments in Jesus' mission to **connect prophecy with fulfillment.**

Instructions:

1. **Break into Groups.** Assign each group a **prophecy** and its **fulfillment**:

- **Born of a Virgin:** Isaiah 7:14 >> Matthew 1:22-23.
- **Healing the Brokenhearted:** Isaiah 61:1-2 >> Luke 4:18-19.
- **A Suffering Servant:** Isaiah 53:4-7 >> Matthew 27:26-31.
- **Resurrection Victory:** Psalms 16:10 >> Acts 2:31.

1. **Group Task:**

- Discuss: How does this prophecy demonstrate God's plan?
- Reflect: What does this fulfillment mean for us today?

1. **Share Insights:** Each group presents their prophecy and fulfillment to the class, closing with a short prayer of gratitude for Jesus' faithfulness.

Activity 3: The Messiah's Anointing in Our Lives (Practical Application)

Purpose:

Apply Jesus' anointing as **Prophet, Priest, and King** to daily life and **personal ministry**.

Instructions:

1. Small Group Discussion:

- **Prophet:** How can we declare God's truth and point others to Christ like Jesus did?
- **Priest:** How can we intercede for others and show mercy?
- **King:** How can we serve with authority while remaining humble?

1. Application Task:

- Have each person **write one action step** they can take this week to reflect one of Jesus' roles (e.g., **speak truth**, **pray for someone**, or **lead with humility**).

1. Wrap-Up Reflection:

- Close with a time of **prayer**, asking for **God's anointing** to walk in these roles as ambassadors for Christ.

Chapter 5 - Repentance from Dead Works

Activity 1: Identifying Dead Works (Self-Reflection and Group Discussion)

Purpose:

Help participants identify and address "dead works" in their lives while replacing them with Spirit-led actions.

Instructions:

1. Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Provide participants with a **list of potential dead works** (see below).
- Ask them to reflect silently and identify **one or two areas** where they see evidence of dead works in their own lives.

1. List of Potential Dead Works:

• **Religious Rituals Without Faith:**

- Attending church services out of habit but without engaging the heart.
- Performing religious acts to earn approval rather than out of love for God.

• **Self-Reliance:**

- Trying to achieve righteousness through personal effort rather than depending on God's grace.
- Focusing on good works to gain favor, ignoring the role of the Holy Spirit.

• **Sinful Patterns or Behaviors:**

- Holding onto grudges or unforgiveness.
- Allowing pride, envy, or bitterness to dominate relationships.

• **Complacency:**

- Neglecting spiritual disciplines like prayer, Bible study, or worship.
- Settling into spiritual apathy, losing passion for Christ.

• **Unfruitful Habits:**

- Spending excessive time on distractions or hobbies that do not glorify God.
- Pursuing selfish ambitions at the expense of serving others.

• **Works Driven by Fear or Guilt:**

- Serving others out of obligation rather than love.
- Giving financially or volunteering to check a box rather than out of joyful obedience.

• **Misplaced Priorities:**

- Focusing on material success over spiritual growth.
- Investing time and energy in worldly pursuits with no eternal value.

1. **Group Discussion (10 Minutes):**

- Divide participants into small groups to share (if comfortable) one area they identified as a dead work.
- Discuss practical steps to **replace dead works** with Spirit-filled actions.

1. **Wrap-Up Reflection (5 Minutes):**

- Invite participants to share key takeaways or steps they will take to address dead works.
- Close with prayer for God's guidance in leading a life of fruitfulness.

Activity 2: The Path of Repentance (Interactive Visual and Discussion)

Purpose:

Guide participants in understanding the steps of repentance and how they lead to transformation.

Instructions:

1. **Create a Visual Pathway:**

- Draw or display a path with the following steps: *Conviction >> Godly Sorrow >> Confession >> Turning Away >> Transformation.*

1. **Interactive Group Exercise:**

- Assign groups to discuss each step on the pathway:
- *What does this step look like in practice?*
- *What are the barriers to this step, and how can we overcome them?*

1. **Reflection and Sharing:**

- Have each group share their insights on one step of the path.
- Conclude with how repentance leads to spiritual growth and alignment with God's will.

Activity 3: Learning from David (Bible Study and Personal Prayer)

Purpose:

Draw lessons from David's repentance to inspire participants to embrace a life of humility and restoration.

Instructions:

1. Read Psalm 51 Together (10 Minutes):

- Reflect on David's heartfelt plea for forgiveness, focusing on verses like Psalms 51:10-12.

1. Group Discussion (10 Minutes):

- Ask: *What stands out to you about David's repentance?*
- Discuss: *How can we model this level of transparency and humility in our own lives?*

1. Personal Application:

- Encourage participants to write a personal prayer of repentance, inspired by David's words.

1. Wrap-Up:

- Close with a prayer asking God to help participants cultivate a steadfast spirit and a heart fully surrendered to Him.

Chapter 6 - Faith Toward God

Activity 1: Hearing God's Word (Scripture Exploration and Reflection)

Purpose:

Help participants understand how **faith comes by hearing** and recognize moments when God's word becomes personal and alive.

Instructions:

1. Scripture Reading (5 Minutes):

- Read Romans 10:17 (*“So then faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the word of God”*) and Isaiah 55:11 (*“So is My word that goes out from My mouth; it will not return to Me empty.”*).

1. Personal Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Have participants silently reflect on a time when Scripture impacted them personally.
- Prompt: *“What passage of Scripture has become a rhema word in your life? How did it guide or strengthen your faith?”*

1. Group Sharing (10 Minutes):

- Invite participants to share their reflections in small groups or as a whole class.
- Discuss: *“What steps can we take to position ourselves to hear God’s voice more clearly?”*

Activity 2: Faith Produces Obedience (Practical Application)

Purpose:

Illustrate the connection between **faith and obedience** and encourage participants to take bold steps of faith.

Instructions:

1. Discussion (5 Minutes):

- Read James 2:17 (*“Faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead.”*).
- Discuss: *“Why does faith naturally lead to obedience? How does obedience strengthen faith?”*

1. Action Plan (10 Minutes):

- Ask participants to identify **one area** where God is calling them to obedience.
- Example Prompts:
 - *“Is God asking you to forgive someone?”*
 - *“Is He prompting you to serve in a ministry or reach out to someone in need?”*

1. Commitment (5 Minutes):

- Have participants write down one actionable step they will take this week in obedience to God’s leading.

Activity 3: Building Faith Through Discipline (*Group Exercise*)

Purpose:

Encourage participants to implement practical disciplines that cultivate faith and deepen trust in God.

Instructions:

1. Brainstorming (5 Minutes):

- In small groups, discuss how the following disciplines help grow faith:
- **Prayer:** Talking to God and listening for His voice.
- **Bible Study:** Meditating on and applying Scripture.
- **Fellowship:** Sharing life and encouragement with other believers.

1. Group Sharing (10 Minutes):

- Each group shares one **practical tip** for each discipline, focusing on how to make it a consistent practice.

1. Commitment (5 Minutes):

- Ask participants to choose **one discipline** to focus on this week and write down a specific plan for implementing it.
- Example: *"I will spend 15 minutes each morning reading and reflecting on a passage from the Gospels."*

Chapter 7 - Jesus-The Foundation of Our Faith

Activity 1: Exploring the Roles of Jesus (Group Study and Application)

Purpose:

*Deepen understanding of Jesus as **Prophet, Priest, and King** and how these roles influence our faith and daily lives.*

Instructions:

1. **Divide into Small Groups:** Assign each group one role of Jesus (Prophet, Priest, or King).

1. **Scripture Study:**

- **Prophet:** Read Deuteronomy 18:15-19 and Matthew 21:11.
- **Priest:** Read Hebrews 4:14-16 and 10:11-14.
- **King:** Read Psalms 2:6-8 and Revelation 19:16.

1. **Group Task:**

- *Discuss:* What does this role reveal about Jesus' mission and character?
- *Reflect:* How does this role apply to your life today?

1. **Wrap-Up Sharing:** Each group presents their role and insights to the whole group.

Activity 2: The Names of Jesus (Reflection and Worship Exercise)

Purpose:

Help participants connect with the **character and mission of Jesus** through His names and titles.

Instructions:

1. **Using the list of names from the chapter:**

1. **Individual Reflection (5 Minutes):**

- Ask participants to choose one name that resonates most with them and reflect on how it relates to their current walk with God.

1. **Group Sharing (10 Minutes):**

- Have each person briefly share their chosen name and why it is meaningful.

1. **Closing Prayer (5 Minutes):**

- Pray together, thanking God for the many facets of Jesus' character revealed through His names.

Activity 3: The Mediator of the New Covenant (Scripture Study and Application)

Purpose:

*Explore how Jesus' role as the **Mediator of the New Covenant** brings salvation and transforms our relationship with God.*

Instructions:

1. Read Hebrews 9:15 and 1 Timothy 2:5-6 Together (10 Minutes):

- *Reflect on Jesus' role as the Mediator who bridges the gap between humanity and God.*

1. Discussion (10 Minutes):

- *Why is Jesus uniquely qualified to be the Mediator of the New Covenant?*
- *How does His mediating work bring us closer to God?*

1. Personal Application (5 Minutes):

- *Encourage participants to write down one area in their lives where they need to rely on Jesus as their Mediator-whether for forgiveness, guidance, or restoration.*

Chapter 8 - Holy Spirit-Comforter, Guide, and Power

Activity 1: Talking with God

Purpose:

Teach participants how to talk with God.

Instructions:

1. Review & Teach (5 Minutes):

- Based on the material in the chapter, starting with the section: “Building a relationship with the Holy Spirit” & the included appendix “Hearing the Voice of God”.

1. Guided Prayer Time (15 Minutes):

- *Lead the group in a time of prayer:*
- *Ask God to Speak to them, to reveal Himself to them.*
- *Help them listen and speak aloud (privately) what they sense God is speaking.*

Activity 2: Recognizing the Spirit’s Voice (Reflection and Sharing)

Purpose:

Help participants reflect on how they have experienced the Holy Spirit’s guidance and learn to recognize His voice more clearly, perhaps based on Activity 1.

Instructions:

1. Personal Reflection (5 Minutes):

- *Ask participants to think about a time when they felt led, guided, or comforted by the Holy Spirit.*
- *Prompt: “What was the situation? How did you know it was the Holy Spirit speaking to you?” “What did it make you feel?”*

1. Group Sharing (10 Minutes):

- *Divide into small groups and share reflections.*

Chapter 9 - The Church and Our Role in It

Activity 1: Exploring Biblical Images of the Church (Reflection and Sharing)

Purpose:

Help participants understand and connect with the diverse biblical images of the church.

Instructions:

1. **Divide into Small Groups:** Assign each group one biblical image of the church (e.g., Body, Bride, Temple, Flock, Family).

1. **Group Study:**

- Read the Scripture associated with the image.
- Discuss: *“What does this image reveal about the church’s purpose and character? How can we live out this aspect of the church in our community?”*

1. **Sharing Insights:** Each group presents their findings to the whole group.

Activity 2: Helping others find their Role in the Church (Practical Exploration)

Purpose:

Encourage participants to identify their unique role in the Body of Christ.

Instructions:

1. **Self-Reflection (5 Minutes):**

- Using the list of gifts from the chapter: Prophecy, Service, Teaching, Exhortation, Giving, Leadership, Mercy
- Ask participants to reflect: *“Which gifts or talents has God given me? Where do I feel most effective or joyful in serving?” “What gifts and talents do I see in the people here with me?”*

1. **Group Discussion (10 Minutes):**

- Split into small groups.
- Taking turns: *“Share with each other the gifts and talents you see them developing and operating in. For the person receiving, how does this resonate with you?”*

1. **Action Plan (5 Minutes):**

- Encourage participants to write down the gifts they talked about and one way they will use their gift to serve in the coming week.

Activity 3: The Church's Mission in Action (Brainstorming and Application)

Purpose:

Inspire participants to engage in the church's upward, inward, and outward mission.

Instructions:

1. **Divide into Three Teams:** Assign each team one dimension of the church's mission:

- **Upward:** Worship and glorifying God.
- **Inward:** Building up the body of Christ.
- **Outward:** Reaching the world with the Gospel.

1. **Team Brainstorm (10 Minutes):**

- Each team discusses practical ways to live out their assigned mission within the church and community.
- Examples: Hosting a worship night (upward), organizing a small group (inward), volunteering at a community outreach event (outward).

1. **Group Sharing (10 Minutes):**

- Each team shares their ideas, focusing on how they can inspire the broader group to act.

Chapter 10 - Sanctified-Set Apart for God's Purpose

Activity 1: Trusting the Process of Sanctification (Encouragement and Prayer)

Purpose:

Reassure participants that sanctification is a lifelong journey and encourage them to trust God's timing and work.

Instructions:

1. Scripture Reading (5 Minutes):

- Read Philippians 1:6 (*“He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus.”*).

1. Group Discussion (10 Minutes):

- Ask: *“How does this verse encourage us when sanctification feels slow?”*
- Discuss: *“What practical ways can we remind ourselves to trust God in this process?”*

1. Prayer Circle (5 Minutes):

- Close by praying for one another, specifically asking for patience, trust, and joy in the journey of sanctification.

Activity 2: Removing Negative Habits (Reflection and Trigger Awareness)

Purpose:

Help participants identify negative habits that hinder sanctification and learn to recognize the triggers and cues that lead to those behaviors.

Instructions:

1. Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Provide a worksheet with these prompts:
- “*What habit or behavior is hindering your spiritual growth?*”
- “*What situations, emotions, or thoughts usually lead to this habit?*” (trigger/queue identification).
- Example triggers to consider: stress, boredom, peer pressure, time of day, or specific locations.

1. Negative Habit Examples List:

- **Complaining or gossiping** - Speaking negatively about others instead of offering grace.
- **Reacting in anger or impatience** - Quick tempers or unkind responses in stressful situations.
- **Overuse of social media or entertainment** - Spending excessive time on distractions that prevent meaningful spiritual growth.
- **Avoiding difficult conversations** - Not addressing conflicts in relationships, leading to unresolved tension.
- **Procrastination or laziness** - Delaying responsibilities or neglecting purposeful tasks.
- **Holding onto grudges or bitterness** - Allowing unforgiveness to take root in your heart.
- **Overindulging in food, shopping, or other comforts** - Turning to these for coping instead of seeking God’s peace.
- **Dwelling on negative thoughts** - Allowing worry, fear, or envy to dominate your mindset.

1. Group Discussion (10 Minutes):

- Divide into small groups. Each participant shares one habit they want to remove and its triggers (if comfortable).
- Discuss: “*What can you do to interrupt or avoid these triggers?*” (e.g., pause and pray, change your environment, seek accountability).

1. Wrap-Up (5 Minutes):

- Encourage participants to commit to replacing the negative habit with a positive one (see Activity 2).
- Pray for God's guidance and strength in identifying and breaking these habits.

Activity 3: Establishing Positive Habits (Building New Patterns and Rewards)

Purpose:

Guide participants in creating positive habits that align with their sanctification journey by emphasizing consistent actions and their spiritual rewards.

Instructions:

1. Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Ask participants to think about areas where they can grow spiritually and consider habits they could implement.
- Prompt: *“What habit can I add to strengthen my walk with God or reflect His character in my daily life?”*

1. Positive Habit Examples List:

- **Daily prayer** - Setting aside time to connect with God at the start or end of your day.
- **Bible reading or study** - Establishing a regular time to read, meditate, and apply Scripture.
- **Gratitude journaling** - Writing down three things you’re thankful for each day to shift your focus.
- **Serving others** - Finding small, regular ways to help or encourage someone in need.
- **Speaking words of affirmation** - Intentionally encouraging a family member, friend, or coworker.
- **Scripture memorization** - Learning one verse a week to meditate on God’s truth.
- **Practicing silence or solitude** - Taking a few minutes daily to sit quietly and listen for God’s voice.
- **Engaging in fellowship** - Regularly attending a small group or church to build connections and accountability.

1. Building the Habit (10 Minutes):

- Guide participants to break the habit into three components:
- **Action:** Define the habit clearly (e.g., *“Spend 5 minutes in prayer every morning before breakfast.”*).
- **Cues:** Identify what will remind them to practice the habit (e.g., time of day, placing a Bible on their nightstand).
- **Rewards:** Reflect on the spiritual rewards of consistency (e.g., *“This will give me peace and help me trust God more deeply.”*).

1. Group Sharing (5 Minutes):

- In pairs or small groups, participants share the habit they want to establish and their plan for implementation.

1. Closing:

- Encourage participants to write down their new habit and share it with an accountability partner to encourage follow-through.

Chapter 11 - Baptisms-Water and Spirit

Activity 1: Exploring Baptismal Significance (Reflection and Sharing)

Purpose:

Help participants reflect on the theological and personal significance of baptism in their spiritual journey.

Instructions:

1. Scripture Study (5 Minutes):

- Read Romans 6:3-4 and Acts 19:1-6.
- Ask: *“How do these passages deepen your understanding of water baptism and Spirit baptism?”*

1. Group Reflection (10 Minutes):

- In pairs or small groups, discuss:
- *“What does baptism mean to you personally?”*
- *“How has your experience of baptism shaped your relationship with Christ?”*

1. Prayer and Encouragement (5 Minutes):

- Pray together for a renewed understanding of baptism and the courage to take steps of obedience in faith.

Activity 2: Seeking the Spirit's Empowerment (Prayer and Application)

Purpose:

Encourage participants to seek the baptism of the Holy Spirit and understand its role in their lives.

Instructions:

1. Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Provide prompts:
- *“What areas of your life or ministry would benefit from the Holy Spirit’s power?”*
- *“What holds you back from fully seeking His empowerment?”*

1. Group Prayer (10 Minutes):

- Lead a time of prayer for those who desire the baptism in the Holy Spirit.
- Encourage participants to pray with expectancy, using Acts 1:8 and Luke 11:13 as their foundation.

1. Closing Encouragement (5 Minutes):

- Share testimonies of how the Spirit’s empowerment has made a difference in the lives of believers.

Activity 3: Symbolism of Baptism (Interactive and Creative Exercise)

Purpose:

Help participants explore the rich symbolism of baptism and connect it to their personal faith journey.

Instructions:

1. Scripture Exploration (5 Minutes):

- Read Romans 6:3-4 (*“We were therefore buried with Him through baptism into death in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, we too may live a new life.”*).
- Discuss: *“What do the elements of baptism-water, immersion, rising-symbolize for believers?”*

1. Symbolism Exercise (10 Minutes):

- Provide participants with a list of baptismal symbols and their meanings:

1. ****Water**** - Cleansing and purification; washing away sin and renewal of life.
2. ****Immersion**** - Death and burial; dying to the old self and sinful nature.
3. ****Rising from Water**** - Resurrection and new life; union with Christ's resurrection.
4. ****Clothing**** - Being clothed with Christ, righteousness, and new identity.
5. ****Light**** - Illumination and guidance; walking in Christ's light.
6. ****Seal**** - Ownership and belonging; marked by the Holy Spirit in God's covenant family.
7. ****Oil**** - Anointing and empowerment; being set apart for God's purposes.
8. ****Dove**** - Presence of the Holy Spirit; peace, purity, and empowerment for ministry.
9. ****Cross**** - Union with Christ's sacrifice; surrender to God's will and daily commitment.

10. ****Community**** - Inclusion in the Body of Christ; fellowship, accountability, and shared mission.

- Ask participants to reflect on which symbol resonates most with their spiritual journey and why.
- Optional: Provide index cards or sheets for them to write a brief statement about how baptism has impacted their faith.

1. Group Sharing (5 Minutes):

- Have participants share their reflections in small groups or pairs. Encourage them to discuss how they can carry the symbolism of baptism into their daily lives.

1. Creative Option:

- If time allows, invite participants to create a visual representation (drawing, word cloud, or simple sketch) of what baptism means to them based on the symbols discussed.

Chapter 12 - Discipleship

Activity 1: Identifying Your Circle of Influence (Reflection and Sharing)

Purpose:

Help participants recognize the people God has placed in their lives to disciple and inspire them to act.

Instructions:

1. Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Individually: On a piece of paper, draw three concentric circles labeled:
- **Inner Circle:** Close family and friends.
- **Middle Circle:** Church or community members.
- **Outer Circle:** Acquaintances, coworkers, or neighbors.
- Ask participants to write down names of people they interact with regularly.

1. Group Sharing (10 Minutes):

- In pairs, share one name from each circle and brainstorm ways to engage those individuals in meaningful spiritual conversations.

1. Commitment and Prayer (5 Minutes):

- Have participants commit to one action step for one person this week (e.g., inviting them to coffee, starting a Bible study, or offering to pray for them).
- Close in prayer for boldness and wisdom.

Activity 2: Characteristics of a Disciple-Maker (Interactive Brainstorming)

Purpose:

Encourage participants to reflect on the qualities that make an effective disciple-maker and identify areas for personal growth.

Instructions:

1. Brainstorming (5 Minutes):

- Write the following qualities on a whiteboard or handout:
- Patience, humility, relational focus, intentionality, faithfulness, and boldness.
- Ask participants to add other traits they believe are important.

1. Self-Reflection (5 Minutes):

- Ask participants to select one or two traits they currently exhibit and one they'd like to grow in.

1. Group Sharing and Encouragement (10 Minutes):

- In small groups, share their selections and discuss how these traits can be developed through prayer, practice, and accountability.

Activity 3: Creating a Discipleship Plan (Practical Application)

Purpose:

Equip participants to develop a simple, actionable plan for discipling someone in their lives.

Instructions:

1. Plan Template: Provide a worksheet with the following prompts:

- **Who?** Name the person you feel led to disciple.
- **How?** Identify one way to connect with them this week (e.g., invite to lunch, discuss a spiritual topic).
- **What?** Decide on a tool or topic to guide your time together (e.g., a question to ask, a book of the Bible, prayer, or addressing life challenges). This doesn't need to be overly formulaic, let it flow naturally from your relationship with them!

1. Group Sharing (10 Minutes):

- Share plans with a partner for encouragement and accountability.

1. Prayer for Action (5 Minutes):

- Pray as a group for courage and guidance in implementing their plans.

Chapter 13 - Spiritual Authority

Activity 1: Recognizing Spiritual Authority in Scripture (Bible Study Exercise)

Purpose:

Help participants identify examples of spiritual authority in the Bible and reflect on how they apply to their lives.

Instructions:

1. Group Study:

- Divide into small groups and assign each group a passage that demonstrates spiritual authority. Use the expanded list below for more variety.

1. Expanded List of Scriptures (Examples of Jesus or His Disciples Using Authority):

• Jesus:

- Calming the storm: *Mark 4:35-41*.
- Casting out a demon in the synagogue: *Mark 1:21-28*.
- Healing the centurion's servant: *Matthew 8:5-13*.
- Raising Lazarus from the dead: *John 11:38-44*.
- Feeding the 5,000: *Matthew 14:13-21*.

• The Disciples:

- Healing a lame man: *Acts 3:1-10*.
- Casting out a spirit in Philippi: *Acts 16:16-18*.
- Paul's declaration over Elymas the sorcerer: *Acts 13:8-12*.
- Peter raising Tabitha (Dorcas) from the dead: *Acts 9:36-42*.
- Paul surviving a snake bite: *Acts 28:3-6*.

1. Discussion:

- Ask each group to discuss:
 - “*What does this story teach us about spiritual authority?*”
 - “*How can we apply this example in our lives today?*”

1. Sharing:

- Each group presents their findings to the larger group.

Activity 2: Understanding Your Sphere of Authority (Reflection and Sharing)

Purpose:

Encourage participants to recognize their God-given areas of influence and authority.

Instructions:

1. Reflection:

- Individually on a piece of paper, answer these prompts:
- *“What areas of influence has God entrusted to me (e.g., family, work, church, community)?”*
- *“How can I use spiritual authority to bring God’s kingdom into these areas?”*

1. Group Discussion:

- Share insights in pairs or small groups.

1. Prayer:

- Close with a group prayer commissioning participants to walk confidently in their areas of authority.

Activity 3: Understanding the Role of Angels in Spiritual Authority (Thematic Bible Study)

Purpose: Deepen participants’ understanding of angels as part of God’s kingdom and their role in spiritual authority.

Instructions:

1. Scripture Study:

- Assign passages about angels. Use the expanded list below for a deeper exploration.

1. Expanded List of Angel Scriptures:

• Angels Protecting and Guiding:

- Guarding believers: *Psalms 91:11-12*.
- Protecting Elisha and his servant: *2KI 6:15-17*.
- Guiding Philip to the Ethiopian eunuch: *Acts 8:26*.

• Angels in Spiritual Warfare:

- Delivering Daniel from the lions: *DAN 6:22*.
- Angelic warfare in response to prayer: *DAN 10:12-14*.
- Fighting on behalf of Israel: *Exodus 23:20-22*.

• Angels as Messengers:

- Announcing Jesus' birth: *Luke 1:26-38*.
- Guiding Joseph: *Matthew 1:20-24*.
- Delivering the apostles from prison: *Acts 5:19-20*.

1. Discussion Questions:

- “What roles do angels play in carrying out God’s purposes?”
- “How does this knowledge encourage us to trust God in spiritual warfare?”

1. Reflection:

- Discuss how angels’ actions align with believers’ exercise of spiritual authority.

Chapter 14 - Keep Watch

Activity 1: Eternal Perspective (Interactive Brainstorming)

Purpose:

Help participants focus on eternity and align their lives with eternal priorities.

Instructions:

1. Brainstorming (5 Minutes):

- Write “Temporary” and “Eternal” on a whiteboard or large paper.
- Ask participants to list things in life that fall into each category.

1. Group Discussion (10 Minutes):

- Discuss:
- *“How can we invest more of our time, energy, and resources in eternal things?”*
- *“What are some practical ways to live with an eternal perspective?”*

1. Prayer and Commitment (5 Minutes):

- Close with a group prayer, asking God to help everyone focus on what matters most and live in readiness for His return.

Activity 2: The Parable of the Ten Virgins (Bible Study and Reflection)

Purpose:

Dive deeper into the parable of the ten virgins to explore spiritual preparedness.

Instructions:

1. Scripture Reading (5 Minutes):

- Read Matthew 25:1-13 aloud as a group.

1. Discussion (10 Minutes):

- Ask these questions:
- *“What does the oil symbolize in this parable?”*
- *“What does it mean to be wise versus foolish in preparing for Christ’s return?”*
- *“How can we ensure our lamps are full?”*

1. Application (5 Minutes):

- Encourage participants to write down one area in their spiritual life (e.g., prayer, Scripture study, serving others) where they want to “refill their lamp.”
- Pray as a group for the Holy Spirit’s guidance and empowerment.

Hearing The Voice of God

The following guest appendix by Rev. Larry Low (www.LarryLow.com) complements our exploration of the Holy Spirit’s role, offering practical insights on hearing God’s voice. The following guest contribution is used with permission.

During prayer one morning, I asked **God** the following question: “What is the most important thing I could teach your people for the times that are heading our way?” And He answered me very quickly, and I sensed it was very urgent when He said: **“Teach them to hear My voice.”**

When the Lord gives me a direction like that, I always pick up a pad and pencil and begin to write what little I know, or what I think I know, and the Scriptures that support it. I love doing Word studies on topics the Lord is leading me to teach. I love the anointing for preaching, but I really love to teach the Word. It is an adventure finding things that have always been there but have been overlooked.

David must have longed to uncover God’s Truths, for He prayed in verse 18 of Psalm 119: “Open my eyes that I may see Wondrous things from Your law.”

That’s what I want to see-Wondrous things from His Word.

As I was studying and preparing to teach the second message on hearing and discerning God's voice, He spoke to my heart the following:

*"Teach them to hear My voice,
Teach them to honor and obey.*

*Yes, Teach them to hear My voice and I will always lead them away:
Away from troubles that would destroy them,*

*Away from the trials that they are in,
Away to a place of peace, love, and joy that few have ever been in.*

*Away to a place of refreshing,
to a place of Divine ecstasy.*

*Oh yes, teach them to hear My voice son
and these people will forever be free."*

05/27/00 9:10 A.M.

The following eleven points should help you understand how the Lord will communicate with you:

1. Hearing God's voice is NOT an audible sound but a KNOWING in your heart.

There was one time when His Word came so clear and bold that it could have been audible. I answered Him by speaking out, it was so real. However, there was no one there but the Lord and I, so I can't really say for sure if He spoke to me like we speak to each other.

There was the time when Jesus was being baptized in the river Jordan and the Father spoke: "This is My Son, in whom I am well pleased," but even some of those there said it sounded like thunder, so I guess He could have spoken audibly to me, but for now, I want you to understand that when I say God spoke to me, it is a KNOWING in my heart more than a sound in my ear.

1. The KNOWING is NOT built by logic within your mind; however, it is a complete thought or understanding.

I have never had the Lord speak anything to me that confused me. I have never had Him speak anything to me that left me wondering 'why.' It is always a KNOWING with complete UNDERSTANDING. God is not the author of confusion (1 Corinthians 14:33).

1. When He speaks, He speaks in complete thoughts.

He never leaves us to fill in the blanks. In the twinkling of an eye, God can fill your heart with enough information to keep you preaching a lifetime. One touch

from God can fill you with fire that will keep you burning eternally. He is a complete communicator.

1. When God speaks to us, He NEVER DRIVES. He leads.

He is not a task master; He is a Shepherd. Herdsmen drive, but Shepherds lead. Jesus is the Great Shepherd of the sheep, and we are the sheep of His pasture.

1. When He speaks to His children, He NEVER CONVICTS; He CONVINCES.

His children are those who have been Born Again (John 3:3, 5) by their confession of faith in **Jesus'** shed blood and His work on Calvary. Who wants to listen to someone who always convicts us of our wrong? I believe most of the children of **God** are afraid to hear **God** speak to them because they have been told that **God** will convict them for this or that. Look at 1 John 3:19-20. Who does it say convicts us or condemns us? It's OUR SPIRIT or heart that condemns the child of **God**, but it is **God the Holy Spirit** that knows all things and is GREATER than our hearts. He is there to be our Comforter. Read the following Scriptures, and it will help you understand that the only ones the Holy Spirit convicts are the sinners. Romans 8:33-34 teaches us that NOTHING can come between us and **God's** love. John 14:16, 26 teaches us that the Holy Spirit is our Comforter, not our convict-or, our Counselor, not our chastiser, our Intercessor and Helper, not our hinderer. Read also Acts 9:31 and 15:28 as examples of how the Holy Spirit (**God's** voice) aids, comforts, and strengthens us.

1. The voice of God can be tested so you can KNOW it is God and not your thoughts or the voice of familiar spirits.

1 John 4:1-3 instructs us to "test every spirit" so we can be sure it is from God. When you think you are hearing from God, you have the right and the responsibility to ask that voice a question (That is testing or proving the spirit.) The question to ask is: "Did Jesus Christ come in the flesh?" The one thing that familiar spirits will never admit is that Jesus came to the earth in the flesh. He was all man and all God. No false spirit or religion will admit Jesus came to this earth in the flesh and redeemed mankind from all their sin for eternity. Test the voice you hear. You must also know that God will never lead you outside His written Word, the Bible. If you are hearing something that cannot be backed up in the Bible, you are not hearing from God. Get rid of it! Test the voice you hear to see if it is from God.

1. The voice of God always brings Glory to Jesus Christ.

The Holy Spirit is the Voice of Heaven. He is the one here on earth to work with us, and Jesus said He will always speak only what He hears, and He will ALWAYS bring glory to Jesus (John 16:13-14). He isn't here to bring your ministry glory or your works or the church's programs. All those things are good, and most of them

are necessary to do what we do, but the Holy Spirit will speak and bring Glory to the Person of Jesus. If you are being glorified by the voice you hear, you are not hearing God. There is a difference between being glorified and being encouraged and strengthened. The Holy Spirit will always encourage and strengthen you every time He speaks to you, even when He is correcting (guiding) you with the word. But glory is when you believe YOU are somebody. You are nobody without Jesus-HE IS THE SOMEBODY, not us.

1. God's voice will always REVEAL something to us.

Look at John 16:14. He always takes what belongs to **Jesus** and reveals it to us. The Amplified adds the words: declare, disclose, and transmit when considering the word "reveal." **God** always discloses something to us after He declares it to us, and then by your faith, He transmits it to us. Study also 1 Corinthians 2:10 and 12.

1. The voice of God will always bring peace.

Read John 14:26 and 27, and Colossians 3:14 and 15. His voice never disturbs us. It is a voice that brings perfect peace. Inner peace is because there is a KNOWING which brings us confidence before God, which translates into perfect peace. If the voice you are listening to disturbs you, you are not hearing from God-shut it off. Jesus promised us peace, not as the world gives but as He gives us through the Holy Spirit's comforting words and constant abiding (John 14:27).

1. The voice of God ALWAYS brings TRUTH.

Read John 14:17, 26; 16:13. As a matter of fact, John 16:13 calls the Holy Spirit: "The Spirit of Truth." God cannot lie! He is TRUTH and therefore will only speak TRUTH. I have had people say things like: "I can't believe what I am hearing is from God. It's too good to be true." And maybe it is too good to be true; that's why you MUST test the spirit by lining it up with the Word of God to be sure it is Truth. Some people just can't believe it because what they are hearing is always positive, and they have been taught that God convicts us of error. God will only tell the TRUTH, and it will always be GOOD NEWS. The sad truth is most people only hear bad news from the voice they are listening to and never anticipate hearing good news, so when good news comes, they question it as a possible non-truth. **Truth is always good news!** It's the **truth that** sets us free, so how could **truth** be anything but good news?

1. The voice of **God** always LEADS US FORWARD AND UPWARD.

Read Deut. 28:1-2, Isaiah 30:21, and John 16:13

God never takes you down! He will never run you down; He only builds you up. When God speaks to you, He is speaking from the frame of reference that everything the Word says about you has already been accomplished and ACCEPTED by you. Jeremiah 33:3 says: "Call to Me, and I will answer you, and

show you **GREAT AND MIGHTY** things which you do not know.” Does that sound like running you down or doom and gloom? There is NO doom and gloom in God, therefore He cannot tell you anything doomy or gloomy. You’ll have to tune in to the world’s news agency for doom and gloom.

Jeremiah 29:11 (NKJV)

For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the LORD,
thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope.

Now, if God THINKS good thoughts of peace, a future, and hope toward us, why would He speak otherwise? The answer is, HE WOULDN’T, and HE DOESN’T! He only leads us UPWARD and ONWARD with great hope to provide us an expected future.

I hope this encourages you to “call upon Him” and learn how to **hear His voice**. He has great things to tell you, but He needs your listening ear before all His good things can do you any good.

For more resources on hearing the voice of God, I invite you to visit
www.LarryLow.com

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Author’s Note _

Thank you for reading this book, I hope it has been a useful resource on your journey. To stay connected with me please visit my website at
www.faithprinciples.org

-Andrew